Chasing the Spotlight

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/17926718.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), the whole gang is here p much, Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Chasing the Spotlight

by holymountain

Summary

Adora has been training to be a bodyguard her whole life. Her new client might be the only thing she isn't ready for.

(Or: Catra is the teen pop sensation that's gripping the nation. She just wished her life wasn't so boring.)

A Good Fit

Chapter Notes

Listen to the playlist!

"I assure you, despite her age, Adora is one of our best agents. She's been at the top of her class since she came here."

"From the exam results you've shown me, I can hardly disagree. And we actually see her youth as a plus. Catra has...a bit of a rebellious streak, shall we say. She has a tendency to leave her bodyguards behind. We were hoping she might be more amenable to someone closer to her own age."

Angella nodded. "I'm sure she will like Adora. Her past clients have only had kind things to say about her – I'd be happy to put you in contact with some of them if you so desire."

Ms. Weaver waved her hand. "No need. I will talk to her myself."

"Of course, Ms. Weaver. She's in a sparring session right now, actually; a perfect time for you to see her capabilities."

At the other woman's nod, Angella guided Ms. Weaver through the halls of Brightmoon Security. It was a little unorthodox to bring a prospective client into the training facilities, but since this particular prospective client was the manager of one of the biggest rising stars in the music industry, she was more than willing to make an exception. It was also an exception she'd made before with Adora; the best way to ease a client's concerns about hiring a nineteen year old was to have them watch that nineteen year old overpower trained combatants older and stronger than her.

Faint sounds of exertion grew louder as they rounded a corner and entered the training room. Adora and her opponents looked over briefly; seeing Angella nod, they resumed their fight. The blonde stood across from an aloof woman with blue hair and a

mustachioed man with a glint in his eye. He moved first, darting across the floor with surprising speed to throw a punch at Adora's face. She blocked it with a quick arm movement, and the two exchanged a series of jabs almost too fast to follow. Suddenly, Adora ducked under a punch and carried her momentum forward, sweeping her opponent's left leg and knocking him to the ground. Before she could press her advantage, however, the other combatant shoved her away with force. She stumbled backwards, but stayed on her feet, and the fight continued.

"She's sparring with Mermista and Sea Hawk, two of our more experienced agents," Angella told Ms. Weaver. "They're also available, of course, but they're generally used in more espionage-focused scenarios. They're quite talented performers. As you can see, however, they're no slouches in combat."

Ms. Weaver nodded. It was hard to discern her emotions; she hid her face behind a crimson mask at all times, and no one knew what she looked like beneath it. In fact, her mask and somewhat foreboding aura had become part of the mythos surrounding Catra. Everyone wanted to know more about the mysterious pop star and her sinister manager.

Dodging another blow from Sea Hawk, who had quickly leapt back to his feet, Adora performed a picture perfect butterfly kick, knocking Mermista to the ground. She then closed the distance between herself and Sea Hawk, flipping him over her shoulder onto Mermista.

"Wonderful," said Ms. Weaver. "I am most impressed, Angella."

The president of Brightmoon Security nodded. "I knew you would be." She raised her voice to project to the rest of the room. "Well fought, agents. Adora, come with me."

The blonde cadet helped Mermista and Sea Hawk up, then jogged across the room to join them. If she was taken aback by Ms. Weaver's appearance, she did a good job of hiding it. "What's up,

boss?" she said, accepting a towel from a trainer and wiping sweat off her face.

"Adora, this is—" Angella began, but was quickly cut off by the other woman.

"Adora," Ms. Weaver said, drawing out the syllables. "I am so pleased to meet you."

Adora glanced at Angella. It was rare the older woman allowed even minor disrespect like that; she wasn't nicknamed the Queen of Brightmoon for nothing. Angella shook her head slightly.

"It's, uh, nice to meet you too, Ms., uh…?"

"Ms. Weaver. I hear you're the shining star of this institution."

Adora flushed and scratched the back of her head sheepishly. "I'm flattered, but I wouldn't say that."

"So humble," murmured Ms. Weaver. "Tell me, Adora, what sort of music do you like?"

Adora shrugged, nonplussed. "Uh, rock, I guess? I've been listening to a lot of Led Zeppelin recently."

Ms. Weaver chuckled. "How quaint! Surely you must pay attention to more, ah, recent music though, however?"

Seeing Adora's confused expression, Angella stepped in. "Ms. Weaver is Catra's manager."

Adora's eyes lit up in recognition. "Oh! She's the teen pop star with the tail, right? I've heard a couple of her songs. She's got a nice voice."

"She has a lovely voice. And we want her to continue to use it." At that, Adora looked vaguely alarmed. "Oh, I do not mean to sound so ominous. But when you have as many fans as Catra does, some of them tend to get a little…too enthusiastic. We have had

issues in the past with a couple stalkers – things like that. Nothing someone with your capabilities would not be able to handle, I'm sure."

"Ms. Weaver is looking for a full time bodyguard for her client," said Angella. "I recommended you."

Adora nodded. "Alright. How long would this assignment be for?"

"Indefinite," replied Ms. Weaver. "Her past few bodyguards have had rather…abbreviated stints, I'm afraid. Catra can be rather temperamental sometimes – you know how these teen stars are." Adora did not, but she nodded anyway. "I'm hoping that you will last longer."

"Anything I should know before this – should I meet her or anything?

"No need," dismissed Ms. Weaver. "Catra trusts my judgment."

Angella put a hand on Adora's shoulder. "We'll talk more about the details of this later. For now, go get cleaned up, and start thinking about what you'll need to take with you. Ms. Weaver and I are going to finalize a contract."

Adora saluted. "It was nice to meet you, Ms. Weaver. I look forward to working with you." With that, she jogged off towards the showers.

"What an *adorable* girl," said Ms. Weaver. "I think she will be a very good fit."

…

Placing a stack of folded white undershirts into her duffel bag, Adora did a quick scan of her room to see if she had missed anything. She didn't really have much in the way of personal possessions; since the job often required her to be elsewhere, Brightmoon quarters were generally fairly sparse, and Adora's was no exception. She lived in a double with another agent, Perfuma,

who had left on a weeklong assignment a couple days ago. (Perfuma's side of the room, incidentally, was one of the more decorated places in Brightmoon, sporting a few vibrant tapestries and seven plants – each had a name, and Adora had promised to water them and give them gentle verbal encouragement every night while Perfuma was away.)

Adora was a bit sad she wouldn't get to say goodbye, but that was the nature of the business – she was sure she would see her bubbly friend again at some point. She did have to find someone to water the plants, however.

Just then, three sharp raps rang out from Adora's door. She sprang to her feet, and opened the door to find Angella standing outside.

"Good," her boss said, entering her room briskly. "You're already packed. Ms. Weaver wants you to start tomorrow morning."

"Tomorrow morning?" said Adora.

"Is that a problem?"

"No, I just – this is all happening a little fast, don't you think? I've only been on a couple of assignments before, and they were all event-specific. And now I'm going to be protecting one of the most famous people in the United States?" Adora flopped down onto her bed. "It just feels so sudden."

"I know, Adora," said Angella, a touch of softness in her voice. "But you are capable. I wouldn't have recommended you if I didn't think you could handle it."

"Why did you recommend me, by the way?" asked Adora. "I mean, don't get me wrong, I'm honored. But we have many more experienced bodyguards. And Ms. Weaver said Catra was temperamental. What does that even mean? What if she doesn't like me, or I mess up?"

"Your lack of experience might be a plus, actually. Apparently Catra has had issues getting along with her previous bodyguards. She would sneak out of her room and be halfway across the town before they realized she was missing. Ms. Weaver is hoping that since you're closer to her own age, you'll be a better fit."

"I guess that makes sense." Adora sighed. "I'm just nervous. I've never done anything like this before. And Ms. Weaver gave me some weird vibes."

"You'll be fine," said Angella. She sat down on the bed next to Adora. "Besides, they are paying an exorbitant amount of money."

"So I have to do it?" Adora asked, a small smile on her face.

Angella smiled back. "I wouldn't say that. But I would say that you are…strongly encouraged to take this assignment. For your own sake as well as Brightmoon's. If you make it more than a couple weeks, the commission alone would let you go on a long vacation." The president of Brightmoon rose gracefully. "Meet me in the lobby tomorrow at 0700. And get some rest. It's going to be a big day." She moved to leave, but paused in the doorway. "Is there any business you need to take care of before you leave?"

Adora shrugged. "I need to find someone to water Perfuma's plants."

Angella laughed softly. "I will see to it."

"She would also like if they were gently talked to a couple times a night. Apparently it really helps their growth. Especially George – she's been a little worried about him."

Angella flicked her eyes to the plants, then back to Adora. "I will *water* them," she said.

Adora watched her leave, then turned to the delicate fern on the windowsill. "Sorry, George," she said. "Looks like you're gonna have to persevere until Perfuma comes back."

…

Adora stepped out of the car, placing a hand over her eyes to block the glare reflecting from the glass building in front of her. She'd driven by the Hordak Records building before, but she never fully appreciated how massive it was. Offering a quick salute and a wave to Angella, she stepped into the building.

"Welcome to Hordak Records!" exclaimed the receptionist from behind the desk, a solidly built woman with short, lavender hair.

"Uh, hi!" said Adora. "I'm here to see Ms. Weaver, or…Catra I guess? I'm the new bodyguard."

The receptionist clapped her hands in delight. "Oh, wonderful! They told me the new person was coming by today. I was worried it would be another one of those hulking, no nonsense dudes in suits. Catra doesn't seem to like them very much, and to be honest I don't either. She may be the biggest star this side of the Atlantic, but she's still a teenager, you know! You seem like a nice person though – I bet she'll like you! And that ponytail is just adorable. My name is Scorpia, by the way. How rude of me! What's your name?"

Adora paused, a little taken aback by the deluge of words. "Adora," she said. "It's nice to meet you, Scorpia."

"So polite! Wow, Catra is going to love you! I can already tell. Now, I will need to see some identification – not that I think you're lying, of course, it's just company policy. You understand, don't you? Of course you do, you're a professional!" She took Adora's offered ID and made a couple taps on her keyboard. "Everything matches up!" She reached down beneath her desk and pulled out a lanyard with a Hordak Records ID on it. "This is for you – the elevator and a bunch of doors won't work unless you scan this first."

Adora accepted the lanyard, stringing it around her neck. "Thank you! Shall I go up, then?"

Scorpia beamed at her. “Of course! The top floor is Catra’s penthouse apartment, and I think your room will be there as well. I’m sure she will be happy to show you around – she’s a bundle of fun, that one. Oh, I rhymed! That wasn’t even on purpose. Anyway, I’m sure she’ll like you. Tell her I said hi!”

Adora nodded slowly. “Thank you!” She walked into the elevator, put her card on the scanner (it beeped approvingly), took a deep breath, and pressed the top button.

If she was being honest, Adora was a little nervous about meeting Catra. Despite her fame, no one really knew too much about her. She released her debut album a year ago after signing with Hordak Records, one of the biggest record labels in the country. It became an instant hit, but it was Catra’s countrywide tour that cemented her stardom. Apparently she was an electrifying live performer; Adora had looked up a couple concert videos, and the way Catra flew through the choreography without missing a note of the song was incredible. Then there was the matter of her appearance. Apparently, people went crazy for cat-girls, though there was a lot of online debate over whether or not her tail was real.

Adora had never had a famous client before, but she’d heard some horror stories from other agents. Perfuma had once been assigned to protect a notable pop star who wouldn’t open any doors himself, afraid of the germs of past door-goers. That wasn’t so bad, Adora thought. Mermista told her about an environmentally conscious celebrity who would make her hold all of the plastic refuse they encountered until they found a recycling bin. It wouldn’t have been so bad if that client didn’t go through multiple iced lattes every hour. And a client once punched Sea Hawk for pulling a particularly inventive driving maneuver to get them out of a traffic jam (though having driven with Sea Hawk before, Adora thought the reaction was probably warranted).

Calm down, Adora, she thought to herself. Catra was probably nice. And even if she wasn’t, Adora was a smart, capable professional. She could do this.

The elevator dinged, and the door opened. Adora stepped out into the most beautiful apartment she'd seen in her whole life. Sunlight streamed through the glass windows, giving the space a warm glow; an elegant granite counter separated a small kitchen and a dining table; beautiful paintings adorned the walls, most of them chaotic arrays of bright colors; a steep staircase led up to a loft in the corner of the room.

"Wow," said Adora. She shrugged off her duffel bag and scanned the room. No sign of her client – maybe she was in the bathroom? There were a few doors off to the sides of the main room. Before she could continue her investigation, however, a voice came from behind her.

"So you're my new babysitter, huh?"

Adora whirled around to see a girl leaning against the wall, arms crossed. She had bushy brown hair and informal red loungewear on. Catra. She stuck her tongue out at Adora.

"You must be a pretty bad bodyguard if your own client can sneak up on you," Catra said. Adora's cheeks flushed.

"I'm sorry – I was just taken aback by how nice this place is. It won't happen again."

Catra laughed, and pushed herself off the wall, sauntering towards Adora. "Relax, I'm just teasing. I'm Catra, but you probably already knew that. What's your name?"

"Adora," she replied, eyeing her client warily. Suddenly, Catra picked up speed and closed the distance between them in a few quick bounds. Before Adora had time to react, the pop star placed her face inches from Adora's and tilted it sideways, as if she was studying her. Adora felt her ears burn, but tried to maintain her composure. Catra grinned.

"Hey, Adora."

Curiosity

Chapter Notes

> Thank you to all who read the last chapter and showed interest in this story! I'm going to try for updates every Sunday; we'll see how I go with that, but I think it should be manageable. I will warn in advance the next chapter is probably going to be a little short; I have a specific moment I want to capture. After that, however, the plot will really start rolling.
>
> Thanks for reading, and let me know what you think! :)

"Hey Adora."

As the pop star gazed at her, Adora realized three things.

One, Catra's eyes were different colors; yellow on the left and blue on the right. She filed that away for future reference.

Two, this job was going to be different than anything she'd ever done before.

Three – and this was the one that really hit her – her new client was *really* attractive.

Uh oh.

"Uh…Scorpia says hi," said Adora, trying to think of ways to fill the silence. Catra snorted.

"Scorpia would say hi to a rock if she stepped near it while she was walking," said Catra, slinking past her and plopping down on a luxuriously plush beanbag in the middle of a beam of sunlight. "Or if it was shiny. Or if it wasn't around other rocks and she thought it might get lonely."

Adora chuckled. Honestly, that did match up with her brief impression of Scorpia. She watched as Catra settled in to the beanbag, curling up contentedly. Her tail swished back and forth slowly on the floor before wrapping around her feet.

"You're staring," said Catra, opening one eye to regard Adora impassively.

"Sorry, I've just never…"

"Never seen a girl with a tail before?" finished Catra. "Yeah, most people haven't."

"It's real then?" asked Adora. "Sorry, I hope that's not offensive. I mean, I've seen pictures of you and stuff. I just wasn't sure if it was part of the whole… pop star mystique thing."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Yes, the tail is real, dumbass. Why would I pretend to have a tail? You know how annoying it is seeing them sell those clip-on ones at my shows?"

Adora's brows furrowed. "Okay, so you have a real tail, and two different colored eyes…anything else I should know about?"

Catra smirked at her. "Nothing you won't find out eventually."

Adora felt the faintest hints of a blush creeping up her cheeks. It looked like the coming weeks would give her a lot of practice in self-discipline. But she had to stay focused. "I'd prefer to find out now if they could affect your well-being or my own. Your manager is paying Brightmoon a lot of money for me to keep you safe."

Catra's expression turned dark. "Yes, Shadow Weaver cares very much about keeping me safe, all right. God forbid I do anything remotely exciting and jeopardize her investments."

"Her first name is Shadow?" asked Adora incredulously.

"Who would name their child 'Shadow'?" Catra shot her an annoyed glace. "It's just what I call her."

“Because she looks like an evil sorceress?”

Catra’s gaze turned triumphant, and Adora pointedly ignored the little rush of excitement she felt upon realizing she had said the right thing. “Exactly! I’m glad you see it too. Everyone’s too desensitized to it here. Or they’re too scared of her to say anything.”

Adora nodded. “She gave me really weird vibes when I met her. And what’s with that mask?”

“She thinks it makes her look intimidating,” said Catra derisively. “*I* think it makes her look like a witch.” She rose off her beanbag and approached Adora again.

“Anyway, there’s nothing else that you need to know about me. Other than that I don’t know what I am, and I’ve never met anyone else like me.” There might have been a tinge of sadness in that sentence, but Catra moved on before Adora could respond. “Now come on, let me show you your room.”

Adora followed the pop star to the space below the loft. “I sleep up there,” Catra said, pointing upwards. The loft was pretty high up, and Adora couldn’t really see what was on top of it. “Your bed is here, so if anyone breaks through the sixteen different layers of security in this building to try and kidnap me, they’ll have to go through you first.”

Adora nodded seriously. “They won’t get past me.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “You’re ridiculous.” She jumped onto Adora’s bed, which looked significantly bigger and softer than her bed at Brightmoon. “No one has ever broken in here, so I wouldn’t worry too much about it, Girl Scout.” She turned and gave Adora a once over. Adora felt the blush again, but met Catra's eyes resolutely. “What would you do if they did, anyway? You look about as old as I am.”

Adora smiled. “I get that a lot. But I’ve been training since I was a baby and I’m one of the highest ranked bodyguards at

Brightmoon Security.”

Catra leapt up. “Alright then, let’s see.”

“What do you mean?” said Adora.

“Try to hit me.” Catra grinned.

“I’m not going to hit you. That’s literally the exact opposite of my job.”

“I need to know how strong you are though! How can I trust that you’ll protect me if I don’t know how strong you are?”

Adora folded her arms. “I’d be happy to put you in contact with a reference.”

Catra stuck the bottom of her lip out. Suddenly, however, her ears perked up. “I know!” She bounded up the stairs to her loft, disappearing from view for a second before sticking her head out to look at Adora. “Ready?” she asked.

“I’m don’t know what you’re planning, but probably not!” Adora answered.

“Too late!” With that, Catra leapt over her railing.

Adora didn’t have time to process what was going on. Instinctively, she put her arms out and slid into Catra’s trajectory. Her eyes shut on the impact, and when she opened them, she found a mismatched pair of blue and yellow ones gazing up at her with mirth.

“You passed the test,” said Catra. She made no move to leave her position in Adora’s arms, instead relaxing into them. Despite her best efforts, Adora blushed. She was now holding one of the most famous singers in America bridal style. Whatever she had been expecting from this new job, this was certainly not it. Catra continued to look up at her.

“You’re pretty cute, you know,” Catra said, a sly grin on her face. “For a bodyguard.”

“Um…thanks?” Adora mumbled. Catra threw her head back and laughed.

“You can put me down now, Adora.” Adora lowered her arms, and Catra lithely stepped out of them. “Thanks for the save.” She headed over towards the kitchen. Adora followed, her blush fading and the rest of her senses finally catching up with her.

“And why exactly was it so necessary to test me by jumping off your bed? You could have been seriously hurt!”

Catra opened the fridge, grabbed a juice box, and sat down on a fancy stool at the counter. “And if I was, we’d have learned that you weren’t qualified. But luckily for both of us, you are!”

“That – that wouldn’t happen – that’s not what bodyguards are for!” Adora sputtered.

“Why are you so upset, anyway?” Catra popped her straw into the box and took a long slurp, a bored expression on her face. “You caught me. I’m fine. You’re fine.” She scooted up from her stool to lie on the counter, her back against the granite. “Sorry for trying to have a little fun.”

Adora sat down. “Look, from my experience, being a bodyguard is hard enough without the person in question deliberately endangering themselves. It’s not—” Catra suddenly bolted upright.

“Wait a second.” Her ears twitched. “The elevator’s coming up. It’s probably Shadow Weaver.” She turned to Adora, her defiance melting in to a rather plaintive expression. “Don’t tell her about the jumping thing, okay? She gets really mad if I do anything even a little bit dangerous.”

Adora shook her head. “I don’t know. She’s technically the one paying my company, and I really don’t feel comfortable lying to her.”

Catra's eyes were wide and pitiful. "Please, Adora?" she said.

Adora had been training since she was a child. She could take down an enemy with seven different forms of martial arts. She could fire a variety of guns with near-perfect accuracy, and she could use over a dozen different melee weapons. She could run a five and a half minute mile. She could hoist a grown man over her shoulder and carry him for miles, or throw him at least fifteen feet, depending on wind resistance. But, in that moment, she found that she simply could not say no to a face that cute.

"Fine," she said begrudgingly. "But no more crazy stunts like that, okay?"

Catra's face lit up. "You're the best!" She slid back into her seat. At Adora's questioning glance, she muttered, "Shadow Weaver doesn't like when I sit on the counter."

On cue, the elevator dinged. Catra sighed. "Here we go."

"Adora, so good to see you again. I see you've met our resident teen idol," Shadow – *Ms.* Weaver purred, gliding into the apartment.

Adora stood up straight and saluted. "Yes, Ms. Weaver." Catra rolled her eyes.

"Oh, so polite. You know, Catra, you could learn a thing or two from your new bodyguard." Catra sent a quick glare at Adora before crumpling up her juice box and stalking over to the trashcan. Adora felt guilty for moment, but Ms. Weaver, as if sensing it, put a hand on her shoulder. "Now now, don't mind her. She has her fits of moodiness."

"She's been very kind to me so far," said Adora. Ms. Weaver laughed.

"I'm glad to hear you two are getting along. Let me take you on a tour of the building. Catra, mind I borrow your new friend for a minute?"

“We’re not friends, and you’re just going to do it anyway, so I don’t see why you’re asking me,” said Catra, walking back over to her plush beanbag. Her eyes flicked to Adora’s for a brief second before she settled back into her sun-drenched resting spot.

Ms. Weaver sighed. “Well, in that case, we will see you for dinner.” She guided Adora to the door, her hand never leaving the young bodyguard’s shoulder.

Ropes

Ms. Weaver led her into the elevator and pressed the button for the 4th floor. They stood in silence for a moment before she turned towards Adora.

"So?"

Adora looked up at Ms. Weaver, confused. "So what?" she asked.

"So what did you *really* think of our young prodigy, now that we're out of her earshot. There's no need to hold back – you can trust me."

Adora scratched her head, unsure of what Shadow Wea—*Ms.* Weaver – already Catra's nickname was beginning to replace her client's actual name in her head – wanted to hear. "I mean, we've only spent a couple minutes together, but she seems very… spirited?"

Ms. Weaver's laugh echoed in the small elevator. Yes, Adora decided, Shadow Weaver definitely fit as a nickname. She would have to watch herself to make sure she didn't call her that to her face.

"Spirited is one way of putting it," said Ms. Weaver. "She has a certain restless energy to her. It's quite understandable, of course. She's so young, but she has so much fame and responsibility. She yearns for the freedom to do anything she wants, but so much of what she wants is simply not compatible with the life of a pop star. I wish I could give her that carefree existence. But that's just not how the world works."

Adora nodded. She didn't know too much about fame, but that all seemed to make sense.

"I mention this because soon, Catra will begin to push at her boundaries with you. She's done it with all of her past bodyguards. She'll want to see how much she can get away with.

If you'll let her do certain things unattended. If you'll buy her things she isn't allowed to have. If you'll lie for her."

At that, Adora's face whitened. Did Shadow Weaver know about Catra jumping off the bed? No, she couldn't know. Right? She put her lips tight together and nodded vigorously. "Understood, Ms. Weaver."

"Of course you understand, Adora. I'm so glad to have you here. You might not see it yet, but I can already tell you'll be a much better fit than our past bodyguards." Adora flushed. She didn't understand why Ms. Weaver seemed to like her so much, and it was putting her on edge. Thankfully, the elevator stopped moving. Before the doors opened, however, Ms. Weaver put her hand on Adora's shoulder again, turning to face the young woman.

"There's one thing you must understand, Adora." Her tone shifted from cloying to something more sinister. "*I* am the one who hired you. *I* am the one paying Brightmoon for your service. And *I* am the one you ultimately report to. You do not work for Catra. You work for me. Do *not* forget that." Adora stared at the eyeholes of the crimson mask looking down at her. She couldn't see the eyes behind them. She gulped.

"Yes, Ms. Weaver."

The doors slid open. "Wonderful. Now, allow me to show you the inner life of Hordak Records. You've never been to a record label before, have you?" Adora, still inwardly reeling, mustered up the presence to shake her head. "Oh, perfect. I do love showing newcomers how things work around here."

Miniature Tarts

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Despite what she'd said at the end of their unsettling conversation in the elevator, Shadow Weaver had excused herself rather quickly from the tour of Hordak Records – apparently, there was an important meeting she needed to attend. An enthusiastic girl with long pink hair came in to replace her, introducing herself as Entrapta. She was clearly very knowledgeable about the record label, though Adora was having a hard time keeping up with the flood of information coming at her.

"And here," said Entrapta, opening an ostentatiously crimson door, "is the recording studio. This is where the magic happens! If by magic, of course, one means talented artists using the latest and greatest of modern recording technology to create audio masterpieces! These booths are constructed out of a lightweight, soundproof material that I invented myself." She scurried up to one of them and took a long sniff. "They smell like licorice!" Opening the door, she gestured for Adora to follow. "Inside, you'll find the Z83 microphone model – another one of my inventions – one of the most powerful on the market. I actually had to tone down the sensitivity because it was picking up faint sounds of the recording artists' heartbeats! Isn't that exciting?"

She threw a pair of headphones at Adora. "Listen to this!" She grabbed the microphone and began whispering inaudibly into it, motioning Adora to put the headphones on. "…all frequencies of the human voice and many that the human ear can't even register! One of the employees brought their dog into work once and I was able to get her in the booth for a quick session. She could hear all sorts of sounds! Of course, I could only run a few experiments before they found her. Oh well. One day!"

Adora winced in pain and removed the headphones. Entrapta's voice got louder when she was excited, and she seemed to get excited…very often.

"And over here," continued Entrapta, leading Adora out of the studio and through another hallway, "is my other favorite place at Hordak." She pushed open a set of double doors theatrically. "The cafeteria!" Several long dining tables stood in the center of the room, and different food stations lined the edges of it. Adora's mouth watered at the myriad of smells coming her way. Entrapta pulled her towards one of the stations. "This place is a goldmine. There are *tons* of social interactions to analyze. Who sits with who? In what part of the room? How do they greet other people? And, most importantly...tiny food!" She took a small pastry from the counter in front of her. "Go on, try one!"

Adora somewhat hesitantly reached for a miniature tart. "Wow," she said, wiping the crumbs from her mouth. "That was really good! Like a regular tart, but…smaller!"

"Exactly!!!" Entrapta beamed at her. "Now come on, there's a lot more to see."

After a *very* involved tour of the rest of Hordak, Entrapta finally led her back to the elevator, citing several unfinished experiments she had to check on. Adora bid her goodbye, and, once she was in the elevator, took a long sigh of relief. She liked Entrapta, but it was all getting a little overwhelming. Honestly, all she wanted to do right now was go back to her bunk at Brightmoon, lie down on her bed, and listen to Perfuma talk about her day and all the different plants she'd seen. In turn, she would tell Perfuma all about Catra and Shadow Weaver and Hordak, and Perfuma would nod her head and braid a flower into her hair and tell her it would all turn out okay.

But she had a job to do.

She took a deep breath, scanned her ID card, and pressed the button for the top floor.

…

When she got back to the apartment, Catra was in the same spot, curled up in her plush beanbag. It looked like she hadn't moved an inch the whole time Adora was away. Her small frame rose and fell gently with her breath, and Adora watched her for a moment. This peaceful look seemed a far cry from the energetic pop star she had been introduced to a couple hours ago. Adora felt a sudden urge to run her hands through Catra's hair. She bet it would be soft, and silky, and…and completely unprofessional. She shook her head. She would have to be more disciplined.

"You're staring again."

Catra's eyes stayed closed, but her tail swished back and forth. Adora straightened her back and sputtered. "I wasn't – I'm sorry – you're awake?"

Catra yawned, stretching her body languidly. "I am now." She adjusted herself in the beanbag, moving into a vaguely more upright position, but made no move to get up. "How was Shadow Weaver's grand tour?"

"Good! It was good," rushed Adora. She didn't think she should bring up the conversation they had in the elevator. She wasn't sure how she could.

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Okay, weirdo. Just a question." She yawned again. "What time is it?"

"Um, almost one," said Adora, checking her watch.

"You hungry?"

As a matter of fact, Adora was famished. She had a fast metabolism, and that tiny tart had only served to awaken her appetite. She shrugged. "I could eat." As a bodyguard, her needs were secondary to her client's.

“Well I’m starving,” said Catra. She rose from her chair in one swift motion and walked towards a room on the side of the apartment that Adora realized was a walk-in closet. “You cool with Chipotle?”

“I’ll eat anything,” said Adora. While again, it wasn’t a bodyguard’s place to tell their client how to eat, it was true that Adora was *not* a picky eater. A favorite game of her friends Bow and Glimmer was to take her out to eat, buy her the weirdest items on the menu, and dare her to eat them. So far, she hadn’t turned down a challenge, even if the mango poutine from the Canadian fusion place had left her stomach feeling a little confused for the next couple days. She just liked food! “But won’t people recognize you? Having a bunch of fans or paparazzi around is a security risk.”

“Not a problem,” came Catra’s voice from her closet. She emerged wearing a purple beanie, a flowing black shirt, and a wide-legged pair of jeans. “I’ll go incognito.”

Adora raised an eyebrow. True, the hat covered Catra’s ears, and her tail had to be hidden in her jeans somewhere. But to say her client still looked anything other than distinctive would be lying. “Sure,” she said. “Just your average teenager with different colored eyes.”

“It’s called heterochromia, asshole.” Catra stuck her tongue out. “Tons of people have it. Plus, people wear all sorts of weird contacts these days.” She grabbed her sneakers from a rack near the door and began to tie them. “Come on, I feel like I haven’t eaten in ten years.”

Adora sighed, but retrieved her jacket and shoes. It didn’t seem like a great idea to go out in public, but she wasn’t really sure how things worked around here. She also wasn’t sure if she could tell Catra not to do things. Or if Catra would listen to her if she did. Pulling her red jacket around her shoulders, she followed her client into the elevator.

“So.” Catra stared straight ahead as they descended. “How does a nineteen year old get into the bodyguard business?”

Adora took a moment to consider her answer. “I attended a military school from a young age, and I did a lot of martial arts. When I graduated, I didn’t really know what I wanted to do, but I had a pretty specific skillset. I saw an ad for a bodyguard agency, and, well, I liked the idea of protecting people.”

“Wow,” said Catra, a hint of surprise in her voice. “I didn’t realize we hired an idealist.” She swung her body around to lean against the wall of the elevator, facing Adora. “What’s the worst thing you’ve had to do to someone who attacked your client?”

Adora laughed. “To be honest, the life of a bodyguard is usually pretty boring. It’s more about observing and avoiding potential threats than actually fighting people. And there’s often a lot of standing around.”

“So you’ve never had to fight anyone?”

“I didn’t say that.”

They exited the elevator, walking through Hordak’s main lobby.

“Oh hey, friends!” exclaimed Scorpia. “Hi Catra! Nice to see you again, Adora!”

“Hey Scorpia!” said Adora, smiling. Catra gave the receptionist a nod.

“Where are you guys off to?” asked Scorpia, leaning forward on her desk.

“We’re just going to get some lunch,” answered Catra, nonchalant. “Chipotle.”

“Want us to get you anything?” asked Adora. She hoped that was okay. But Scorpia had been so nice. And it wouldn’t take them any extra distance.

“Oh, no thank you. I brought lunch from home! That is so sweet though.” She stood up from her chair.

Catra sighed, rubbing her forehead. “Now you’ve done it.”

“Can I give you a hug?”

Adora had begun a hesitant nod before Scorpia embraced her, but she wasn’t sure the receptionist had even waited for an answer. The larger woman’s hug was, if unexpected, at least warm and comforting. After a few seconds, she released Adora and turned to Catra.

Catra rolled her eyes. “Fine.” Scorpia squealed with delight and scooped her up. Adora laughed at the resigned expression on Catra’s face. “There’s no point in resisting. She’s just going to do it anyway.”

Finally they exited the building and walked through a small grassy park across the street from Hordak, Catra swiftly guiding Adora through the network of paths.

“So who did you fight?” she asked.

“What?”

“You said that you’ve had to fight people as a bodyguard. So who was it? How’d it go down?”

Adora scanned the unfamiliar area ahead of them. “Well, my last client was a very successful entrepreneur. About once a week, she would have to go downtown to a pretty rough neighborhood for a meeting with someone she was hoping to make a deal with, so she hired me to accompany her. There was a lot of drug and alcohol use around there, and I guess I don’t look that threatening, so sometimes people would cause trouble. They would be really belligerent and confrontational, and one time they even tried to rob her.”

“So what happened?”

Adora cracked her knuckles. “Let’s just say that after a couple trips they learned to stop trying.” She smirked, and Catra clapped her hands gleefully. To be honest, the drunkards had not been the toughest opponents, especially considering Adora regularly trained against Brightmoon’s top agents. But she was happy that she could entertain her client.

They spent the rest of the walk discussing Adora’s experiences as a bodyguard. Catra was surprisingly curious, though she didn’t seem to take bodyguard work very seriously. Still, it was a far cry from the aloof and disinterested pop star Adora had expected. Adora wasn’t used to being the focus of attention. It was kind of nice.

“Okay, so as a bodyguard, where’s the most secure seating in this Chipotle?”

“Hmmmm.” Adora’s eyes swept the room. “Ideally, a table towards the back, where we can observe the entrance.”

Catra shrugged. “Makes sense. But the only place not taken is the window, so… guess we’ll have to risk it.” She stuck her tongue out.

Adora paid careful attention to Catra’s order – she was admittedly curious as to if someone so famous had any weird quirks. But it seemed like a pretty standard carnitas burrito, though the pop star did insist on a heaping serving of the hottest salsa.

Adora, unsure of what exactly to expect, dug out her wallet at the register as the employee wrapped up her chicken burrito, but Catra gave her an amused look and put it all on a sleek, black card that read ‘Hordak’ in small print. They sat down by the window, each digging in ravenously. Conversation took a backseat to the food in front of them.

A couple minutes later, Catra leaned back in satisfaction. “Wow.” She burped. “I needed that.”

Adora brushed a napkin over her mouth. “Agreed.” She glanced up at the menu display.

“Are you still hungry?” asked Catra, with more wonder than judgment.

“No! No,” rushed Adora. “Unless you are, that is.” Catra threw back her head and laughed, then pulled the black card out of her pocket. “Here,” she said. “Knock yourself out.”

Adora accepted the card, then immediately offered it back. “Thank you, but no. My focus would be divided between giving my order and keeping an eye on you. It’s too risky.”

Catra raised her eyebrows. “Really? Too risky for me to sit at this Chipotle counter while you get a burrito?” At Adora’s unyielding expression, she sighed. “Ugh, fine. C’mon.” She stood up. “I’ll go with you. Even though you’re being *ridiculous*.” She walked into the Chipotle line, and, after a second, Adora followed.

“You don’t have to do this,” said Adora. “Really, I’m fine.”

Catra assessed her skeptically. “If you can look me in the eyes and tell me with 100% honesty that you are not still hungry now, then we’ll go. But I don’t think you can do that.”

Adora looked her in the eyes. “I am not—” She slumped, rubbing her head sheepishly. “—not still hungry. I am hungry. Thank you.”

“Don’t mention it. Anyway, it’s not my money.”

The woman behind the barrier asked Adora what she would like.

“A burrito, please,” answered Adora.

“And for you, miss?” she asked Catra.

“Oh, nothing for me, thanks.” Catra smirked, looping her arm through Adora’s. “I’m just keeping her company.”

Adora's cheeks burned as she guided the woman through her burrito's interior. "What are you doing?" she whispered to Catra, while the woman was piling grilled beef onto her rice and beans. "And uh, corn salsa, thank you."

Catra leaned against her arm. "I'm staying a safe distance, that's all. Your focus is divided. I don't want you to lose track of me."

"That's not what I meant– um, yes, lettuce please. No sour cream. That's all, thank you."

Catra chuckled. She gave the Hordak card to the cashier and released Adora, sauntering away. "This one's on me, babe." Adora's face was a solid shade of crimson as the cashier rung her up.

Catra let out a peal of laughter as they walked back to their seats. Adora, still flushed, crossed her arms. After a few moments, Catra composed herself. "I'm sorry, I don't mean to tease you. But you should have seen your face! You were like, 'ohhhh, nooooooo, they didn't cover this in bodyguard training! What do I dooooo?" She mimed out her bodyguard's despair theatrically. Adora rolled her eyes, then dug into her food. Catra watched her bodyguard eat for a few moments, taking a long slurp from the soda she had surreptitiously refilled after buying Adora's second course. "How's it compare to burrito number one?"

Mouth full, Adora held up a finger. She chewed for five thoughtful seconds, swallowed, and thought for five more. "Hard to say. They're both really good." She went back to eating. Catra laughed. She let Adora finish her meal in silence, gazing out the window at the people walking by. When Adora looked over to check the entrance, she saw a smile lingering on the pop star's face.

…

A minute after they left the Chipotle, Adora noticed they were being followed.

It wasn't a very skilled tail. Under the guise of examining a storefront, Adora watched from the corner of her eye as a tall man in a well-tailored suit maintained a steady distance from them, pausing when she stopped and pointed at one of the items on display.

Catra examined the rocking horse she was gesturing towards. "Huh? I mean, it's well-made, but I think you're a little big for it."

"We're being followed." Adora nudged Catra forward, knowing the pop star would instinctually want look back. "Don't look. Just keep moving."

Catra stared at her for a second, then jerked her head around, scanning the area behind them. "You sure? I don't see anyone."

"I said don't look!" She grabbed Catra's left arm as gently as she could, pulling her forward. "You know the area. What's the fastest, most public way to get back to Hordak?"

Catra thought for a second. "Not sure," she said. "It's on the other side of the park, so at some point we have to cut through there." She studied Adora for a moment. "You're serious about this, huh."

Adora nodded sharply. They continued down the sidewalk, faster than before. Adora's long strides covered ground quickly, and before long Catra was struggling to keep up.

"Adora. Hey! Adora!" she exclaimed, yanking her arm out of her bodyguard's grip. "Do you really think we're being followed? This feels like a bunch of normal, boring people to me. And even if we are, it's probably just some fan who recognized me."

Adora frowned at her for a moment. "Fine. Man in the suit. Walking behind that woman with the purple coat."

Catra's eyes searched for a moment before landing on their target. He met them with pale blue ones. He leered.

"Okay, you're right," admitted Catra. "Doesn't look like a fan." They continued onwards, but the man followed. He was gaining on them, more brazen now that he knew he had been seen.

"Adora?" Catra's voice was quieter than before.

"Don't worry. If he tries anything, I'll handle it." They reached the park. Adora glanced behind them. The man was fast approaching, clearly aiming to intercept them when they entered the less populated area. She made a decision.

"Catra, get behind me," she said. Catra met her eyes for a moment, then did as she asked. Adora turned her full attention to the man in front of her, watching as he came closer and closer. He slowed when he saw Adora staring him down, but kept coming.

"Hey, ladies. Nice afternoon for a walk, isn't it?" His voice had an edge of amusement to it that Adora didn't trust.

"Sir, do not get any closer to me or my client," said Adora.

His grin was wide. "Client? I didn't realize I was dealing with a *professional*."

Adora's only response was to deepen her glare.

He scowled. "Aren't you two cute."

"What do you want, weirdo?" yelled Catra.

"Who says I want anything? I'm just passing by. We're going the same direction, actually."

"Liar." Adora's voice was even. "We saw you following us."

"Alright, I'll admit it." He looked at Catra. "I recognized you immediately. You're the cat girl, right? The singer." His eyes narrowed. "I just wanted to say hi."

"Well, you've said it." Adora crossed her arms. "Now get moving."

"Oh, but I'm so curious about her…anatomy. I have some questions I'd like to answer. About what parts are in what places." His mouth twisted cruelly.

"I'm telling you one more time, do not step any closer to her."

"Or what?"

"Or you'll regret it."

He laughed sharply. "You think you're pretty tough, huh?"

He stepped closer. She swung.

…

"Oh. My. God."

Adora wanted to get off the scene immediately, so they walked quickly through the park back towards Hordak. Catra bounced up and down beside her.

"That was so cool!!! You just…WHAM…and he just…dropped!"

Adora examined her fist, which was slightly raw from the impact. "I warned him not to get closer. But they never think a teenage girl can punch."

Catra giggled. "I bet he knows now. I wonder what he'll think when he wakes up."

Adora flashed a grin. "You okay?"

Catra nodded, her mirth fading. "Yeah. I just can't believe he came up to us on the street like that." She tugged down her beanie. "I know some people are kinda pervy about the cat girl thing, but no one's ever really…been so aggressive about it before. Not to my face."

"Well, I can't say I know what that's like." She put a hand on Catra's shoulder, meeting her eyes. "But if anyone else is gross

enough to do anything like this, I'll happily punch them too."

Catra's laugh was short, but her frown lessened. "Thanks, Adora."

They walked the remainder of the way back to Hordak in silence.

…

The rest of the day went by in a blur for Adora. Shortly after they returned to Hordak, she accompanied Catra to her session with a vocal coach in the Hordak studios. Adora had been looking forward to hearing Catra sing in person, but she was told by the rather ornery singing instructor to wait outside the soundproof booth so as to not disrupt the acoustics. Catra looked rather unenthusiastic about the lesson; from what Adora could tell, the coach was having her do a series of exercises over and over again. At one point it seemed like they got in a pretty severe argument, but Catra finally sighed and resumed her singing, rolling her eyes at Adora through the glass.

Before the lesson was over, Entrapta bounced in to give Adora some tech. The bodyguard was now the owner of a Hordak smartphone, headset, and watch, all of all of which were capable of sending and receiving calls and messages. They were linked to each other and to her laptop (which she hadn't even taken out of her bag yet). Her smartphone, which Entrapta apparently designed herself, came equipped with a multitude of different apps, ranging from the potentially functional (a satellite map that could display real time images of the surrounding area) to the perhaps unnecessary (an elevator tracker that showed what floor the Hordak elevators were on at all times) to the completely irresponsible (an app called simply "Grenade," that, when opened, would allow the user to pick an amount of time after which the entire phone would explode).

"Entrapta, this can't be legal," Adora had said. The pink-haired technician simply laughed.

"What the government doesn't know can't hurt them!"

Adora wanted to protest that statement, because it *definitely* wasn't true, but Entrapta was too busy fiddling with the watch's clasp ("At the right level of tightness, it can accurately supply your bodily information!") to really engage with her.

Her phone came equipped with five contacts: Catra, Ms. Weaver, Scorpia, Entrapta, and Lonnie. Her curiosity over the last name was abruptly resolved when Lonnie called her.

"Adora, right? Entrapta told me she was going to hook you up with the tech. I'm Lonnie, the chief of security at Hordak. When you get the chance, meet me in my office on the eighth floor."

After the lesson, as Catra returned to her room, Adora did just that. Lonnie turned out to be a sturdy woman who seemed like she knew what she was doing. She introduced Adora to her two deputies, a hulking man named Rogelio who communicated solely in grunts and a rather anxious boy named Kyle. They would coordinate with Adora during Catra's concerts and events.

As she stood in the elevator going up to Catra's apartment, Adora got another call, this one from Scorpia. The receptionist informed her that the weather was beautiful today, a really interesting guy with two different scarves on just walked by, and this weekend her cousin was taking her on a boat trip – oh, and Ms. Weaver requested Adora and Catra's presence in the cafeteria for dinner.

…

"Going to get a burrito was a reckless decision?!"

"If Adora hadn't been there—"

"But she *was* there! It's her *job* to be there!"

"This time, yes. But how many times have you run off without your bodyguard to go cavort around the town? This is a pattern of reckless—"

"What do you expect me to do when I'm trapped in my apartment all the time? If you had your way, I'd probably be locked inside!"

Adora glanced back and forth like she was watching a game of tennis. After Ms. Weaver had learned about what happened on their excursion, the conversation had quickly turned into a shouting match. Adora looked down at her plate. She was almost halfway done, but Catra had barely touched her food, and Ms. Weaver hadn't taken a single bite. Adora wondered if she even *could* eat with her mask on.

Finally, Ms. Weaver held up her hand. "Enough." She sighed. "I trust you have at least learned the importance of staying with your bodyguard. For now, that will have to be enough. We have other matters to discuss." Catra crossed her arms, but didn't protest. Ms. Weaver leaned forward.

"This morning, I received a call from the booking director of Princess Fest. Ariana Grande just pulled out; apparently a sudden conflict arose. He wanted to see if he could book you instead."

Catra leaned back in her chair. "This is the one with all the floofy pink stuff, right? Hard pass. It looks way too girly for me."

"I said yes, of course," continued Ms. Weaver. "This is the headlining position on the main stage. The festival is full of young listeners who might not know you yet. We can't pass this opportunity up."

Catra groaned. "Really? I haven't performed in months. I need time to go over choreography – and I don't even have a set."

Ms. Weaver waved her hand. "We'll fly out tomorrow and work on it there. I know it's short notice, but this could be your next big break."

"Of course. I can't even go buy a burrito by myself. Why should I expect that I can make decisions about *anything* in my life?" Catra pushed herself off her chair and headed for the elevator.

“Catra,” Ms. Weaver called. “Catra!” But the pop star didn’t turn around. Adora moved to follow her, but Ms. Weaver gestured her to remain.

“Stay a moment, won’t you, Adora?” Adora sat down uncertainly. Ms. Weaver sighed. “She has her fits of drama. I just hope she knows that I have her best interests at heart. Sometimes I think she forgets that.”

Adora wasn’t sure what to say. “I’ve never been to a music festival before,” she offered hesitantly. “So it works out for me, at least.”

Ms. Weaver laughed. “Oh, wonderful. I do appreciate you looking after her, Adora. It sounded like quite the situation today.”

Adora nodded. “That’s why I’m here.”

“Of course, of course. There is one thing, though.” She leaned closer to Adora. “You didn’t know about this, so I won’t hold this time against you. But in the future… do not go anywhere with Catra without notifying me first.” Her fingers drummed against the table.

“Yes, Ms. Weaver.” For some reason, the words left a bad taste in Adora’s mouth.

“I must seem intense, I know. I just get so worried, as her manager. We’ve been working together for so long – I feel quite protective of her. I know she resents that, but I can’t help it. And with incidents like what happened today, I’d just prefer to know where she is, for my own peace of mind.”

Adora nodded. She supposed that she couldn’t really fault Ms. Weaver for that.

…

When she got back to the penthouse, Catra was sitting at the counter.

"Hey, Adora," she said, leaning forward and resting her head on her hands.

"Hey." Adora walked over and sat down next to her. "You okay? That was a pretty intense argument."

Catra waved her hand. "I walk out of dinners with Shadow Weaver all the time. She's just so *irritating*. It's like she doesn't think I can do anything for myself." She slumped her head further.

Adora put a hand out to pat her on the shoulder, then pulled it back. "I brought you some food," she said instead, holding out a small bag. "Since it didn't seem like you ate that much."

Catra took the bag, looking inside it. "Oh! A mini-tart! I love these!" Stuffing it in her mouth, she turned to Adora. "Thangmth 'ou." Adora laughed, and after a second, Catra did too.

"Adora?" she asked, after she finished chewing. "Really, thank you."

"They're just small tarts," said Adora, rubbing the back of her neck.

"Not for the food." Catra paused, looking down at the table. "Look, I…I admit I had my doubts about you when we first met. I'm used to my bodyguards being big men in suits." She scratched behind her ear. "But today with that creep? I was really scared. I've never been confronted like that before. Probably because of those huge bodyguards. So I was kinda freaking out. But the way you took control – you seemed so confident in what you were doing. And you knew exactly what to do." Catra fiddled with her hands. "You were really reassuring. And then you decked that guy, which was totally awesome. So…thank you." She smiled.

Adora flushed. "Just doing my job." Catra laughed.

"I knew you would say something like that. You're such a goody two-shoes." She leaned over and booped Adora on the forehead.

“I like it though.” She laughed again, then leapt up across the counter.

“I’m going to bed now,” she called over her shoulder. “You should probably do the same. Knowing Shadow Weaver, we’ll probably leave obscenely early tomorrow.”

…

After Adora brushed her teeth and changed into a white undershirt and plain boxers, she lay in her bed, struggling to sleep. She was exhausted, but this bed was significantly softer than her one at Brightmoon, and it was throwing her off. It didn’t help that so many thoughts were running through her mind. She couldn’t believe it had only been a single day at Hordak. Between adjusting to her new client, dealing with Ms. Weaver, and meeting so many different employees, it felt like ages – and that wasn’t even getting in to the man who accosted them. She turned over, hoping the other side would provide her more comfort. Honestly, the day had been intensely stressful. She hadn’t been sure what to expect, but it was not this. Was she really cut out to deal with such a high-profile client?

Still, though. What Catra said to her back in the kitchen kind of made up for it.

She fell asleep with a smile on her face.

Chapter End Notes

> And the end of Adora's first day at Hordak comes to a close! I know it's a long chapter, so thanks for reading! I wanted to give you guys something a little meatier since last week's update was so short. I really appreciate the interest people are showing in this story! It's been a while since I've written anything substantial, and this is a fun challenge.
>
> See you next week! :)

Cold Feet

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Everything Adora could see was pink.

She and Catra stood in their hotel room, one of three bedrooms in a luxury suite originally reserved for Ariana Grande. And while Adora wasn't sure if it was the pop star's preference or the people putting on the festival, whoever was in charge of furnishing the room had a singular vision in mind.

"Wow." Catra collapsed on the soft pink rug that covered the floor. "My eyes are starting to hurt just looking at this." Adora pulled back the pink curtains, pulled out the pink wooden chair from the pink desk, and sat down.

"At least we won't be here very long," she offered. The festival was tomorrow, so the plan was for Catra to spend all of today rehearsing. The Hordak dance troupe that accompanied her on her tour was currently out with another artist, so this would be a solo performance; while the full effect of Catra's vaunted choreography might be lessened, it would at least be simpler to get everything together on such short notice.

Four quick knocks came at the door, but before Adora could open it, Scorpia burst in. "Hey guys! Your room is pink too! Isn't it just lovely?"

"It looks like this room is almost perfectly identical to ours! I'll have to take some measurements to confirm, of course." Entrapta followed Scorpia into the room, speaking into a handheld recording device. "And I wonder if Ms. Weaver's room is similar…"

"I don't mean this in a negative way, but remind me again why you two are here?" Adora had been surprised to find the two of them in the car with her, Catra, and Ms. Weaver when they left

Hordak for the airport early that morning. They probably explained it then, but a couple minutes into the ride Catra had fallen asleep leaning on her shoulder, and Adora spent the rest of it too focused on staying still to really pay attention to the conversation.

Entrapta beamed at her. "I wear a lot of hats here at Hordak Records," she said, gesturing to a curious contraption on her head that continuously rotated miniature versions of a top hat, a propeller beanie, and a sombrero. "And I also do tons of different things for the company! Including the light shows for Catra's performances."

"And I'm here to make sure she doesn't, uh, blow anything up," said Scorpia, with a sheepish look at Entrapta.

The inventor cackled. "You can try!" She gave the room a final once over before bouncing out the door. "On to the third test case!"

"Entrapta, I don't think Ms. Weaver wants us to go in her – oh no. Entrapta!" Scorpia ran after Hordak's resident mad scientist.

Catra laughed. "Isn't she hilarious? I remember being introduced to her when I first got signed to Hordak – I thought she was the most annoying person I'd ever met. Then she pulled me aside at the big welcome party and asked me to help record the top executive's conversations because she was trying to understand the social patterns of the workplace." She rose from the carpet lazily. "It changed the party from a total snoozefest into something actually exciting. Did you know that one of the biggest shareholders in Hordak has a foot fetish? He got completely wasted and propositioned like five different people."

After dropping that apparent bombshell on her, Catra went into the bathroom, leaving Adora to complete her examination of the room. She didn't expect anything fishy, but it was standard procedure to give anywhere her client would be staying a solid once over. She checked under the bed and the tables. Nothing

suspicious. She peered out the windows. Too high to break into, or to jump from safely in an emergency. She pulled out the drawer of the bedside table. Was that a…yes, that was a hot pink Bible. Wow.

Aside from a monochromatic color scheme, the room seemed perfectly adequate. Adora's only concern was that there was only one –

"Is Catra ready?"

Adora jumped. Ms. Weaver stood in their doorway.

"She, uh, just went to the bathroom."

"Tell her to meet me in the rehearsal room as soon as she comes out. We have a lot of work to do today."

…

They did indeed do a lot of work that day. Adora was eager to finally hear Catra perform, but found herself relegated to guarding the door to the space – this was not a private rehearsal room, and other artists and bands would periodically try to get in. Most accepted Adora's firm refusal, but a couple persistent ones required her to call Ms. Weaver, who would come over and icily inquire as to why they were wasting her artist's precious time. They would leave fairly quickly after that.

After a while, the visitors died down. And while Angella always said that patience was a bodyguard's most important virtue, Adora was starting to get intensely bored. The empty hallway around her offered little stimulation.

She took her jacket off. If she was just going to remain in front of this door and tell people not to come in the room, she could at least do something productive. She reached for her toes. It was always important to stretch before working out.

She was midway through her third set of pushups when she noticed Catra's head in the doorway. The pop star was staring at her, her mouth slightly open. Adora leapt up.

"What's up?" she said. "Do you need anything?"

Catra shook her head slowly. "No." She blinked. "We were, um… we just…we finished rehearsing for the day. So we are going to get food now. If you would like to come with us."

"Well, that is my job," said Adora jauntily. She wasn't sure why Catra was acting so weird. But any news about food was good news.

…

When they got back to the hotel room, Adora asked if Catra was nervous about her performance tomorrow.

"Yeah," came the immediate reply. Catra rolled over on the bed so that she was lying on her back. "The day before is always the worst. Once the adrenaline kicks in, it's fine. But just the anticipation…"

Adora nodded from the desk chair, though she wasn't sure Catra could see her. "I get that. I'm usually a wreck the entire week before our physical evaluations at Brightmoon. My roommate – her name is Perfuma – she says my energy is all over the place. But during the test, I don't feel nervous. I'm too focused."

Catra rolled over again, resting her head on her arms. "Roommate, huh? I didn't realize you lived with other people."

"Well, we don't really see each other that often, since we're away on assignment so much. But she's another bodyguard at Brightmoon. She's lovely. She has all these plants, and she cares about them a lot. And she'll always listen to you if you have a problem."

"Are all your friends bodyguards?"

“Most of them!” Adora chuckled. “Except for my best friends, Glimmer and Bow. Glimmer is the daughter of Angella, the president of Brightmoon. She grew up wanting to be a bodyguard, but Angella thought it was too dangerous and forbid it. No one told me that, though. So one of my first days there, this tiny girl with purple hair asks me to spar, and of course I say yes. A couple minutes later my boss comes into the room, furious because I have her daughter in a headlock. But Glimmer was really cool about it, and now we’re best friends!” Adora smiled at the memory. “She and Bow have been inseparable since childhood. He’s a really fun, enthusiastic dude who loves crop-tops – you’d like him. Everyone does.” She pulled out her phone – her personal phone, not the Hordak issued one – to show Catra the lock screen: her, Bow, and Glimmer crumpled together on the couch after a movie marathon. She and Glimmer were both asleep on Bow, who had somehow maneuvered his hand free in order to take the selfie. It was one of Adora’s favorite pictures.

“Very cute,” said Catra, glancing at the photo.

“What about you?” Adora asked. “Tell me about your friends.”

“There’s not much to tell.” Catra’s tail wrapped around her feet. “I mean, you’ve already met Scorpia and Entrapta.”

Adora guffawed. “Yeah, okay. Really though.” Silence. “You’re serious.”

Catra’s laugh was more bitter than amused. “Surprised I don’t have a squad of famous friends? I’m not Taylor Swift. Most of the famous people I meet seem pretty stupid to me. Or maybe fake is a better word. They don’t seem like people I could trust.”

“I guess that makes sense. But what about people from before you were famous?”

“Sure, they reach out from time to time. But…” Catra regarded Adora coolly for a moment. “Look, I’m not gonna get into it right now, but I had a pretty rough childhood. And more often than

not, people who reach out to me now are people who didn't give a shit about me when I wasn't a pop star. So I wouldn't regard them as friends."

"I'm sorry, I—"

Catra shook her head. "It is what it is." They sat in silence for a few moments.

"I mean, Scorpia and Entrapta are super cool. And, I know we've only just started working together. But I could see us, being, you know. Friends." Adora knew she was teetering on the edge of professionalism. But it wasn't in her nature to be silent at a time like this. Catra rolled her eyes.

"I appreciate that you're trying to be nice. But if my only friends are people who are literally paid to be around me, I think that's a bad sign." Her tail flicked back and forth. "Now come on. Let's go to bed. I'm exhausted."

Adora's concerns for her client's social life melted away in the face of a more pressing issue. "Uh, yes. About that. I can just take this chair, I guess? Or maybe the floor would be more comfortable."

"Or you could just sleep in the bed, weirdo."

Adora's cheeks burned. "But – aren't you – wouldn't that – I'll just take the chair!"

"Don't be ridiculous," said Catra. "That chair looks horrifically uncomfortable. This bed is massive, and I sleep curled up anyway."

Adora felt like she should protest more. But the chair *was* uncomfortable. And if she was sore tomorrow, or if she didn't get enough sleep, she would be a less effective bodyguard.

"Alright." She went to the bathroom to change into her pajamas. When she came back, true to her word, Catra was curled up on top of the covers. Adora gingerly lifted up the edge and slipped

beneath them, giving the pop star plenty of room. It wasn’t hard; as Catra said, the bed was massive. She lay on her back, trying to get comfortable without moving too much and disturbing her client. The blanket was soft, but not incredibly thick, and she found that her feet were unpleasantly cold. Still, part of bodyguard training was sleeping in uncomfortable environments, and Adora finally drifted off.

When she awoke to pink-tinted sunlight streaming through the windows, however, there was a comfortable weight on her legs, and her feet were the perfect temperature.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry for the late update! This chapter was originally going to be much longer, but I decided to split it in two and tackle the performance next week. So stay tuned for Catra's (on-screen) musical debut! :) and thanks for reading!

Princess Fest

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora wasn't sure what to do.

She reached over to the bedside table for her phone, careful to keep the bottom half of her body still. A message from Ms. Weaver ran across the screen:

Meet me in the lobby at 9:00am with Catra.

Adora glanced at the time: 8:08. Too early to wake up Catra, too late to go back to sleep. She resolved that she would wake her client up at 8:20. Speaking of her client…

Catra had draped herself across Adora's lower half. Her face was turned away from Adora; all the bodyguard could see was a mess of bushy hair attached to the body curled around her legs.

Just then, Catra made a muffled noise, and rolled over. Her chest rose up and down slowly, her mouth slightly open.

Well, okay. Maybe she could wait until 8:30.

…

As the new headliner of Princess Fest, Catra would be the last show of the day, taking up the 8pm slot on the main stage. So, as it turned out, they had a lot of time to kill. And while Catra grumbled a bit about waking up so early when her performance was so late, once she got out of bed the pop star seemed pretty energetic. She wanted to explore Princess Fest – apparently she knew some of the other musicians.

Adora had half expected Ms. Weaver to shoot down that idea, but after a few moments of consideration, the manager had

acquiesced – provided Adora stuck with the pop star at all times.

"It's not like I can do any more preparing, anyway," said Catra as they walked towards the performers' entrance to the festival. "If I sing today my voice will be tired for the concert." Adora nodded, her mouth occupied by a croissant she had taken from the hotel breakfast buffet. Catra showed her badge to a stern man in a black t-shirt. He examined it, then waved her by, sending a questioning glance Adora's way. "She's with me."

Their first stop was the Royal stage, the second-biggest stage of the festival. Catra took Adora around the back of it, revealing stairs that led up to the side of the stage. It was still early; the only signs of life were plainly dressed sound techs running around frantically.

"Are we allowed to be here?" asked Adora. No one had told them they couldn't, but she felt like she was trespassing.

Catra laughed. "I'm famous," she replied succinctly.

"Still, though. I mean, we just walked right up here. Shouldn't people be in place to stop things like that from happening?"

Catra poked her. "I know it's like, your job or whatever, but could you switch out of security mode for a bit? Just relax." The pop star grabbed a folding chair from a small stack leaning against the wall. "What sort of music do you like? There are tons of people playing today."

"I don't really know that many current bands," said Adora. She scratched her head. "Maybe you can read some of them off? My friend Glimmer plays me new music in the car sometimes, and I bet some of the bands she likes are here."

Catra pulled the list up on her phone. "Chvrches…Kali Uchis…Jorja Smith…Snow tha Product…070 Shake…Kacey Musgraves—"

"Oh, I've heard of her!" exclaimed Adora, excited.

Catra giggled. “You didn’t tell me you were an *expert*! Now I feel like an uncultured clown.”

Adora punched Catra’s shoulder lightly. “Ha ha.” She smiled. “No, I appreciate the thought, but I’m happy to follow you around for the day and see what bands you think are worthy of your time. I’ll take it as a chance to broaden my horizons.”

“We’ll give you a crash course in current music,” Catra agreed. “The first person you need to see is Tierra Whack. She is so cool. Her new album is 15 songs, but they’re each one minute long. Here, actually—” she dug a pair of earbuds out of her bag and stuck them into her phone. “We still have a bunch of time before the show starts. Your education starts now!”

Adora took the headphones with hesitation. “I don’t know if I feel comfortable with that. I like to be able to hear to everything that’s going on around me.”

“Yeah, I knew you wouldn’t be able to switch out of security mode.” Catra stuck her tongue out. “What if we shared? Then you could still keep one ear free to the outside world.”

That was still more distraction than Adora would have liked, but the sound techs bustling around them didn’t seem to be too much of a threat. “Alright, I suppose. But once more people start coming in I’m going to take them out.” Catra cheered. As she pulled up the album, Adora felt her pocket buzz.

It was a one-word message from Ms. Weaver. *Location?*

We’re at the Royal Stage.

The response came almost instantaneously. *Good. Keep me posted.*

Catra offered her an earbud. “Ready to get your mind blown?”

…

It was, Adora had to admit, a pretty good album. She and Catra sat on the side of the stage, the pop star silently nodding her head up and down to the beat. Since she was down an ear, Adora intended to continually scan the area for threats, but she found that her gaze would often land on her client. Catra's small movements entranced her. Sometimes, she would close her eyes, and it seemed like the music brought something out from deep within her. Other times, she would open them and flail her arms about wildly, laughing as she let the rhythm flow through her.

Occasionally, however, her client would meet her gaze, arching an eyebrow in challenge. Adora would gulp and look away. She did need to monitor their surroundings, after all.

Soon enough, ambient rumblings of conversation began to fill the air, and Adora could see a crowd gathering outside. More people moved across the stage, tapping microphones and plugging in amps, but no one questioned their presence, though one sound tech did politely ask Catra for a selfie.

Adora checked the time on her phone. "Isn't she supposed to start soon?"

"Yeah, but no one expects these things to start on time. As a performer, you have to give people that last bit of time to get to the stage – plus, an extra couple minutes of anticipation never hurts." Catra stretched her arms out above her head. "Shadow Weaver doesn't like that, though. She has all these ideas about what it means to be a proper pop star. It's exhausting."

Tierra Whack clearly didn't share those concerns, beginning her set a full fifteen minutes after it was scheduled. Judging from how enthusiastic the crowd was, however, it didn't seem like they cared.

After the show, Adora and Catra continued to roam through the festival, stopping to take pictures with fans when they recognized Catra. After this happened a couple times, Catra pulled her hood up. "I don't mind the fans – actually, it's pretty much the best part

of being famous," she told Adora. "But during the day or two before a show, it just feels like added pressure. *After* a show – well, after a good show – I could spend hours with them." While a few discerning festival-goers saw through her hood, most didn't give them a second glance.

When it got really crowded, Catra would take Adora's hand, leading her through the masses to their next destination. A small voice in her head that sounded a lot like Angella informed her that this wasn't very professional, but Adora didn't hear it offer any suggestions of other ways to make sure she stuck with her client in the crowd, so she elected to ignore it. And if she continued holding on for a bit even after they were through the worst of the throngs, well, she was just exercising due caution.

Every time they reached a new location, she would update Ms. Weaver. Her texts were a record of a day well spent: she and Catra had criss-crossed the festival, catching some artists that Catra knew and some that they just thought had funny or interesting names. Adora particularly enjoyed The 1975 – they had more in common with the music she listened to than the (admittedly quite talented) pop singers. And they did see Kacey Musgraves, if only so Adora could brag to Glimmer about it.

When they tired of the music, they would retreat to the performers' lounge, a secluded tent area with comfortable seating, no fans, and catered food.

"Why do I get the feeling that, even though we just saw some of the most popular musicians in the scene right now, this part is actually more exciting for you?"

Adora shrugged, her mouth stuffed to the brim with sweet potatoes. "Maybe," she said after she finished chewing, "because they have so much stuff here! And they make it all right in front of you! This is insane!"

Catra laughed. "You're ridiculous." She slurped her strawberry smoothie, which stood alone in front of her in sharp contrast to

Adora’s jam-packed plates.

Taking one final bite, Adora leaned back in her chair. “Wow. I could die happy right now.” She closed her eyes for a few moments, then opened them abruptly. “Actually, maybe I’ll do one final trip. How’s the smoothie?”

“Try it.” Catra slid it across the table, something like a challenge on her face. Adora’s face went slightly pink, but she took a sip nonetheless.

“Wow. Yeah, I’m getting a smoothie.” She stood up from the table and looked expectantly at Catra.

The pop star groaned. “Oh, come on. For real? We’re in a tent! They ID people at the door!” Adora crossed her arms. “Ugh. Fine, but I’m stealing some of your smoothie.” She stood up, following her bodyguard to the smoothie bar. “And let’s do a different kind. I’m bored of strawberry.”

…

Finally, it was time. They returned to their hotel suite, where Ms. Weaver awaited them.

“Catra, my dear.” The manager put a hand on the singer’s shoulder. “Remember, we have worked long and hard for this. I saw talent in you years ago, and you’ve since proven that talent to the world.” Her hand rose to Catra’s cheek. “Now prove it to them once more.”

Catra nodded resolutely before vanishing into the bathroom to change. Ms. Weaver turned to Adora. “Thank you for updating me on Catra’s whereabouts today. I don’t usually feel comfortable with her out and about, but knowing she’s with you makes me feel much more secure.”

“Of course, Ms. Weaver.”

“Come to my room when she’s ready and we’ll head over.” With that, Ms. Weaver glided out of the room.

…

“What do you think?”

Adora glanced up, and promptly froze.

Catra had finally emerged from the bathroom. She wore a dark red jacket around her shoulders and matching pants with small slits in them. The jacket was unzipped, revealing a black crop top and a bare midriff.

“Well?” Catra twirled around. Adora tried to answer, but her brain struggled to form a coherent response. She swallowed uncomfortably – her mouth was dry.

“G-good!” She forced out. With effort, she contorted her hand into a thumbs-up.

Catra smirked. “You okay?” Adora nodded up and down emphatically. “Good, cuz it’s almost time.” They walked over to Ms. Weaver’s room. Catra rapped against the door a couple times.

“Just a moment,” came Ms. Weaver’s voice. She sounded a bit strained. Catra and Adora exchanged glances. The door opened.

“Ready, girls?” Despite whatever they just heard, Ms. Weaver looked like her regular imposing self. She regarded Catra’s outfit. “A little risqué, don’t you think?” Catra met her stare without flinching, and Adora tensed up, ready for an argument to break out. But Ms. Weaver simply sighed. “I suppose that’s par for the course these days.” Her head shifted towards Adora. “Event security will handle stage divers and other such nuisances. But if anyone comes near Catra, I trust you will step in.”

“Yes, Ms. Weaver.”

“Wonderful. Now come. We do not want to leave the fans waiting.”

…

When she peeked out at the crowd, Adora couldn’t see the end of the mass of people. There were way more here than there had been to see Tierra Whack at the beginning of the day. Even though her job mostly boiled down to standing on the side of the stage and watching the performance, she still felt a bit nervous. More for Catra than herself.

The pop star, on the other hand, had started grinning as soon as they came within eyesight of the stage and hadn’t yet stopped. Standing next to Adora, she rubbed her hands together and bounced up and down lightly.

“You ready?” asked Adora. It felt a bit like a pointless question, but she couldn’t help herself.

Catra’s grin turned downright feral. “I was born ready.”

The lights turned down. The crowd roared.

“Here we go,” said Catra, turning to Adora. “Wish me luck.” She winked, then bounded onstage, a spotlight finding her almost the second she stepped out.

Adora’s eyes followed her client. “Good luck,” she murmured. She didn’t think Catra needed it.

“Hey everyone!” The crowd cheered in response. “How’s everyone doing tonight?” Another cheer. “Wonderful. I know it’s been a long day, and I appreciate all of you for staying. Now without further ado…Entrapta!” The lights flickered all sorts of different colors before settling on a rippling pattern of bright red as the first song began.

The pulsating bass underscored a high tempo melody. Catra stood stock-still in the center of the stage as the lights and the music

moved around her. She slowly raised the microphone to her lips.

It's hard to know who to trust in this day and age

Adora couldn't really focus on the words, because as soon as she started singing, Catra broke into dance. It seemed like a pretty complicated routine, with lots of side-to-side movements, and a surprising amount of saluting. Adora glanced at the crowd, only to have her quick look turn into a gape of wonder. A significant amount of people had formed a space in the center, mirroring Catra's movements.

Do you have what it takes
Will you hold when I break
Bring me peace when I ache
Be the real in this fake

Will you be my be my be my be my

Be my Force Captain

Adora wasn't sure what a Force Captain was, but she felt a sudden desire to be one. Or at least to learn the dance routine.

Catra's set continued. She danced across the stage effortlessly, her voice soaring through complex melodies without missing a note. Adora was awestruck. She'd never really listened to pop music, but this was…this was incredible. Catra exuded confidence; if she felt pressure from the thousands of people watching, it didn't show. Adora imagined trying to do her job with a bunch of onlookers, and involuntarily shuddered. She shook her head. *Incredible.*

Though the first couple songs were fast-paced dance hits, soon Catra switched it up, delving into what sounded more like an 80s power ballad.

We're on the edge of greatness
Turning darkness to light

Adora was glad she didn't really have any bodyguard duties during this concert. She wasn't sure she'd be able to concentrate on them. Her focus belonged entirely to Catra.

We must be strong
And we must be brave

Catra was a fantastic performer, Adora mused, for the same reason that she was an inconvenient person to bodyguard. She *demanded* attention. It wasn't just the eyes, or the ears, or the tail (though those certainly didn't hurt). It was her…everything. Her confident demeanor; her graceful movements; her beautiful singing; her mischievous grin; her sharp teeth that poked out of her mouth sometimes when she smiled; her lips—

We must be strong!

The end of the song snapped Adora out of her reverie. She blushed, glad that there was no one backstage to witness her. She really had to get a handle on these unprofessional feelings.

Oblivious to her bodyguard's inner turmoil, Catra launched into her next song. This one, from what Adora could glean from the lyrics, was about Catra's rise to fame.

I come in with the heat that could melt a glacier
watch this cat chase the spotlight like it's a laser

…

The set ended before Adora was ready for it to be over. The groans of the crowd told her that she wasn't the only one. Catra bounded offstage towards Adora.

"Catra, that was incredible!" Adora exclaimed.

Catra beamed, careening to a stop in front of her bodyguard. "You think so?"

Adora nodded emphatically. The crowd's general noises of discontent morphed into a cohesive chant. "One more song! One more song! One more song!"

Scratching her head, Catra looked back at the stage, hesitation clearly evident on her face.

"What do you think?" asked Adora.

"I mean, I don't want to leave them wanting. But that was my set. Shadow Weaver is super strict about not doing anything unplanned, and I don't really have any other songs anyway. Not ones they would know." She sighed. The chants grew louder. Suddenly, her head perked up. "Actually, you know what?" Before Adora could respond, she ran back onto the stage. The crowd roared in response.

Catra grabbed the microphone. "So, I don't usually do encores." The mass of people somehow got even louder. Adora smirked; Catra had them in the palm of her hand. "But I really appreciate you guys turning out tonight. I know that when you bought tickets for this festival, you thought you were going to see Ariana Grande, not me. And you guys have been more than welcoming to me. I'm very thankful." As the crowd cheered, she turned to say something to a sound tech. She wasn't speaking into the mic, so Adora only heard a snippet – something about finding a karaoke version? "But I know, deep down, you all wanted a chance to dance to this song. So let's do it." She gestured to the sound tech, and soon the familiar notes of a song Adora *knew* Glimmer had shown her started playing.

Breakfast at Tiffany's and bottles of bubbles
Girls with tattoos who like getting in trouble

The crowd was nearly beside themselves with excitement, yelling along to the words and dancing as best they could given how tightly packed they were. Catra strutted across the stage as she sang; Adora couldn't take her eyes off her.

I want it, I got it, I want it, I got it
I want it, I got it, I want it, I got it

Catra's roaming brought her to Adora's side of the stage, and the pop star met her eyes briefly, a smirk flashing across her face as she sang the lines. Adora's knees felt weak.

You like my tail? Gee thanks, don't touch it
I see it, I like it, I want it, I got it

By the time the song was over, Adora was having serious doubts about her professional integrity.

The crowd's cheering rose from thunderous to downright deafening as Catra took a bow. The pop star reveled in the noise for a moment, raising her hands above her head and closing her eyes. Then, with a final wave, she ran across the stage towards Adora. Adora's smile quickly turned to panic as she realized Catra didn't intend on stopping.

"Adora! Did you see that?!!" Catra launched herself into the air, throwing her arms around Adora's neck. All thoughts of professionalism scattered to the wind, Adora embraced her client.

"That was amazing, Catra," she said. "I've never seen anything like it. That was incredible."

"You think so?"

Adora tightened her hold. "I know so. Just listen to them."

Catra lingered in the hug for a long moment before finally pulling back, a wide smile on her face. "Adora," she began. "When you were—"

Harsh footsteps from behind Adora cut her off. When Catra looked at their source, her face paled. "Ms. Weav—"

"*What* were you thinking?"

“I was thinking I would put on a great show for these people,” replied Catra, defensive. “Did you hear how loud they were cheering? They loved it!”

Ms. Weaver ignored her. “One,” she said, her voice flat and quick, “You performed an encore without permission. I created your set list with a specific intent. Every song is in a specific place. Not only that, but the venue wasn’t planning on you doing an encore. These decisions need to be made ahead of time, not in the moment.” Catra opened her mouth to protest, but Ms. Weaver silenced her with a wave of her hand. “I am *not* finished.” Her voice reverberated with barely contained fury. “Two. You performed a cover song without permission. If the venue didn’t have the proper forms in, we could’ve had a lawsuit on our hands. Three. You performed a cover song as the last song of your set. Do you want that to be people’s last memory of your concert? We are trying to make a mark on this industry, on this *world*, and you would throw that all away for some cheap applause.” She slammed a fist against the side of the stage, nearly decapitating a nearby sound tech. “I am beyond disappointed. Now come with me. We are going back to the hotel."

…

The walk back had been silent and tense, despite the enduring noise from the crowd. Even though the festival had officially ended, it sounded like it would be a while before the party stopped. Catra kept her head down as they walked back, but every so often her tail would swish back and forth at a stray cheer.

When they got back to the room, she flopped onto the bed. “Ugh! She makes me so angry!” At Adora’s sympathetic look, she continued. “The crowd loved the show, and they loved the cover! It’s just *her* who can’t be pleased by *anything* I do!”

Adora sat down next to her on the bed, putting a comforting hand on her back. “The show was unbelievably good, Catra. I’m sure

Ms. Weaver will come around. She just has really high standards for you."

"She better." Catra sighed. "Well, whatever! I feel so good right now, even Shadow Weaver can't bring me down." She jumped up, seemingly revitalized. "Let's go out there! Seeing the fans literally always makes me feel better. And I want to photobomb as many people as I can."

Adora laughed, following her client to the door. *Going out to take some pics with fans*, she messaged Ms. Weaver as they descended in the hotel elevator.

Her phone buzzed as soon as she put it back in her pocket. *Absolutely not. Too much of a security risk – who knows what kind of people came to this festival, and what kind of drunken nonsense they'll attempt? Return to the room immediately.*

"Uh, Catra?"

"What is it, dearest bodyguard?" Catra leaned against the wall of the elevator, nonchalant.

"I think Ms. Weaver wants us to go back to the room. She says it's not safe to go out there."

Catra laughed. "Shadow Weaver doesn't think anything is safe. Relax! What she doesn't know won't hurt her."

Adora felt a sinking feeling in her stomach. "She, uh, does know."

Catra stared at her for a moment. "What do you mean?" The door opened to the lobby, but neither of them moved.

"I told her."

Catra blinked twice. "Like just now?" Adora held up her phone. Catra's eyes widened. Before Adora could react, she snatched the phone from her bodyguard's grip. Her face turned into a scowl as

she scrolled through the messages. “So you’ve been doing this the whole day, huh?” Her tone was dangerously calm.

“Catra, I—”

“So everything I do or don’t do is decided by Shadow Weaver. Through you.”

“Catra—”

“You *saw* how horrible she is. You just saw it! You saw how much shit she makes me deal with to match up to her impossible standards and now you’re just…helping her!” Adora saw the beginnings of tears in Catra’s eyes.

“Catra, I’m sorry. I didn’t think that—”

“No, I’m sorry. I forgot, for a moment, that you’re just another tool for Shadow Weaver to control me with.” Catra glared at her. “It won’t happen again.” She punched their floor number, and the doors closed again. She crossed her arms, staring straight in front of her.

It was the longest elevator ride of Adora’s life.

On the way back to the room, she tried to say something. Anything. To apologize -- but how could she apologize for doing her job? But if she had just been doing her job, why did she feel like she had done something wrong? She should say something, she resolved. But every time she looked at Catra, the words died in her mouth.

An uncomfortable silence hung in the air as they readied themselves for bed. Adora changed into her pajamas and slipped under the covers as close to one side of the bed as she could. When she woke up the next morning, her feet were cold.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you to everyone who has stuck with this fic so far! :)

PS I'm always happy to discuss the story or She-ra or anything either here or on my tumblr (flowerdressedtoimpress).

Fashion Genius

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Things had been a little tense at Hordak since Princess Fest (or since the '7 ringscident,' as Adora had overheard Lonnie call it in a conversation with Scorpia). Ms. Weaver was upset with Catra, Catra was upset with Ms. Weaver *and* Adora, and Adora was… Adora was confused.

"I don't know what to do," she confided to Bow and Glimmer over brunch one day. Perhaps picking up on the fact that Catra had barely said a word to Adora since the festival, Ms. Weaver had given her the weekend off. She welcomed the reprieve; while Adora was still confident in her ability to protect her client, it had been a lot more fun when Catra was speaking to her. "She hardly even looks at me anymore. But I can't ignore a request from Ms. Weaver! She's my boss!"

"I'm still not over the fact that you went to Princess Fest," grumbled Glimmer, taking a long slurp of her iced coffee. "Bow and I tried so hard to get tickets."

Bow nodded sadly. "We were ready, too. I had the website up on my computer the day before they went on sale. But by the time we got out of class, they were sold out. If it weren't for freaking Professor Blossom and his insane no-laptop rule, we could have been there." He wiped away a fake tear from his eye. Well, Adora was pretty sure it was fake. Bow could get carried away sometimes.

Adora laughed. "It *was* pretty fun," she said. "Catra showed me so many cool artists. And I told you I saw Kacey Musgraves, right?"

"Yes, you told me." Glimmer took the angriest bite of French toast that Adora had ever seen anyone take. "It's fine, it's fine. I'm

happy for you, really. I just missed out on her last tour, and now this, and—"

Bow put a hand over Glimmer's. "We'll see her one day. We have to believe that." She nodded resolutely. "So, why don't you just apologize to Catra, Adora? You clearly feel bad about it. She can't be mad at you for doing your job."

"Oh, believe me, she can," said Adora through a mouthful of hash browns. "And she has good reason to! Ms. Weaver controls so much of her life already. And I thought I was just signing on to be a bodyguard, but it seems like I'm also another avenue for her to do that. She has every right to be upset. But I can't disobey an order from the person who hired me!"

"Still," said Bow. "You can at least tell her that you're sorry about the situation. I mean, I don't know what she's like. But I think that would help."

"What *is* she like?" asked Glimmer. "It's still so crazy that you're working for her. I mean, she has her own Wikipedia page and everything. What is she like in person?"

Adora tilted her head thoughtfully, swallowing a rather impressive amount of scrambled eggs before answering. "She's…she's really cool, honestly. I mean, she's *so* talented. Her singing voice is absolutely incredible. And she's so confident, too. Going out in front of all those people and performing? I was nervous just being backstage, but she was having the time of her life. But at the same time, she's not stuck up at all. She's funny, and really fun to talk to, and she's actually super nice to me." Adora grimaced. "Or she was, at least, before I messed it all up." She was halfway through her next bite of eggs and potatoes before she noticed the amused expressions Bow and Glimmer were giving her. "What?"

They exchanged glances. "Sounds like *someone*," said Bow, a big smile on his face, "has a bit of a crush."

Adora reddened. “What?! No, I just admire her talent! And I appreciate that she treats me like a person instead of a hireling.”

“Whatever you say,” said Glimmer with a smirk. “She is pretty attractive though, don’t you think?”

Adora glared at her, her face coming closer and closer to the color of the ketchup spread across her food. “I don’t—I mean, yeah, I guess, like, objectively, but—”

Her friends laughed. “Sorry for teasing,” said Bow, not sounding very sorry. “I think it’s cute that you regard your client so highly.”

“I don’t get what her manager is so mad about, anyway,” Glimmer offered, thankfully providing a change in topic. “Someone posted a video of the 7 rings cover and it already has twenty million views. *Ariana Grande* retweeted it. How is that a bad thing?”

Adora shook her head. “I don’t know. Catra said that Ms. Weaver has a very particular set of standards. She doesn’t want Catra to be known for cover songs, and there was this thing with licensing – honestly, it’s a little over my head.” She looked at the remnants of Glimmer’s French toast, which the pink-haired girl was pushing around unenthusiastically. “Are you going to finish that?”

“All yours.” Glimmer pushed her plate across the table. “Well, I wish we had better advice. It sounds like you’re in a bit of a bind.”

“I still think you should apologize,” said Bow. “Or maybe buy her some ice cream! It’s hard to stay mad at someone who buys you ice cream.”

Adora snorted. “Did you miss the part where she’s a famous singer who can buy anything she wants?” She doused Glimmer’s plate in syrup. “I just hope she cheers up soon. We’re going to the mall on Friday. Apparently she and Ms. Weaver have this agreement that one Friday a month she gets to go on an excursion.”

“And she wants to go to the mall?” asked Glimmer incredulously.

Adora shrugged. “Your guess is as good as mine.”

“Excuse me?” Their waiter stood next to their table, a slightly queasy expression on his face. “I have an order of the pickled jalapeño grits with garlic?”

Glimmer nodded, then visibly gagged as the waiter put the plate on the table. “Thank you,” she managed to force out. She pushed it towards Adora.

“Oh my god,” said Bow. “Adora, you do *not* have to eat that. I mean, I know we got it with the express purpose of making you eat it. But…oh my god. I can smell it from here.”

Adora picked the bowl up, sniffing it cautiously. “Doesn’t seem too bad,” she mused. She dipped her spoon in, chewed tentatively, and swallowed. “Huh. The grits actually balance out a lot of the spiciness really well. Besides,” she said, grinning at the looks of horror on her friends’ faces, “if I back down from one of these challenges, you guys will stop buying me food!”

“Oh, Adora.” Glimmer shook her head. “You really, really, frighten me sometimes.”

…

When she got back to Hordak the next morning, Catra was splayed out on her plush beanbag, lying upside down on her back, her legs hooked over the top of it and her head barely off the ground. Adora snorted. At least some things hadn’t changed. She’d honestly be a little worried if she saw Catra sleeping like a normal person.

Catra opened her left eye briefly, then closed it. “You’re back,” she said matter-of-factly.

“Yes! Hi!” exclaimed Adora. She put her bag down on one of the stools, then lingered, unsure of what to do next.

“Fun weekend?” asked Catra, eyes still closed. Her voice was rather flat, but she was talking to Adora, so the blonde counted it as a win.

“My life is pretty boring when I’m not at work, to be honest. But I did get to see my friends, which was nice. Bow and Glimmer – I’ve mentioned them to you before.”

Catra grunted. After a few moments, Adora realized no further response would be forthcoming. She shifted her weight from foot to foot.

“Hey,” she began. “Are we—”

“No.” Catra finally opened her eyes to meet Adora's. “We’re not cool, if that’s what you’re asking.” They regarded each other in silence for a few moments. “But,” the pop star continued begrudgingly, “it’s been kind of lonely not talking to anyone. So we’re not…not cool.”

Adora nodded tentatively. “I’ll take it.” She smiled at her client, who rolled her eyes before shutting them again. Adora noticed Catra’s tail flick back and forth, though, and felt a certain warmth bubble up inside her.

…

The week went by quickly. It was less painfully awkward now that Catra was talking to her again, but her client still wasn’t as friendly as she had been when Adora first started. Their conversations were more one-sided, and sometimes Catra would retreat up to her loft, leaving Adora to sit at the counter and twiddle her thumbs, ostensibly ready to fight any intruders who managed to get into the elevator. At least Entrapta had put a couple of games on her Hordak phone.

To alleviate some of the boredom, she had taken to sorting Catra’s fanmail, which Scorpia delivered in a big box (and with an even bigger smile) every couple of days. Generally they fell into two

categories – heartfelt messages from younger fans and rather over-the-top love letters from older ones.

"We have a form response that gets sent to anyone who writes," Catra told her when she asked about it. "I think Scorpia is in charge of it. But when I have time, I like to respond. Especially when they're from little kids. Sometimes they send me pictures they draw – it's adorable."

Soon, Adora discovered a third category: homemade baked goods that they had no way of knowing what ingredients were in and other potentially dangerous gifts. She and Catra argued for fifteen minutes about a set of admittedly impressive Catra-shaped cookies before the pop star agreed not to eat them. ("They look like me, Adora! When am I going to have another chance to eat something that looks like me!")

Despite these conflicts, Adora felt like her client was warming back up to her throughout the week. The upcoming mall trip helped with that – Catra seemed to be in a better and better mood as Friday grew closer.

"Why do you want to go to the mall so badly, anyway?" Adora asked Thursday night, as the two lay on the floor of the penthouse, watching the last moments of sunlight fade from the sky. "I mean, you're a celebrity. I would have figured you had your own personal shopper or something like that."

Catra scoffed. "As if I could trust anyone else to pick out clothes for me. No one takes tails into consideration! But honestly, it's less about buying clothes and more just kind of fun to pretend to be a normal person for a bit. To just walk around, look through stores, eat from a food court…normal teen stuff." She glanced over at Adora. "I'm guessing they didn't really do mall trips at military school?"

Adora chuckled. "No, not really. But I've been with Bow and Glimmer a few times. I don't really like shopping, though. I'm pretty basic with the clothes I wear."

“I hadn’t noticed.” Catra smirked, then shrieked as Adora leaned over and shoved her playfully. “Bodyguard! Bodyguard! I’m being attacked!” They pushed back and forth for a few moments before agreeing to a wordless truce, laughing and lying back down, their shoulders barely brushing against each other’s. “Well, we’ll have to change that. I happen to be a bit of a fashion genius, you know.”

“Really,” said Adora. Catra stuck her tongue out. “I guess I’ll have to see this genius in action, then.”

…

Fashion genius, Adora discovered, involved Adora carrying a *lot* of clothes around. Every time she thought her client had finished picking out things for them to try on, Catra would pile on one more cute top, skirt, jumpsuit, or other item onto her outstretched arms. By the time they reached the fitting room, Adora could barely see over the garments.

“In here,” Catra directed her. The pop star was in her trademark incognito outfit, wide-legged jeans hiding her tail and a beanie and sunglasses covering her more remarkable facial features. Ms. Weaver had sighed when she saw the singer’s garb, but simply told them that the driver would pick them up at 10 precisely, and not to be late. While Adora thought Catra still looked pretty eye-catching, so far no one had recognized her.

With a grunt, Adora deposited the clothes on the small bench inside the booth. When she looked up, Catra had already taken her hat and sunglasses off, and was starting to remove her shirt.

“H-Hey!” sputtered Adora.

Catra paused with her shirt halfway over her head. “What? I’m not gonna put them on over my clothes.” She continued her movement, and Adora turned around to look at the door, only to find to her alarm a full-length mirror hanging from it. Her eyes met Catra’s in the reflection and her face rapidly reddened. She

turned sharply and concentrated very hard on the corner of the room. Catra laughed. “I have a bra on, you know. I’m not getting naked in a department store.”

“That’s still not – I’m not – I’m going to wait outside,” rushed Adora. She slipped out quickly and collapsed with relief onto one of the chairs in the waiting area.

“You’re ridiculous, you know that?” Catra’s voice, laced with amusement, lofted over the door. “I guess I’ll have to model each outfit individually.”

Despite her reservations about voyeurism, Adora found herself actually quite enjoying the experience. Catra would come out every couple of minutes or so with a new look – sometimes long, elegant dresses, other times sensible combinations of shirts and skirts or pants, and once, memorably, a dark crimson suit with an untied bowtie.

“What do you think?” Catra said with a twirl. “Kinda my style, don’t you think?”

Adora nodded emphatically and gulped. Why was her mouth so dry?

Finally, Catra came out back in her jeans and beanie, carrying most of the clothes in her arms. “Well, that was fun. I’m gonna go put these back real quick.”

“You’re not going to get anything?” asked Adora incredulously.

Catra shrugged. “There were a couple tops I liked, I think I’ll get those. But the real fun is just trying everything on.”

“You should get the suit,” Adora blurted out. She flushed. “I mean, if you want to.”

Catra gazed back at her. “You think?” she asked, a certain shyness in her tone that Adora wasn’t used to.

“Yeah,” Adora said. “I do.”

Maybe it was a trick of the light, but Catra’s face looked a little pinker than usual. “Okay,” she said. A grin spread across her face. “I did look pretty killer in it, didn’t I. And awards season is right around the corner.”

When Catra returned after dumping her massive pile in the return section, holding the relatively small selection of purchases under her arm, Adora stood up, ready to move on to their next destination. They had less than an hour left before Ms. Weaver’s deadline. But Catra wagged a finger at her.

“Not so fast, hotshot. You haven’t tried anything on yet! I know you’re all about plain, functional looks, but I left a couple outfit options in there I think you might like. If wearing more than two colors at once doesn’t short-circuit your brain, that is.”

“Ha ha.” Adora rolled her eyes. “I don’t know if that’s the best idea, though. I mean, what if something happens?”

“Oh my godddd,” groaned Catra. “I’ll be like ten feet away from you. I’ll be sure to scream if anyone tries to kidnap me.” Seeing Adora hesitate, she stepped forward, a smirk on her face and a hint of challenge in her voice. “I can always just go inside with you if you’re worried.”

Adora fought the redness in her cheeks that seemed to be a persistent factor of this mall trip. Separating herself from her client even in this seemingly minuscule way went against a lot of her bodyguard instincts, but she knew saying so would bring all the tension that had been slowly ebbing from their relationship right back to the forefront. She huffed. “I guess you’ll be fine waiting outside, then.” Catra plopped herself down on the chair and Adora entered the room.

While Adora didn’t doubt Catra’s fashion acumen, she was still surprised by how much she liked the pop star’s suggestions. The outfits Catra left in the room were more reserved than the ones

she had modeled for Adora. Swiveling in front of the mirror, she admired the designs on an elegant, and ridiculously soft, black sweater that fit her almost perfectly. She turned around to examine the price tag.

Oof.

Still, though. As Catra said, it was fun just to try things on. She pushed the door open. "Well? I mean, it's three times as expensive as it should be, but I actually really like it."

No response came. The chair was empty, the clothes Catra wanted to purchase lying next to it.

"Catra?" Adora looked right and left. Nothing but a rather bored looking employee glued to his phone. She walked over to him. "Hey, did you see the girl I was with – did she go anywhere?"

"Huh?" He looked up. "I didn't see anything, sorry."

"Ugh!" Adora stomped her foot, causing the employee to jump. She walked past him, breaking into a run as she scanned the floor. There were a decent amount of people in the store, but she didn't see Catra's bushy hair or purple beanie. As she ran out of the store, the alarm started blaring. Crap – she hadn't taken the sweater off. "Sorry!" she yelled at the workers who had started peering over in curiosity. "I'll come back, I promise!"

Adora ran towards the escalators, panic building within her. The mall was humongous – looking out across it, there were dozens of routes that someone could take to exit, dozens of stores they could lose her in. "Catra?" she shouted, receiving only a few confused looks in response. "Think, Adora," she muttered to herself. She hadn't heard any signs of a struggle. And famous as Catra was, it's not like anyone knew they were going to this mall. The most likely scenario was that Catra just left of her own accord. But why would she do something like that? And where would she go?

Just then, she heard a familiar voice carry across from the other side of the mall. Adora's head shot up. Catra's bushy hair bobbed up and down – it looked like she was talking to someone.

Relief flooded her, but anger quickly replaced it. Adora stalked over around the perimeter of the mall, her frown deepening. Catra *knew* she wasn't supposed to do things like this. Which probably supplied the motivation for her to do so.

Catra's sunglasses and beanie were off, and she had her arm around a visibly emotional adolescent. They were posing for a picture, Adora realized, seeing an older woman holding up her phone to capture the moment. As she grew closer, she could make out the words of their conversation.

"Yeah, I love bubble tea! Taro's my favorite flavor, what's yours?"

"I love taro too!" the girl squeaked, a huge smile across her face.

Catra grinned. "I knew you had good taste. I mean, you like my music, after all."

The girl and the older woman, who Adora assumed was her mom, broke into laughter. "I seriously can't believe I met you. My friends are gonna go crazy. We're like your biggest fans. I can't believe you're just at a mall! Do you come here often? Doesn't it get crazy?"

Catra chuckled. "Not often, but when I get the chance. And believe it or not, you're the first person to see through my disguise today." She slipped her beanie back on. "Now, it's been lovely to meet you, Rebecca, but I think I see my bodyguard standing over there, and she doesn't look happy. So I'll have to say goodbye for now, but I hope we'll meet again someday."

The girl, apparently named Rebecca, nodded vigorously. "I'll be at your next show! Right mom? Please?"

The mom patted her head. "We'll see, honey." She sent an appreciative look at Catra. "Thank you for your time, dear." The

two walked away, Rebecca turning back to look at Catra every few seconds as if to confirm that she really met her.

Catra turned towards Adora, taking a long sip of a purple drink in her hand. "Nice sweater. Want some bubble tea?" she asked. Adora glared at her, wordless. Catra at least had the grace to look a little remorseful. "I'm sorry, okay? I just wanted to get a drink."

"You could have waited for me. Or, I don't know, told me where you were going. Instead of just *vanishing* without a sign."

Catra rolled her eyes. "What's the big deal? We're in a shopping center, for god's sake, not a warzone. I went to get a drink and got held up when a fan recognized me. It's not the end of the world."

Adora folded her arms. "I'm your bodyguard," she said. "Where you go, I go. Do you know how worried I was when I stepped out of the fitting room and you weren't there? I thought something happened to you! I ran out – I set the alarm off! You *can't do* things like that. Do you understand?"

Now, it was Catra's turn to glare. "Do *you* understand how suffocating it is to have to check in with someone when I want to do literally *anything*? I'm nineteen! I can't even go to the bathroom without you waiting outside!"

"Because that's my job!" yelled Adora. People were starting to give them odd looks, but she paid them no mind. "It's literally my job! I'm sorry that me being around you is such a burden, but my job is to keep you safe! Or did you forget what happened a couple weeks ago?"

Catra opened her mouth, then closed it. Her eyes narrowed. "Whatever."

Adora felt her stomach turn. This was not how she wanted the day to go. She glanced at her watch. 9:41. "We should go buy the clothes you want," she said. "It's almost time to meet the driver."

Catra nodded curtly and walked past her, head down. They paid for her purchases – Adora put the sweater back, apologizing again to the mostly bemused employees – and waited outside in silence for the car to come.

"Hey." Catra crossed her arms, not meeting Adora's eyes. "Are you…going to tell Shadow Weaver? About me…you know."

Adora turned to look at her, not speaking until Catra matched her gaze. "No," she said finally. "I should, but I won't. I know how she is with you."

"Thank you. I…I appreciate that." Catra looked like she was going to say something else, but she turned away.

Despite that, the tension remained on the ride home, Catra staring out the window resolutely as they traveled back to Hordak. Adora felt a mix of emotions run through her. She still felt angry. Catra had manipulated her into letting her guard down and then purposefully ditched her. But she couldn't help but feel sympathy for her client. Knowing how controlling Ms. Weaver could be, it made sense that Catra would rail against it. She sighed. Bodyguarding wasn't supposed to be this emotionally charged.

…

The silence continued after they got back to the penthouse and got ready for bed. Adora smiled for a moment as she opened her drawers – she really did have pretty basic clothing. For all her complaints and unruly behavior, Catra paid more attention to Adora then most people did. She turned to look at her client. Catra was brushing her teeth, tilting her head to get the right angle to clean her extraordinarily sharp incisors. Adora felt a rush of softness inside her. She didn't want to go back to the silent treatment. But, she realized as Catra brushed past her without meeting her eyes, that wasn't her decision to make.

Adora slipped under her covers with little enthusiasm. She never had much luck finding sleep when her mind wasn't at peace. After

a half hour or so of restlessness, however, she heard a soft thump, and felt a weight at the bottom of her bed.

"Adora?" Catra's voice sounded tentative. Adora sat up. She could barely see her client in the darkness.

"Yeah?"

"I'm…I'm sorry, for ditching you. I know that wasn't cool. And I know it's not your fault that I need a bodyguard, or that I'm not allowed do anything by myself. I just get so frustrated sometimes. And I guess I took it out on you. So…I'm sorry."

Adora felt the remnants of her anger slip away as if they had never been there. "Thank you," she said. "And I'm sorry too. I never apologized, for what I did at Princess Fest. I know that really made you upset."

"You were just doing your job," replied Catra, a bit too quickly.

Adora shook her head, then realized Catra probably couldn't see her. "I was. But I still hurt you. And I felt like I did my job tonight, without telling Shadow Weaver about your brief adventure."

"Why didn't you tell her?" Catra asked hesitantly. "I mean, don't get me wrong, I'm really grateful. I probably wouldn't be able to leave this building for a month. But…what changed?"

"Well, I've been thinking," Adora said slowly. "Shadow Weaver may be the one paying me, but my job is to protect *you*. And, not to brag, but I'm a good bodyguard, and I can do that without reporting to her on your every activity. So in situations like this, where she's not going to find out unless I tell her, I'm okay making the judgment call that it's not information she needs to know."

Catra didn't respond for a moment. Then, a solid blur flashed in front of her. There was suddenly a body pressed against hers, and two arms wrapped around her tightly.

“Thank you,” whispered Catra. Adora raised her arms and returned the embrace. They stayed like that for a long moment. Adora’s cheek brushed against Catra’s, and she was surprised to find that it was more than a little damp. “Sorry,” Catra murmured. “I just…” Adora squeezed harder.

Finally, Catra pulled back. By now Adora’s eyes had adjusted more to the dark, and she could see most of her client’s features in front of her. “How’s this,” Adora offered. “I’ll promise to give you more leeway when I can and not automatically report everything to Shadow Weaver, and you promise me not to ditch me again.”

Catra nodded. “Deal,” she said. Still essentially in Adora’s lap, she made no move to leave from her position. “I guess I’ll, uh, go back to my loft now.”

“You don’t have to.” The words were out of Adora’s mouth before she realized it. She was having an impulsive day. “I mean, if you don’t want to. I mean – you can sleep wherever you want. Um. I’m just going to shut my mouth now.”

Catra giggled. “You’re ridiculous.” She slid backwards, and for a second Adora thought that she indeed intended to climb the stairs back to her own bed. Instead, the pop star curled into a ball in next to Adora’s legs. “Move around as much as you want to,” she told Adora. “I’ll adjust.” Adora slid back underneath the covers, and Catra maneuvered herself into the crook of her legs. “Goodnight Adora.”

Adora smiled to herself. “Goodnight Catra.” In no time at all, she was fast asleep.

…

When Adora woke up the next morning, Catra was snoring softly, her chest moving up and down steadily. She had migrated slightly upwards, sprawling sideways across the bed, her head buried in the blanket next to Adora’s torso.

If she wasn’t careful, Adora could get used to waking up like this.

She sat up, gently pulling her legs out from underneath Catra. Military school and bodyguarding didn’t really allow for lingering in bed long after waking, and Adora had firmly ingrained those instincts. Walking gingerly across the apartment – her legs had fallen asleep beneath her client’s body – she gazed out at the city under the newly risen sun before turning to the kitchen table. With all the excitement about the mall trip, she hadn’t had the chance to go through the box of fanmail Scorpia delivered yesterday.

Grabbing a yogurt from the fridge, she sifted through the pile casually. Most seemed pretty innocuous letters, though one came in a bright red envelope sealed with a lipstick kiss. Adora snorted, trying to imagine the kind of person that sent it. Did they honestly think it would win them Catra's affections? She put it aside and delved further into the box. Near the bottom, she felt a rather thick envelope, which she pulled out to examine.

The letter had no return address, which was pretty unusual. Most people wrote to Catra with at least the hope of a response. She pried the flap open with her finger and peered inside at the contents curiously.

Uh oh.

Chapter End Notes

> I'm alive! Sorry it's been such a long time since the last update. It's been a hectic past few months, but I made it through - I try not to go into very much personal detail online, but just know that a major milestone has been achieved :)
>
> Anyway, I hope you like how this story is progressing! Yes, the suit is Catra's princess prom outfit -- I couldn't resist. I'll be away for the next two weeks, but once I get back I will be hard at work on chapter 8. And as always, I'm happy to discuss details about this story here or on tumblr (or if you like yugioh lmao): flowerdressedtoimpress.

Thank you for reading!

Lawless

Chapter Summary

A threatening letter. An approaching deadline. A new challenger.

Chapter Notes

Previously on Chasing the Spotlight:

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response. She pried the flap open with her finger and peered inside at the contents curiously.

Uh oh.

My dearest Catra, it's an honor. I'm your biggest fan
I have some questions to exchange for some answers if I can
I'd love to see the vocal cords your voice travels through
if your eyes keep their color when I cut them out of you
if your tail keeps on twitching when I slice off your head
if your ears still perk up when your body is dead
it's so rare to find things that can thrill me like that
so call me curiosity; I might kill me a cat

Lonnie put the letter down. "Jesus Christ."

Adora nodded grimly. "And look at the photographs that came with it," she said, pushing a few of the dozens of pictures that had accompanied the threatening words across the granite counter to the chief of security. Lonnie held them up to her face, her frown deepening. They were pictures of Catra — at concerts, at fanmeets, out on the street — with one common theme: in every photo, the pop star's eyes were scratched out.

"Jesus Christ," Lonnie repeated. "We've had stalkers before, but…"

"But nothing this extreme," Ms. Weaver finished, pacing back and forth beside the counter. "And you said this came in the mail today?"

"Probably a day or two ago." Adora rifled through the photos. "But this has been going on for some time. I'm not in that many of them, and I've been pretty much glued to her side for the past couple weeks. Most of them must be from before I started working here."

Lonnie grabbed one of the pictures. "This one — I recognize that background. This is from a benefit concert she participated in

back in the fall. November I think. Which means this has been going on for *at least* six months."

"We should go to the police," said Adora. Her pulse was racing. Who would write a message like this? What kind of sick fascination did they have with Catra?

Ms. Weaver shook her head. "The police are useless. Blithering fools who care more about following protocol than catching criminals. We must increase our own security forces. In the meantime, we need to be more careful than ever with Catra. No more trips to the mall or other... *excursions*." Her head swiveled towards Adora, and the bodyguard knew Ms. Weaver was referencing her and Catra going to Chipotle. It seemed so long ago now.

"Speaking of Catra," said Lonnie. "What do we tell her about all this?"

"What do we tell me about what?"

Adora jumped. Catra stood at the end of the counter with her arms crossed. Her gaze flicked from Lonnie to Ms. Weaver before finally settling on Adora.

"Well, uh," began Adora, "Nothing to worry about! Just a, uh, letter from a fan that's a bit…extreme…"

"Another stalker?" Catra walked over to the refrigerator and grabbed a green apple, taking a large bite before sitting down languidly at the counter. "How frightening."

Adora and Lonnie exchanged glances. "This one's a little different, Catra," said Lonnie.

The pop star rolled her eyes. "What, did they cut out letters from a magazine to write their message? Does it say that they can't live without me? Did they—" she threw up her hands in mock horror—"did they go to one of my concerts and take pictures of me?!" She dramatically collapsed on the ground, then hopped up lithely, a

mischievous grin on her face. "Chill out, guys. This stuff happens all the time."

Adora tried to look reassuring, but the dread twisting in her stomach must have worked its way up to her face, because Catra's smile faded as she examined Adora's expression.

"What? Don't tell me you guys are actually taking this seriously."

"There are few issues more serious than your safety," Ms. Weaver proclaimed. She beckoned Catra to look at the pictures laid out on the table. Rolling her eyes, Catra moved over, then guffawed loudly at the photographs in front of her.

"Really? They scratched my eyes out? What do they think this is, Criminal Minds?" As she flipped through the images, however, her mood sobered. "They've been doing this for a long time, huh." Her hands stopped on a particular picture of her — Catra and Adora walking through the park outside Hordak. "This one is from the first day you started working here. When we went to get burritos. Remember?" Adora nodded. "There's no way they would have known we would do that ahead of time. Which means this person must have just been hanging around Hordak, waiting for me to come out." Catra's tone remained steady, but her tail flicked back and forth quickly as she talked.

"I'm glad you can appreciate the severity of the situation." Ms. Weaver strode over and plucked the letter from the countertop in front of Lonnie. "They also included a death threat, in case you have any doubts about what level of response this requires."

Catra snatched the letter and scanned it quickly. Her eyes widened, and Adora moved a step closer to her, but when she lifted her head, there was a grin on her face. "Well, I wish they paid more attention to meter, but that's at least more creative than cutting out letters from a magazine." The speed of her tail flicking heightened, however, and her smile did not linger.

"So," Lonnie ventured, breaking the uneasy silence that had settled over the room. "What do we do now?"

"We go on lockdown." Ms. Weaver's voice carried an unusual intensity. "I'm hiring more security, but until we find who this maniac is, Catra is not allowed outside of Hordak. It's simply too dangerous. Do you understand, Catra?"

"No, I don't!" retorted Catra. "I get that we should be worried, but I have Adora. And I'm not just going to stay in one building. That's ridiculous."

"Yes, you most certainly are." Ms. Weaver stalked over to stand in front of Catra, staring down at her. "You are in *danger*, Catra. Someone is threatening to *kill* you. Until we can properly evaluate the risks and how we can best protect you, you're not going anywhere."

Seeing Catra open her mouth to protest, Adora stepped between them. "I agree with Ms. Weaver, Catra." The pop star looked at her in shock, and Adora felt a tinge of guilt, but continued. "This person has been surveilling you from a distance for a long time. If they came up close, I'd be confident in my ability to protect you. But what if they shoot you? What if they try to run you over? I'm just one person. I think, for now at least, it's best to be cautious."

Catra slumped. "I guess you're right." She turned back to Ms. Weaver with fire in her eyes. "But *don't* try to keep me locked in here forever."

Ms. Weaver nodded. "We will handle the situation as quickly as possible." She stepped away from her young protégé and moved towards the elevator, beckoning Lonnie to join her. Before she stepped in, though, she turned around. "On the bright side, perhaps this will give you some time to work on your new album. I know it's been a little...stagnant for a while." Catra simply glared in response. Her manager sighed. "I know it's a sore subject, but we can't delay it forever. I'll talk with you tomorrow about how we can move forward."

With that, she and Lonnie stepped into the elevator, the security chief quirking her eyebrows to Adora as the doors closed. Adora turned to Catra, who was still staring at the elevator.

"You okay?" she asked, unsure of where exactly she stood with the pop star. Catra slid into one of the chairs around the counter and put her head down. When she didn't respond immediately, Adora sat down beside her. "It's okay if you're not. I know this is super scary." Catra remained silent, and Adora rested her hand lightly on Catra's arm. They stayed like that for a long moment. Finally, Catra raised her head.

"I just..." Catra's voice wavered slightly. "Sometimes, I wish I didn't have to deal with any of this. I wish I looked normal. I wish I was just some random girl who wasn't famous and worked a regular 9 to 5 job where no one knew who I was." She locked eyes with Adora. Hers looked watery, but her cheeks were dry. "But I'm not. So I'm just going to have to deal with it." She started gathering up all the pictures that were on the table. "I'm not going to let some random psycho dictate how I feel and what I do with my life. And I'm not going to let Shadow Weaver do that either." Once she had them all in a pile, she started to shred them with her fingernails.

"Wait!" Adora rushed to stop her. "Catra, I think it's great that you're not letting yourself get freaked out, and I'm all for being empowered and everything, but we should probably keep those intact in case we need to use them as evidence! If we ever find out who it is and need to press charges or anything like that."

Catra glared at her. "Fine!" She stalked off towards her loft. "Do what you want with the stupid photographs. I'll be up here, *not* listening to anyone try to tell me what to do."

Adora sighed, but didn't pursue her client. She couldn't blame her for being shaken up by the letter, but she hoped Catra would find a better outlet for her emotions. Regardless, though, it was her duty to protect the pop star. Adora looked out of the penthouse window at the city around them. Was the letter writer out there

somewhere? Were they staring at Adora right now through a pair of binoculars? She scowled. Wherever they were, *whoever* they were, Adora would stop them. It was her job. And besides...

She didn't think she'd be able to forgive herself if she couldn't.

...

With Catra effectively quarantined in the Hordak building, things had gotten a little tense.

"What is her *problem*?" Catra flung a pillow across the apartment, collapsing on Adora's bed in a frustrated heap. Adora grimaced.

Maybe more than a little tense.

She walked over to her client, picking up the pillow as she went. "Hey, I get that expressing your emotions is healthy, but do you mind trashing your own bed instead of mine?"

Catra's voice was muffled, her head buried in the covers. "They're throw pillows, Adora. That's what they're for."

"I'm pretty sure that's not the reason they're called throw pillows."

"Then why are they, Adora?"

Adora sat down gingerly next to the pop star, then paused. Huh. Why *were* they called throw pillows?

She decided not to press the issue. "I know Ms. Weaver is tough on you. But that's just because she believes in you. You know that."

At that, Catra sprung up to face her. "No, she doesn't. If she believed in me, she'd give me time to write my own songs. Instead, she's basically force-feeding me lyrics and arrangements!"

Adora frowned. "I thought she said that she wanted you to start writing your next album."

"Yeah, she did, but..." Catra flushed lightly. "Well, I've been having a lot of trouble. I mean, what am I supposed to write about? I don't *do* anything. I just stay in this building and do vocal lessons and read fanmail." She was quiet for a few moments, and Adora resisted the urge to put an arm around her. "For my first album, I drew from my life before Hordak. I went through tons of shit, basically. And a lot of people could relate to that! Even though they were my experiences, people could apply them to their own lives. How am I supposed to write relatable, authentic music about sitting around all day? Who wants to listen to that?"

"I would," offered Adora.

Catra granted her a rueful smile. "Thanks, Adora. But seriously, I've been having such writer's block. But Shadow Weaver says that we need to release the album later this year, which means writing the music has to happen now. So she's basically been writing songs for me."

Adora leaned in, intrigued. "Are they good?"

"I don't know. I guess. I mean, I don't think they're bad or anything. But they're not *me*. I don't sing because of the fame, or because I'm good at it. I sing because I have something to say. And when you're out in front of a crowd, telling them how you feel, and they sing back to you, because they share that feeling in some form, it's — it's incredible. There's nothing like it. And I just don't think I could get that kind of feeling from singing someone else's stuff."

"Wow." Adora raised her eyebrows. "That was kinda beautiful."

Catra laughed softly. "Thanks for listening to me rant." She leaned against Adora lightly, and it felt so natural and *right* that Adora's arm came up to support her seemingly of its own volition. "I must seem like a crazy person. It's such a stupid problem to have."

Adora shook her head vehemently. "You're not stupid. Or crazy. It totally makes sense." She moved her hand up and down Catra's back tentatively. "Do you really have no song ideas, though? I mean, even in Hordak, things happen. You're being stalked by a psycho. That's kind of...maybe 'exciting' is the wrong word. But your life is hardly *boring*."

"Well..." Catra blushed suddenly, and leaned back, breaking the contact between them. "There is one song I'm writing. But I'm still in the opening stages of it. It's definitely not ready to perform yet."

"What's it about?" Catra shook her head, still a little red. "Oh, come on, don't hold out on me like this!" Adora poked her in the side and Catra giggled.

"No! It's a secret," she said. "You'll hear it eventually...if you're nice to me, that is." Catra stuck her tongue out.

Adora laughed. "What if I just keep poking you until you give in?" She jabbed at Catra with her fingers, aiming for the spots on her client's stomach she knew were ticklish.

"Ah! Help! Bodyguard!" Catra yelped through her laughter, writhing away on the bed. Adora pursued; Catra retaliated; before long, the two were a tangled mess of limbs, laughing until they were gasping for air.

"I'm glad you two have found some way to entertain yourselves."

"Ms. Weaver!" Adora jerked upright somewhat ungracefully and, not really knowing what to do, saluted, while Catra rolled into a sitting position on the bed.

Her manager chuckled. She must have come in while they were roughhousing; normally, Catra could hear the elevator approaching from several floors away. "I hate to interrupt such...*joyous*... activities, but there are matters we need to discuss."

"I told you already, I'm working on the new album. I just need more time," said Catra, folding her arms across her chest. "It's not exactly easy finding material to write about when I haven't left this building in weeks."

Ms. Weaver waved a hand. "And, as I've told you before, if you cannot produce anything, we will have to move forward with something else. Have you looked over the demo tracks I sent you?" Adora noticed a hint of eagerness in her voice that sounded almost out of place coming from the ever-serious manager.

Catra glared at her. "I did. But I'm *not* using someone else's song."

"Oh, Catra." Ms. Weaver's laugh seemed to echo somehow through the vast apartment. "I forget, sometimes, how young you are. How unaware of how this industry works. *No one* writes their own songs. Do you think Ariana Grande or Taylor Swift are sitting around their luxury apartments, agonizing over which lines fit where and what melody sounds best? My dear — of course they aren't. They have people who do that sort of grunt work for them."

"I bet Ariana Grande and Taylor Swift aren't being held captive inside their record labels," muttered Catra.

"They also aren't being *stalked* by a highly dangerous fanatic," retorted Ms. Weaver. Her voice softened. "At any rate, that's what I wanted to talk to you about. I know you love to see me as your evil jailer, but I truly just want the best for you. Your safety and your happiness." Catra scoffed, and Ms. Weaver looked at her sternly. "In that order." They held eye contact for a moment before Catra shrugged and glanced off to her side. "Sometimes, however, the two fortuitously collide. How would you like to attend the Etheria Awards?"

Catra's head jolted back to Ms. Weaver. "What?" she exclaimed. "I'm not even eligible to be nominated this year."

"You wouldn't be going as a nominee." Ms. Weaver glided towards the counter and sat down on one of the stools. "I found a gentleman who agreed to take you as his...personal guest."

"You said I would go as someone's *date*?! When were you going to ask me about this?"

If Catra's anger perturbed Ms. Weaver, she didn't show it. "I'm asking you now. Your album came out over a year ago. You haven't been in the public eye since Princess Fest, and that was the first time you performed in several months. Our key demographics do not suffer from overlong attention spans." She drummed her fingers on the counter. "We need to remind them of your existence, and make sure they're anticipating what's coming next. Obviously, safety is a concern, but the awards are fairly exclusive. There's good security, and no one will know you are going until you're there. Besides, I thought you would jump at the chance to get out of the building."

Catra was not mollified. "That doesn't mean you can just decide that I'll go with someone without even telling me about it. I'm not going."

"Oh, Catra." Ms. Weaver chuckled. "Always so rash. Don't you want to know who you'd be accompanying?"

Catra shrugged. "Not really. It's not like any of these random celebrities are gonna be fun to hang out with."

Ms. Weaver rose out of her chair and stepped towards the elevator. "Fine," she said over her shoulder. "Ignore this opportunity for adventure. I'll tell Mr. Lawless that you're not interested."

"Wait!" Catra jumped up. "*Wallace Lawless* wants me to go to the Etheria Awards with him?"

Her manager paused, but did not turn around. "He did, but I'm sure he'll find someone else to take your place. It's not as though he has a lack of options."

"Who is Wallace Lawless?" Adora blurted out. "And what are the Etheria Awards?" Both Catra and Ms. Weaver turned to look at her.

Catra snickered. "You are *so* clueless about pop music." She tapped Adora's nose lightly. "Don't worry, it's cute. You might be the only teen girl in the world who doesn't know who Wallace Lawless is. He's ridiculously famous."

"The Etheria Awards is a prestigious event that honors the best musicians among the current crop. Mr. Lawless is nominated this year for Best Artist, which he's won two years straight," said Ms. Weaver. "And they've already announced that he's going to perform. So attending with him is guaranteed screen time. Not to mention the media buzz you'll get just for walking in on his arm."

Adora glanced at Catra. The pop star had expressed her disinterest in the glitzier aspects of her status on numerous occasions, as well as her general disregard for other celebrities. She'd said that most other famous people were boring and inauthentic. But the look on her face at the moment did not seem anything like disinterest.

"He really wants me to be his date?" asked Catra incredulously. Ms. Weaver nodded. "We've never met before. I didn't think he even knew I existed." She bounced her weight back and forth between her feet.

"It would seem that he does." Ms. Weaver's voice was dry, but not unkind. "What shall I tell him, dear?"

Catra scratched her head. "I mean, I'd be crazy to turn him down, right? He's *Wallace Lawless*. And even a stuffy reception full of famous people is better than being trapped in here another day."

"Wonderful." Ms. Weaver nodded once, then stepped into the elevator. "I shall inform his manager at once. The event is next Friday; we'll do media prep the week leading up to it, and I'll have the fashion team come in and fit you for a dress as well." She

fixed her stare on Catra as the doors began to close. "It will be your first public appearance since Princess Fest; anything less than perfection is failure. Do not disappoint me."

Catra held her gaze until the door closed, then flopped back down on Adora's bed. After a few moments, Adora sat down next to her. "So," the bodyguard said, not really sure where to begin. "At least we're getting out of here."

The pop star was silent.

"Catra?"

"Yeah!" She shook her head vigorously. "Yeah, you're right. I just..." She turned to look out the window dreamily. "I can't believe Wallace Lawless wants me to be his date."

A feeling Adora refused to acknowledge wriggled around in her stomach. She did her best to stamp it out.

...

The week leading up to the awards show went by slowly. Though Catra was excited for the event, she still had to write and record new music, and her difficulties with composing new songs persisted, as did Ms. Weaver's insistence that *something* had to be recorded.

"Tell her to come out of there. I want to hear how she sounds."

They were in the recording room in Hordak. Catra had been in the booth for nearly an hour working on one of the new tracks that Ms. Weaver and her team had written, while Adora and the manager in question waited and watched from outside. While Ms. Weaver had occasionally borrowed one of the headsets Entrapta and the other sound techs used to listen in on her progress, she told Adora a live performance was a different experience entirely. Adora nodded agreeably. She was just excited to hear Catra sing again.

A nearby sound tech went over to the booth, gesturing towards Catra. With a look of relief, the pop star took off her headphones and stepped out.

"Finally! Can we get something to eat? I've been in there for ages."

Ms. Weaver chuckled softly. "Soon, my dear. Just give us a quick rendition of what you have so far, first, won't you? So we can hear your progress."

Catra groaned. "Really?" Adora smiled encouragingly at her, and her frown lessened slightly. "Fine. But then we're going to the cafeteria."

Ms. Weaver nodded to Entrapta, who began the backing track. The song was slower than most of the ones Catra sang at her concert, the melody more simple.

Haven't heard from you in a long long while
But it's been hard for me to forget that smile

The relatively reserved accompaniment and slower tempo showed off Catra's voice in a way that her more modern fare did not, and Adora found herself bobbing her head back and forth as Catra worked her way through the song. The lyrics, as far as Adora could tell, described a longing for a past relationship, romantic or otherwise. She soon tuned out, though, too engrossed in watching Catra. The singer swayed from side to side lightly, and hit the notes perfectly, but the energy that infused her performance at Princess Fest was absent. The confidence that Adora knew Catra possessed, the "look at me, you're gonna regret if you don't" attitude that seemed to ooze from every song she performed — it just wasn't on display. Catra simply stared at Ms. Weaver as she sang.

Speaking of Ms. Weaver — the manager was riveted to Catra's performance, her gaze fixed firmly on the pop star. Adora glanced at her out of the corner of her eye, then turned to face her as she

realized how complete the older woman's focus was. Ms. Weaver sat almost unnaturally still, and Adora could see her hands clenched into fists at her side.

What good are apologies when the damage is deep
Now you're nothing to me but a secret to keep

The lyrics had taken a dark turn, wresting Adora's concentration back from Ms. Weaver. Catra still delivered the lines without much embellishment, and the lack of emotion plus the restrained melody gave Adora a vaguely haunting feeling.

Finally, the song was over. Adora, Entrapta, and the rest of the sound techs gave a brief round of applause. Once the clapping subsided, Ms. Weaver spoke.

"Beautiful work, Catra. I..." She paused. Adora had never seen the manager hesitate before; she always seemed very sure of what she said and where she stood. "You've made me very proud today."

Catra's face brightened for a second, though she quickly masked it with a scowl. "I'm still going to write my own music, you know. This is just a placeholder until I get it figured out."

Ms. Weaver waved her hand. "We'll discuss that later. Go get some food for now." She made no move to get up, and after a moment, Catra nodded hesitantly and left the room, beckoning Adora to follow. Adora rose, and, with one last look at Ms. Weaver, exited the recording studio. The manager remained seated as Entrapta directed the sound techs around her, undisturbed by their movement, staring at the spot Catra had sung from as if still watching her performance.

...

The rehearsals continued throughout the week. Though Catra still complained to Adora about singing songs that weren't hers, Adora noticed that her laments contained far less venom than they had before. The singer and her manager's perpetually rocky

relationship had been oddly peaceful since Catra's performance in the recording studio. Ms. Weaver kept her patience with Catra more, and seemed to put less pressure than usual on her protégé. And Adora felt like she heard Ms. Weaver praise Catra more this week than she had in the whole rest of time Adora had been working at Hordak. Though the stalker remained a threat, and Catra remained confined to the building, the pop star's mood was noticeably better than it had been since the letter first came in.

Of course, Adora thought a bit grumpily, there was another possible explanation for Catra's good mood, and his name was Wallace Lawless.

It all started the Monday before the awards show. As usual, Scorpia brought up a box of mail for Adora to sort through. They were on the lookout for more letters from the stalker, but so far the most suspicious item they'd received was an invitation to an already booked luxury hotel room attached to the most lascivious letter Adora had ever seen. Though it, like the stalker's letter, also contained a poem about Catra's body parts, Adora didn't think the two were related.

While Adora had never seen Scorpia in an even slightly negative mood, there was an extra spark in her smile as she handed the box over. She leaned in to whisper conspiratorily in Adora's ear. "There's more to bring up; can you give me a hand?"

When they reached the bottom floor, Adora saw why the receptionist was so giddy. An enormous quantity of roses flooded the ground floor of Hordak Records, in both huge, elaborate arrangements and smaller (though still substantial) bouquets.

"Holy cow." Adora whistled in wonder. "Someone went a little overboard with the fanmail."

"Not just someone." Scorpia's smile somehow grew even wider. She gestured to a card that lay among the largest complex of roses. Adora picked it up.

"Dear Catra," it read. "Thank you for agreeing to accompany me to the Etheria Awards. I will be honored to have you by my side when I win Best Artist for the unprecedented 3rd year in a row. I look forward to experiencing your exquisite beauty in person. With regards, the Prince of Pop, Wallace Lawless."

It took them half an hour to unload all the roses in the penthouse, and another half hour for Catra to finally wake up (she liked to sleep in when she could, and Ms. Weaver had been more lenient with the schedule as of late). She walked through the apartment with an awed look on her face. "*Wallace Lawless* sent these?" she repeated when Adora showed her the card.

Well, Wallace Lawless didn't carry roses up the elevator all morning, Adora thought uncharitably. But she didn't want to ruin the moment.

"What a ridiculous thing to do," murmured Catra, her cheeks more than a little pink. "So over-the-top." It took a long time for the smile to leave her face, and she didn't complain once that day, even when Ms. Weaver made her run through a new song's bridge ten times in a row.

Wallace Lawless's presence continued, unwanted, in Adora's life throughout the week. Catra would blast his music from her speakers and dance around the penthouse in order to "prepare" for the awards show. Personally, Adora didn't really get the appeal. She found much of it repetitive and misogynistic; his most popular song, which Adora knew uncomfortably well at this point, was called simply "Thotz" — yes, with a z — and catalogued the many different women he had...romanced over the years. She voiced as much to Catra on occasion, but the pop star just shrugged and laughed it off.

"It's fun, Adora. It's not meant to be taken that seriously. It's just catchy music with goofy punchlines that people can dance to."

Maybe so. But Adora felt a growing irritation towards the ostensible best artist in the world. The Etheria Awards would be

Catra's *one* chance to go out and have a good night, and he didn't seem like the most responsible or respectful companion. No responsible person would choose the name "Lawless," after all. Adora would have to keep a close eye on him. If he did anything to make Catra uncomfortable, she would...well, she'd think of something.

Ms. Weaver pulled her in for a meeting the day before the show. "I know this will be a new environment for you," she said, closing the door to her office and motioning Adora to sit down. "There's going to be a lot going on. Scores of A-list celebrities under a single roof. It can be...chaotic."

Adora nodded. Her chair was excessively soft, and she had to struggle to look somewhat dignified as her body sunk into the cushions.

"Fortunately for you, you don't have to worry about most of what's going on. You just have to worry about Catra."

"Right!" Adora sat up as straight as she could under the circumstances. "Have there been any new leads with the stalker?"

Ms. Weaver shook her head. "We can't let our guard down, but there's been nothing since the initial letter, and no one outside of Hordak and Mr. Lawless's camp should know that Catra will be there. Be on the lookout, but it should be safe."

"Any other security concerns I should know about?"

"Only the basic flow of action. You won't be seated with Catra during the event; bodyguards, assistants, and other auxiliary staff tend to be seated on the upper levels, away from the cameras. You should be able to find a seat where you can see Catra — and vice versa, should she need to signal or contact you for any reason."

Adora frowned. "I won't be near her? But what if something happens? If there is cause to evacuate, I don't want us to be separated."

Ms. Weaver nodded approvingly. "Good thinking. When you get there, make sure you find the fastest routes between the seating areas. If something happens, get to Catra immediately. Until something does, however, you will be cordoned off with the rest of the less famous. They are fairly strict with who they populate the most exclusive sections with." She rose as if to signal the end of the meeting, then turned to Adora, an amused lilt in her tone. "And of course, much as Catra is fond of you, having a bodyguard sit in on a date can be a little distracting."

"Of course." Adora felt a flush in her cheeks, and wasn't sure why. She stood up to leave. She was halfway to the door when Ms. Weaver spoke again.

"Oh, and Adora?"

"Yes?"

"Do keep an eye on them. There's no harm in a bit of fun, but if Catra is getting a little too rambunctious, or too enthusiastic with the champagne...have a word with her."

"Yes, Ms. Weaver." Adora could only imagine how well that would go over.

When Ms. Weaver's voice returned, it was quieter than before. "It feels like parenting a child sometimes. I just don't want anything to happen to her. Adora, tell her...tell her that if this goes well, I can arrange for her to attend other events. Other awards shows and cocktail parties and fancy dinners. She doesn't have to be someone's date, she can just go. We'll have to plan carefully with security, but it should be possible."

Adora smiled. "I think she would really like that."

"Yes, well..." Ms. Weaver seemed a bit uncertain. "I hope she does. I know we have our disagreements, but I do want her to be happy. You see that, don't you, Adora?"

"Yes, Ms. Weaver." Adora didn't think she could answer anything but yes to that question if she wanted to keep her job, but she was surprised to find it felt like an honest answer. Beginning with the arranged date with Wallace Lawless, Ms. Weaver had been showing a concern for Catra's feelings that hadn't always been present before. And now with the promise of future outings...Adora could see things looking up for the relationship between the pop star and the masked manager.

She saluted once, and left the room. Tomorrow was the big day.

...

Apparently, when a bodyguard attended a formal event with a client, the bodyguard was supposed to dress elegantly too.

"I don't know about this, Catra," said Adora, examining herself in the mirror. Sure, the dress Catra had picked out for her was pretty — dark red, sleeveless, with a lighter red top that thinned as it descended over the rest of it. But — "How am I going to move quickly in this? If something happens and I need to get to you, it's gonna slow me down."

Catra rolled her eyes. "One, it's an awards show, not a war zone. The most exciting thing that's gonna happen is Drake confessing his love to someone during his acceptance speech. Two, if you leave this building in pants and your red jacket, Shadow Weaver is going to flip out and probably make you change on the way there. Three" — she tiptoed behind Adora, adjusting her dress slightly — "you look amazing. Red is definitely your color. So stop complaining and let me do your makeup."

Adora nodded meekly as Catra led her into the bathroom. Amazing, huh? Well, Catra was probably right; it was just an awards show. Besides, she could always rip the dress off at the knees if she needed to run somewhere.

Catra sat her down on the toilet seat and got out an eyeshadow palette that even Adora, who almost never wore makeup, could

tell was expensive. "Alright," she said. "I'm thinking some winged eyeliner just for a bit of extra pop. And maybe some light eyeshadow; I have a red that's almost the exact same shade as your dress. That sound okay?"

"I guess," replied Adora reluctantly. "Do I have to wear makeup? It's not like I'll be on camera or anything."

"Of course you don't have to. But come on, Adora, live a little. We're getting dressed up and going to a fancy event. It's supposed to be *fun*. "

"Alright," grumbled Adora.

Catra clapped her hands gleefully. "Yes! You're gonna look so good, I promise. Now close your eyes." Adora felt Catra's hand rest gently on her shoulder, and her heart beat a bit faster as the pop star began to brush her face, the cool sensation of the liquid eyeliner contrasting with the warmth of Catra's exhales against her skin. She shivered. "Hold steady! I don't want to mess anything up."

After a few minutes, Catra told her to open her eyes. When she did, Adora gulped, not expecting her client to be so close. The pop star was mere inches from her, biting her lip as she examined Adora's makeup. "Hmm. It's a little uneven, but I don't think anyone will notice." Catra rubbed her head sheepishly. "Usually people do my makeup for me, so I'm not the best at it. Sorry! You can take it off if you want."

Adora stood up and moved to the mirror. "I think it looks great," she said, mostly truthfully — the right wing was a little longer than the left, but the eyeshadow wasn't overpowering, and did indeed match perfectly with the dress.

Catra flushed. "Really? Well, I'm glad. You do look really nice right now." She tilted her head as she regarded Adora. "Just one final touch..." Catra vanished, then walked back in with a long, sharp

butterfly hairpin and stuck it in Adora's ponytail. She pulled back for a moment, then nodded. "Perfect."

As Adora glanced in the mirror again, the elevator chimed.

"Oh! That's my hair and makeup team." Catra stepped out the door of the bathroom, then poked her head back in. "We're probably gonna take a while, so maybe you should get something to eat. There's going to be finger food at the awards show, but knowing you..." Catra smirked at her. Adora stuck her tongue out in response, but headed towards the elevator, nodding politely to the pair in charge of orchestrating Catra's appearance on her way. With a final wave to Catra, she headed down to the cafeteria.

After a satisfying meal of macaroni and cheese, fried rice, roasted vegetables, and of course a few miniature tarts, she headed back to the penthouse. Chaos greeted her as soon as she stepped out of the elevator. Dresses and undergarments were strewn across the floor, makeup kits haphazardly arranged on the counter, and at least seven different pairs of heels lay mismatched all around the room.

"Hey, Adora!"

Catra stepped out of the bathroom delicately, and all the mess melted away. She wore a long dark gray dress that shimmered with every move she made. The dress had a high neck but no sleeves, and an eye-catching slit below the waist. Her makeup was subtle, but made her blue and yellow eyes pop even more than usual.

"Wow," breathed Adora. "You — uh — you look incredible."

Catra twirled around. "Don't I? Adrian and Tamara really know their stuff. It helps to have such a stunning model, of course."

Catra's antics helped bring Adora back down to earth. "Mmm, I'm sure. Tell me, are they giving an award tonight for the most humble pop star? Cuz I think you'd be a shoo-in."

The pop star in question giggled. "Maybe they'll give out a surprise award for best makeup on a bodyguard. That trophy would look great in my collection."

Adora smirked as she stepped closer to her client. "You know, we bodyguards give out awards of our own sometimes. There's no way you wouldn't walk away with some of those ones."

"Oh really." Catra's voice was tinged with amusement. "Like what?"

"Oh, I don't know," mused Adora. "Most troublesome client; least reasonable client; worst disguised client—"

"Hey! My incognito outfit is a masterpiece of subterfuge and you know it!"

Adora laughed. "*That's* what you have a problem with?"

Catra tossed her hair back. "I know I can be a bit troublesome sometimes. But I would think a high-level bodyguard like yourself can handle a little trouble."

"I suppose I can."

"Uh, not to get in the middle of anything, but Mr. Lawless's limo was scheduled to arrive two minutes ago." Adora jumped as the makeup artist poked her head out of the bathroom hesitantly. "You two should probably head downstairs."

"Oh, crap!" said Catra. She turned to the hair stylist. "Any final adjustments?"

The stylist shook her head. "You look gorgeous, dear. Now go on — we'll straighten up a bit here." Cara beamed in response, then walked to the elevator, motioning Adora to follow.

Adora's stomach felt a bit funny as they stood next to each other in the descending elevator. Maybe she shouldn't have had the mac

and cheese *and* the fried rice. But her stomach could usually handle anything.

She turned to Catra. "Hey," she said, all the silliness of their previous conversation gone. "If Wallace Lawless tries anything strange, or makes you uncomfortable in any way, just give me a signal, okay? I'll come over and talk some sense into him.

Catra laughed. "You're ridiculous," she replied. "I'm sure he'll be a gentleman."

"I'm serious, Catra. Let's decide on a signal for you to use if you want some help."

"Adora, I appreciate the concern, but this is the Etheria Awards, not some random party. I'm not going to give you a signal to come beat up one of the most famous pop stars in America."

"I really think—"

"I said no, okay?" Catra's voice was quiet, but firm. "I appreciate you looking out for me, but I'm not incapable of fighting my own battles." The elevator stopped moving, and the doors opened. Ms. Weaver stood outside, putting a stop to any thoughts Adora had of continuing the argument.

"Good, you're here. His limousine just pulled up; let's go outside." With a quirk of her eyebrows to Adora, Catra followed her manager out the doors, Adora trailing close behind.

Wallace Lawless's limo was predictably ostentatious, bright red in color with LAWLESS printed across the side and flame decals above the wheels. Adora rolled her eyes. Three men in suits and sunglasses stood outside on the sidewalk.

"Good evening, gentlemen," said Ms. Weaver.

The one in front nodded brusquely. "Miss Catra," he grunted. "Right this way. Mr. Lawless is inside waiting."

"He's not even going to come out and greet you?" muttered Adora. Catra gave her a look. "Sorry."

Ms. Weaver put a hand on Catra's shoulder. "Even though you're not performing, you'll still be on camera. Do at least *try* to behave." Her tone softened. "But do try to have a good time as well." Catra smiled up at her, then stepped towards the door one of the men was holding open. Adora moved to follow, but the first man stopped her. "This limo is for Mr. Lawless and guests only."

"I'm her bodyguard," retorted Adora. "I go where she goes."

"Mr. Lawless and guests only," he repeated.

"It's alright, Adora," said Ms. Weaver. "You and I will ride in a Hordak car." She gestured to a black SUV parked behind the limo, then leaned in towards Adora like she was sharing a secret. "With how hard it is to drive a limo in traffic, we'll get there faster anyway."

Adora slumped, but nodded. Catra gave one last look over her shoulder before stepping into the limo, the men in suits following behind her.

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Ms. Weaver was right; despite having to wait a full traffic cycle for the limo to pull out of Hordak and onto the road, they had almost made it through the long line into the building (via the side entrance for the non-celebrities in attendance) by the time Wallace Lawless's distinct vehicle came into sight. Adora and the manager paused to watch as the horde of photographers jockeyed for position behind the barrier around the red carpet, the flash of cameras almost blinding.

"They make an attractive couple, don't they," murmured Ms. Weaver as the pair stepped out of the car. Adora nodded mutely. They did look quite striking together; Catra was stunning, of course, and Wallace Lawless's crimson tuxedo jacket and black dress shirt stood out without clashing too much with her outfit. As

he stood with his arm around Catra, Adora got her first real look at him in person. He had jet-black hair and high cheekbones, a face that Adora had to admit most people would classify as attractive, though she pettily noted that he wasn't as tall as he came off in his music videos. He switched directions and poses every so often for the cameras, Catra matching his movements effortlessly. Adora watched as he leaned over to whisper something in Catra's ear, the pop star giggling in response. Finally, having apparently given the paparazzi enough angles, they slowly walked along the red carpet into the event, Catra holding on to Wallace Lawless's arm demurely.

Ms. Weaver tapped her on the shoulder, and Adora jumped, releasing a breath she didn't know she'd been holding. "Come, let's head inside," the manager said, turning to walk inside the concert hall. With one last look at Wallace Lawless and Catra, Adora followed.

Once inside, they were shepherded up two flights of stairs, coming out to rows of unassigned seating. Ms. Weaver led her to two corner seats three rows from the edge of the balcony. They had a pretty good view of the stage, but Adora couldn't see a lot of the floor seating where she knew Catra would be eventually. She turned to Ms. Weaver.

"Is there a way we can sit any closer? I'm worried about keeping an eye on Catra. And if something happens, it'll take me ages to get down there."

Ms. Weaver chuckled. "I do so appreciate your enthusiasm for the job, Adora. You take Catra's safety very seriously, as you should. While I don't think we'll have anything to worry about, once the event starts, you should be able to move into the standing room on the second floor balcony." Adora nodded. "Perhaps it is for the best anyway; I'll be busy flattering various producers and executives who could prove to be useful in the future. A bit boring for someone not so entrenched in the industry." Ms. Weaver patted Adora's hand. "I must say, it's refreshing to have someone else who genuinely cares for Catra. It's such a cutthroat business.

I do my best to look after her, but there's only so much a manager can do. She's lucky to have you."

Adora nodded again, grateful that the dim lighting of the auditorium hid the sudden color in her cheeks. She had nothing to be embarrassed about. Of course she cared about Catra. They were friends.

Ms. Weaver's hand moved to Adora's shoulder as the manager scanned the room. "Go whenever you get the chance. I see Jack Antonoff on the other end of our row. I've been trying to get him to produce one of Catra's songs for months. He will not escape me any longer." With that, she released Adora and stalked up the stairs. Adora gulped. Whoever Jack Antonoff was, she didn't envy him.

She managed to sneak down the stairs while the usher helped someone with an enormously floofy dress navigate the crowds. Catra was right to make her dress up — in her normal attire, Adora would have looked as out of place in this environment as she felt. They covered formal events in Brightmoon training, of course, but nothing to this scale of grandeur. The bits and pieces of conversation she picked up sounded almost like a foreign language, and some of the dresses Adora passed by had so many odd frills and colors that they barely registered as clothing.

Still, regardless of how she felt, Adora looked the part enough that no one questioned her as she descended to the first balcony and made her way to the railing. From there, she scanned the crowd beneath her for Catra and her date. The celebrities and their guests were arranged in circular tables with fancy looking drinks and appetizers in front of them. It made a dazzling scene, but Adora noticed in horror that nobody was showing the slightest interest in the food, instead conversing almost too enthusiastically with those around them and taking infinitesimal sips of what looked like champagne. Adora's nose wrinkled in disgust. She would never understand famous people. Well, except for...

There she was! Catra and Wallace Lawless sat at a table in the second row from the stage. Catra sat attentively while he told what seemed to be a very entertaining anecdote to her and the rest of the table, which consisted of a pale-looking man and two older women in glitzy outfits, one of whom threw back her head and laughed at what he was saying. Adora scowled. Catra had told her that everyone would be politely schmoozing and networking at these kinds of events. It probably wasn't that funny.

She continued to watch as the rest of the attendees filed in. Wallace Lawless seemed to be dominating most of the conversation — how shocking, thought Adora unkindly. She was surprised, however, at how much fun Catra seemed to be having. The pop star waved her arms around dramatically, responding animatedly to something the pale man said. Wallace Lawless led the table in a champagne toast and finished his glass in one gulp, prompting Catra to do so as well. Adora bit her lip. One glass was fine, but she didn't want Wallace Lawless to influence Catra to drink too much and get sick. She was small enough that even the tiny flutes of champagne would hit pretty hard. To Adora's relief, though, there only seemed to be one bottle on the table, mostly spent after everyone's toasts.

Soon enough, the event started. The lights went down, and an extravagantly dressed woman who introduced herself as Light Hope came on stage to enthusiastic applause. She thanked everyone for coming and appreciating the wonderful music the nominees had created. Adora tuned out after the first minute or two, too focused on Catra and her date. They were sitting quietly, but every so often Wallace Lawless would lean over and whisper something in her ear; Catra would laugh, and sometimes turn around and whisper back. Adora didn't want to watch, but found it hard to turn away. She just had to make sure Catra was okay. She was just doing her job.

Another bout of applause broke her concentration. Light Hope left the stage, and the lights went up on a musical set up behind her. Three young men bounded out, two of them holding guitars. Adora must have missed the introduction; they looked familiar

enough that Glimmer had probably made her listen to them at some point.

Well, whatever. Adora turned her head back to Catra and her date. She could worry about whatever famous people she was ignoring later.

We go together
Better than birds of a feather, you and me

Wallace Lawless was bobbing back and forth to the song, swaying side to side in an exaggerated fashion. Catra giggled the way she sometimes did when Adora was particularly serious about protecting her in a seemingly safe environment.

We change the weather
I'm feeling heat in December when you're round me

He grabbed Catra's hand and made her join in his off balance dancing. It was hard to see in the dim light, but Adora was pretty sure he was singing along to the words echoing through the room.

I'm a sucker for you
You say the word and I'll go anywhere blindly
I'm a sucker for you, yeah
Any road you take, you know you'll find me

Adora felt anger bubble up in her chest. Who was Wallace Lawless to say these things? He didn't know Catra at all. He didn't know how her ears would perk up when she was interested in things even if she was trying not to show it; how she loved being teased and tested despite her protests; how scared she was under her confident exterior. He didn't know *anything*. And Catra didn't need someone who was going to give her all this attention and not mean it, someone who would be part of her life and leave. She needed someone dependable. Someone who would care about her even when she was sad or angry. Someone who saw the person beneath the outside image of a glamorous pop star.

She shook her head vigorously. Maybe all that was true. But she was just here to ensure Catra's safety, and so far Wallace Lawless, distasteful as he may be, hadn't done anything to jeopardize her. As the nameless trio left the stage to great applause, Adora watched the aforementioned star flag down a waiter for a champagne refill. The pale man and the women held their glasses out as well, and, after a moment's hesitation, Catra joined them.

Two flutes of champagne shouldn't be an issue — Brightmoon had protocols for monitoring clients' intake in formal situations and calculating how many standard drinks they had — but Catra didn't usually drink, and her low body weight wouldn't do her any favors in this regard. But even if Adora wanted to intervene, what would she do? She wished Catra had set up a signal with her like Adora had wanted to. But Catra was so enamored with Wallace Lawless and his antics she probably wouldn't have given the signal anyway.

Adora continued to observe the pair as the show went on. Awards were presented, songs were performed, speeches were made — Adora was sure it was all very impressive. She barely tuned in when Kacey Musgraves won an award for best country album, only briefly noting that Glimmer would be ecstatic. Her friend, Adora realized, was probably watching the ceremony from her house right now.

The wild experience her life had become was a lot to think about, but Adora didn't have time for reflection. Wallace Lawless had just downed his fifth glass of champagne, and refilled Catra's without even asking her. Enough was enough. She wasn't sure how, but she had to make sure her client was okay.

Her chance came swiftly, when Light Hope came back onstage.

"The biggest awards of the night are still to come," she said. "But first, a performance from the pop phenom who has won Best Artist an astounding two years in a row, and tonight is nominated to make it three! Everyone, give it up for Wallace Lawless!"

The crowd burst into applause. Adora watched as Wallace Lawless jumped out of his seat and ran onstage, taking off his suit jacket to swaths of cheers and wolf whistles. "How's everyone doing tonight?" he crowed into the microphone.

"Worse now that you've started talking, but thanks for asking," muttered Adora. She turned around without hesitation and walked through the doors back to the stairwell, descended to the ground floor, and ducked under the velvet rope barriers. Surprisingly, no one stopped her; Adora spotted more than a few members of the event staff migrating closer to the stage as Wallace Lawless started his performance. With a deep breath, she began to walk through the tables, mentally reconstructing the layout from the aerial view she'd had up on the balcony. Catra sat close to the stage; she had a lot of A-list celebrities to wade through before she would reach her.

Finally, she saw a familiar mass of bushy hair in front of her. She paused, unsure how Catra would react to her intervention. She probably wouldn't take kindly to Adora making comments about her drinking. But Adora had to say something.

"Hey, Catra," she said quietly, crouching down next to her client.

"Adora!" Catra yelped. She threw her arms around her bodyguard, then pulled back in surprise. "What are you doing down here?"

"I, uh, just wanted to check in on you, make sure you were okay!" Adora found the certainty in her actions that propelled her this far quickly eroding. Yes, it was her job to keep Catra safe, but how could she convey that without seeming like the fun police — or worse, like an extension of Ms. Weaver's authority?

Catra giggled. "Aw, you're sweet! I'm having a great time. Come on, watch the show with me." She grabbed Adora's hand and pulled her down to sit beside her. Adora hesitantly acquiesced, turning her attention to Wallace Lawless's performance as she struggled to figure out how to phrase her concern for Catra's state.

Chillin in my bed with two feminist thots
Thinking anything but feminist thoughts

The first time Catra had played her this song, Adora had to look up what a "thot" was on her phone. She almost wished she hadn't; the less she understood of Wallace Lawless's lyrics, the better. Catra didn't seem bothered by it, though, nodding along to the beat, still holding Adora's hand in her own.

One thot two thot three thot four
All these thots but I still want more

"What is this song even about?" Adora asked. "Aside from him not respecting women."

Catra rolled her eyes at her. This was not the first time they'd had this conversation. "It's just fun, Adora. Don't read into it so much."

"I'm not sure what about misogyny is fun."

"Look at Cyndi and Barbra. They're women. They're enjoying it. They're having fun." Adora looked across the table at the women in question. They did indeed seem to be having a good time, tapping their hands on the table to the beat of the song.

And then I went and met a thot from Atlantis
A night so crazy I still don't know where my pants is

Adora scowled. "It should be 'are,' not 'is.' Does he even hear himself? Or know grammar?" Catra gave her a look. She shrugged sheepishly. "Sorry, sorry. I'll keep the comments to myself."

Catra laughed softly. "You're so cute when you're annoyed. You're so grumpy."

"I am not grumpy." Adora crossed her arms, trying to avoid reacting to the first part of her client's statement. "I just don't get his appeal, that's all."

She felt a hand brush lightly against her upper arm. "You know, Adora, if I didn't know any better..." Catra smirked when Adora turned around to face her. "I would almost think you were jealous."

"What!? No, I just — why would you think that?" Adora sputtered, hoping her face wasn't as red as it felt.

Her client raised an eyebrow. "Oh, I don't know. You rushed down here to see me the minute he went onstage. You can't stop criticizing him. You're sitting in his seat. Almost seems like you'd like to be here instead of him." She leaned forward dangerously, eyes glinting with the light from the stage.

Adora pressed against the back of her chair, heart pounding. "I just wanted to make sure you were alright! I wouldn't — that would be completely unprofessional — I would never—"

Catra guffawed, thankfully interrupting Adora's panicked explanation. "God, you are so *easy*!" She laughed to herself, starting as a snicker but crescendoing into a full-bodied chortle. "Ugh, I know I shouldn't but it's just. So. Easy." She abruptly turned and rested her head against Adora. "I'm tired. Do you know how much longer this is gonna be?"

The sudden weight on her shoulder was just one more gust in the whirlwind of emotions the last minute had brought for Adora. She took a deep breath. Catra had been joking. Of course she wasn't jealous, that would be ridiculous. She just didn't like Wallace Lawless. She just thought Catra deserved better.

"How much longer?" Adora blinked, then a smile came over her face. "Ha! So you admit you don't like his music!"

"Of course I do." Catra yawned. "I'm just ready to go to sleep!" Her breath wafted upwards, and the distinct scent of alcohol reminded Adora of her original mission.

"Uh, Catra?" she asked. "How much champagne have you had?"

With great effort, Catra pushed herself off Adora and turned to face her. "Who's asking?"

"Your bodyguard."

Catra's eyes twinkled mischievously as she leaned in to whisper in Adora's ear. "Well, you can tell my bodyguard that since this is my one night of fun, I've had as much as I want." She swayed back, a little unsteady. "Not more than four anyway. Or five. Don't worry, they're tiny cups."

Adora glanced at the table. She could evaluate the size of the flutes more accurately from up close, and they were definitely small — but again, so was Catra, and she was clearly feeling the effects of the alcohol. As Adora considered the situation, she felt a weight on her shoulder again.

"Ado-ra," crooned Catra in a sing-song voice as she relaxed against Adora's side. "My bodyguard. Guarder of my body." She giggled.

Adora smiled down at her. "I think you've had enough champagne for the night, alright, hotshot?"

Catra pouted in response, but then yawned again. "You're lucky you're so cute, or I wouldn't let you boss me around like this." She settled into Adora, resting her head in the crook of Adora's neck.

"I'm glad you're getting comfortable and everything," said Adora, "but I do have to go back upstairs before he's done with the song."

Catra made a muffled noise of protest. "Stay for a bit though, okay?"

Adora rubbed her hand up and down Catra's back slowly, a warm feeling spreading through her body from her neck. "Okay, I'll stay for a bit."

Adora had spent a lot of time over the past few weeks wishing Wallace Lawless songs would be over — it was strange to now feel the opposite. After one last off-color line about women (Adora didn't ever want to hear someone say "Hippothotamus" again in her life), the crowd around her burst into applause, and Adora realized she didn't have much time to get back to her spot. She didn't want a confrontation with the event staff, or the man whose seat she was currently occupying. She gave Catra a final squeeze and gently extricated herself so that she could stand up. "I'll find you on the way out!" she shouted to her client over the cheers.

Catra winked at her in response, then settled back down in her seat. Adora walked swiftly but steadily back up to the stairwell, reserving her judgment for the event staff trickling back to their posts until she was safely on the second floor. (But seriously, what kind of professional would leave their position for a musical performance? Let alone *Wallace Lawless*?) By the time she returned to her spot on the balcony, Light Hope was back on stage.

"A big thank you to Wallace Lawless for that incredible performance!" The crowd roared again. Adora rolled her eyes. "Now, for the moment you've all been waiting for... the biggest award of the night, Best Artist of the Year!"

Adora glanced down at her client's table. Catra put her hand on Wallace Lawless's shoulder, and the rest of the table turned to look at him in anticipation. Wallace Lawless himself had a knowing smirk on his face that Adora found herself wishing she could punch off.

"Our nominees are Drake...Future...Bad Bunny...Ariana Grande...and Wallace Lawless!" Cheers followed every musician's name, the most raucous for the pop star Adora was quickly coming to despise. She did get a look at Ariana Grande on the big screen when they announced her; the singer wore a puffy pink dress that made the theme of her suite they had stayed in at Princess Fest make all too much sense. She seemed nice enough, though.

"And the winner is...for the third year in a row, Wallace Lawless!" As everyone around her started to applaud, Adora couldn't bring herself to clap, even though it would be the proper move for a bodyguard to avoid drawing undue attention to herself. She couldn't understand how or why these people would seriously like his music. She watched Catra stand up and press a kiss to Wallace Lawless's cheek in congratulations as he made his way back up to the stage, and felt anger surge through her. What did she see in him? He was arrogant, and crass, and misogynistic, and not that good looking. And Adora was pretty sure she was taller than him.

Wallace Lawless grabbed the mic stand. “Seems like I was just up here,” he mused, prompting chuckles from the crowd. "Anyway, I have a lot of people to thank tonight — my producer, my manager, my family. I could never have done this without them, etcetera etcetera, yada yada yada." He paused and grinned slyly. "I think we all know who is really responsible for this award, though. I'll give you a hint — he's got two thumbs, and he looks a lot like *this* guy." Wallace Lawless held his thumbs up, clearly indicating himself. "No one has *ever* won Best Artist three years in a row before. My producer does tracks for tons of artists. My manager has other clients. My parents, god bless them, have another child — you'll never be me, Chadwick!" He cleared his throat. "Ahem. The point is, the only common denominator is me. No one else could do what I do, so the only person I really have to thank is myself." He patted himself on the back. "Thank you, Wallace." He then gestured towards the crowd. "And thank you all, of course, for being here tonight!"

The crowd erupted into cheers, though Adora gratefully noted that they were a little less enthusiastic than before. It was still more than he deserved in her opinion. She looked down to see Catra giggling from her seat as she applauded. Adora hoped a ridiculously self-important speech like that would change Catra's opinion of Wallace Lawless, but the pop star still rose to embrace him as he returned to sit next to her. Adora looked away.

The rest of the Etheria Awards went by fairly quickly. A few more speeches about the importance and impact of music by important

people Adora had never heard of, some lifetime awards to older artists Adora had never heard of, some philanthropy awards to current artists Adora had never heard of — it all sort of ran together. Before she knew it, Light Hope returned to the stage.

"That marks the end of the 2020 Etheria Awards. To all of you, and to everyone watching at home, thank you for your time and attendance, and be sure to join us next year when we come together once again to celebrate music in all its variations and forms. Have a wonderful night!"

Adora blinked. The show seemed to move by so slowly; she wasn't expecting it to end so abruptly. But already people around her were standing up from their seats and filing out towards the staircases. Adora started to get in line to return to Ms. Weaver, then turned back to look out from the balcony again. Wallace Lawless had a hand on Catra's back, and seemed to be talking about something with her. She tilted her head in consideration, then nodded, a smile breaking out on her face. The two began to make their way out of the auditorium, though the ground floor was only marginally less packed than the upstairs sections.

All thoughts of Ms. Weaver gone, Adora pushed her way through the crowd, ignoring sounds of protest from the extravagantly dressed throngs around her. She said she'd find Catra on the way out. And on her watch, Catra would not be going anywhere with the "Best Artist of the Year."

The narrow staircase made it even more difficult to maneuver through the attendees, but Adora put her shoulder down and found openings where she could. Brightmoon training prepared their bodyguards specifically for moving swiftly within a crowd, and Adora had always been a top student. Soon enough, she reached the ground floor, where guests from the upper levels were being ushered out one exit, separated from the celebrities by only a velvet rope barrier and event staff scattered alongside it. Adora paused for a moment to scan for Catra and her date. She couldn't find them in the mass of vaguely recognizable faces in front of her. She turned to look at the door leading outside the

auditorium only to catch a glimpse of her client's hair as she exited the building.

She had to act fast. Without hesitating, she ducked under the velvet rope. "Hey, you can't come over here!" exclaimed one of the staff, a burly man with a scowl on his face. He tried to grab her arm, but Adora spun away, and stepped into the crowd, ducking to dodge his vision as she moved towards the door. The celebrities had less of a bottleneck than the less famous people coming from the balconies, so it was easy for her to jog between them and make her way to the exit. Once outside, she was faced with a sea of limousines; fortunately, the flame decals that marked Wallace Lawless's limo were rather eye-catching. She ran towards it, and as the crowd dispersed in front of her, saw that Catra and Wallace Lawless were about to get into the car.

"Catra!" she yelled as she closed the distance, easing her run into a jog.

The two of them turned around. "Adora!" Catra skipped towards her, and grabbed her hand in excitement. "Wallace invited me to an afterparty at his mansion to celebrate his win! Wanna come?" Before Adora could respond, Catra turned back to Wallace Lawless. "Adora's gonna come too!"

He raised an eyebrow. "And who is this 'Adora'? I've never heard of you before. Were you nominated tonight?" He squinted his eyes at her as if examining a test result.

Adora met his gaze with her own. "I'm her bodyguard."

Wallace Lawless laughed. "Really? A young chick bodyguard?" He paused for a second. "Huh. I wish I'd thought of that." He turned to the limousine. "Hector!" A man with sunglasses — Adora assumed, but couldn't be sure, that it was one of the same ones as earlier (they all kind of looked the same) — poked his head out of the limo.

"Yes, boss?"

"Make a note. I want to look into getting a female bodyguard." Another pause. "A thottyguard. Oooh, write that down. Did you get that, Hector?"

"Yes, boss." He stayed stoic and composed, but Adora swore she could hear a piece of Hector's soul breaking.

"Perfect." Wallace Lawless turned back to her. "Anyway, sweetie, thanks for the idea, but we have security already. You won't have much to do!"

Catra grabbed his arm. "Can she just come as my friend? She's really cool."

Wallace Lawless looked down at her quizzically. "Cool?" He turned to Adora. "This party is pretty exclusive. Really only A-list and up are going to be there. Somehow, I don't think that's you. How many Instagram followers do you have?"

"Uh, I don't have an Instagram," Adora responded hesitantly.

"So none. How many Twitter followers?"

"I don't have a Twitter."

"None again." Wallace Lawless shook his head disdainfully. "Look, I'd love to have you at the party. I'm sure you're super nice, and, uh, 'cool.' But the fact is, this party is top tier. It's the number one post-Etheria Awards event tonight. They wrote an article about it in People Magazine, google it. Anybody who is anybody — *everybody* who is anybody — is going to be at this party. The only people who aren't are, well, nobodies. And that's what you seem like. A nobody." He let that statement hang in the air for a moment, then turned to Catra. "Now come on, Catra. Let's get out of here!"

"What did you just call her?"

Catra's voice was deathly calm. She stared up at Wallace Lawless, a mixture of challenge and scorn on her face.

Her date seemed a little taken aback. "A nobody? I'm not being mean, it's just a fact! I'm a somebody, you're a somebody. She's a nobody."

"She's not a nobody. She's my friend."

He shrugged. "That's not what everyone else will see."

"*That's* what you're concerned about?" Catra glared at him. "Adora's *not* a nobody," she repeated. "She's kind, and funny, and she always makes sure that I'm safe and okay. Qualities that I'm beginning to see *you* do not possess." Catra jabbed her finger into Wallace Lawless's chest. "So go have fun at your party with all the other shallow, self-important *somebodies* out there. We're going to go home." She grabbed Adora's hand and started leading her away.

"Catra, wait!" Wallace Lawless jogged after them. "Come on, don't do this! We'll have a great time! Lenora can come too, I guess, we'll just crop her out of the official photo album or something."

Catra spun around. "Her name is *Adora*. And I'm done with you."

As they walked away, Wallace Lawless still pleading behind them, Adora turned to Catra. "Are you sure about this? This is your one night of fun, remember?"

"I'll have more fun in the apartment with you than in that asshole's mansion," Catra replied with a smile. Adora's heart soared. "Besides," she said through a yawn, "I'm pretty ready to go to sleep." She leaned on Adora's shoulder as they walked back towards the event, weaving through the remaining celebrities.

They found Ms. Weaver near the door; as far as Adora knew, she wasn't supposed to be here any more than Adora was, but she supposed the manager had her own ways of circumventing such boundaries. "Hello, dears," she said as they approached. She looked around. "Where is Mr. Lawless?"

Catra lifted her head from Adora. "We had a difference of opinion." She yawned again. "I had a good time tonight, so thank you for arranging it. But I don't think I want to see him again."

Ms. Weaver nodded. "I'm glad you had fun. Now come, let's get you home." She led them down the street to where the Hordak SUV was parked.

"Ms. Weaver?" Catra asked tentatively as she and Adora stepped into the backseat.

"Yes, dear?"

Catra stayed silent for a moment before she spoke. "I realized something tonight. I don't want to use anyone else's songs, even yours. I don't care if we have deadlines to meet. I don't care if I lose fans or lose money." Adora heard the emotion building in Catra's voice, and reached out to hold her hand. "I don't want to be an artist like all the rest of them who cares about status and numbers and fame. I just want to make my own music." She let out a breath. "I'm sorry if that makes you upset."

Ms. Weaver didn't respond immediately. "We'll discuss this in the morning," she finally said in a stilted voice. "Let's not rush into anything without thinking about it. There are other factors to consider."

Catra shook her head. "I'm not changing my mind. I don't want to be fake. I don't want to be anyone other than myself."

"We'll discuss this in the morning," Ms. Weaver repeated sternly. Adora saw her grip on the steering wheel tighten. Catra nodded softly, then moved over to the middle seat so she could lean against Adora.

Adora moved her arm around Catra's back to give the pop star more room. As Catra made herself comfortable, Adora felt a deep contentment. Today had been a little too much excitement for her. Between dressing up, being in an unfamiliar environment, and of course dealing with Wallace Lawless, she could use a solid week

of monotony to relax. Of course, she thought fondly as she pushed a hand gently through her client's hair, nothing was ever really boring with Catra around.

"She's very comfortable with you, isn't she?"

Ms. Weaver's voice cut through the silence, and Adora looked up to see her gaze pointed at them in the rearview mirror. Adora nodded hesitantly, unsure of what response the manager was looking for.

Evidently that was enough, as the rest of the car ride was spent in silence. Adora continued to run her hand through Catra's hair, watching her rise and fall gently against Adora's shoulder. Their legs pressed against each other, and Catra's tail gently curled around Adora's ankle.

It was almost perfect. Adora leaned back against the headrest, trying to fall asleep. Even though she'd barely exercised today, her body felt exhausted. With Catra pressed softly against her, she felt comfortable enough to drift off.

But no matter how she adjusted her head, she couldn't escape the feeling of being watched, and the distinct image of Ms. Weaver's eyes in the rearview mirror.

Memory of a Melody

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

True to her word, Catra refused to sing any of Ms. Weaver's material.

The manager carried on the next morning as if nothing had happened, entering the penthouse after lunch to summon her protégé to the studio for another practice session. Perhaps she hoped Catra's vow would be forgotten amidst all the champagne and excitement of the Etheria Awards. But while the pop star looked even groggier than usual, she remained firm in her commitment. She would write her own music, and wouldn't accept anyone else's.

"Catra, be realistic. Crafting your own songs is an admirable goal. But there's simply no time." Ms. Weaver placed a hand on Catra's shoulder, standing behind her as the pop star munched half-heartedly on a granola bar. "I have a meeting with Hordak's board of directors this Wednesday. They'll want to see measurable results."

Catra groaned. "Well, they can want whatever they want. Tell them I'm working on it." She took a long sip of water, coughing softly as she swallowed.

Ms. Weaver's voice remained even, but Adora saw her fingers curl and uncurl at her side. "We don't have time for you to work on it. We're already behind schedule." She sat next to Catra at the counter. "These people control your future and mine. If they don't think you're being productive, they will take steps to correct that. They will want to see an album, or at least the makings of one."

"Well, I don't have an album."

"No, you don't," said Ms. Weaver, a note of intensity in her voice. "But I do. And unless you produce one by next Wednesday, that is what we'll be showing the board. Now come down to the studio and practice." She stood abruptly and walked towards the elevator, beckoning Catra to follow.

"No."

Ms. Weaver paused. "What was that?" Adora gulped, wishing there were some way she could intervene.

"No!" Catra narrowed her eyes. "I told you. I don't care about the directors. I don't care if we're late on the album. And I don't care if everyone else in this stupid industry does it." She jumped to her feet. "*I'm* writing this album. I've already started, and even if it takes years, I'll finish. I'm not going to use anyone else's songs."

"You've already started?" Ms. Weaver turned around, a surprised note in her voice. "Show me."

Catra's ears flicked downwards, and she glanced at Adora so quickly the bodyguard almost thought she imagined it. "I have a song, but... it's not ready yet."

"Wonderful." Ms. Weaver turned back to the elevator. "We need an album by Wednesday, and you have one song that isn't even ready to perform." She opened the door and stepped inside. "Fine. You do not have to practice today. But we are not done with this discussion. I will not stand idly by and watch you ruin your career." She reached to press the button for her floor, then paused. "Perhaps you can use this time to reflect on your priorities. What is truly important to you and what...could be compromised on." Her gaze flashed over Adora almost as quickly as Catra's had. The bodyguard looked back uncertainly, uncomfortable with the attention. Did she have something on her face?

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With that, the truce that had settled between Ms. Weaver and Catra before the Etheria Awards disintegrated. The pop star and her manager could barely be in the same room anymore without an argument breaking out. Ms. Weaver accused Catra of being naive and irresponsible; Catra declared that Ms. Weaver was simply trying to control yet another aspect of her life. Adora felt like she should speak up in her client's defense, but she didn't really know how.

As Wednesday crept closer and closer, Catra redoubled her album-writing efforts. She kept her notebook with her at all times, rotating spots throughout the apartment as the days went on. She moved from her bed, to the counter, to her beanbag (adjusting it every few hours to follow the sunbeams coming into the room), to Adora's bed, back to her bed — sometimes she would just lie facedown on the floor and demand not to be bothered. Adora watched her client with concern; she'd never seen Catra so single-minded.

Adora tried to give her space, knowing how important this was to her. But the bodyguard's curiosity was getting to her. Monday evening, as the sunlight entering the room was becoming more orange than yellow, Catra gave a cry of frustration and threw her notebook aside. Adora eyed her gingerly from behind a pile of halfway sorted fanmail. "Everything okay?" she asked.

Catra lay back on Adora's bed, groaning as she stretched out. "Oh, everything's fantastic. I'm making incredible progress. Not worried at all about what's going to happen at the board meeting when I show up with nothing."

The bodyguard nodded sympathetically. She definitely felt pressure to succeed when they had evaluations at Brightmoon, and sometimes even when guarding Catra. But it must be totally different for someone with such a large following. "What are you writing about?" she asked, both hoping to distract her client from her predicament and genuinely interested.

Catra sighed. "Well, I'm working on a couple different songs. But lately I've been trying to write one about this whole stalker situation. It's caused me to realize a few things."

"Really?" Adora leaned in, curious to hear how Catra was processing it. Truth be told, she'd been trying to gauge the pop star's feelings about being stalked for a while now. Normally Catra just treated it like a big joke, but Adora knew she'd been upset when they first received the letter.

"Yeah," said Catra, sitting up to grin mischievously at Adora. "I've realized that writing a pop anthem about a stalker is freaking *hard*."

Adora laughed despite herself. "I can't imagine why," she deadpanned.

Catra snickered. "Seriously! I've tried so many different angles. It just feels anticlimactic. 'Oh no, I don't leave the apartment now.' And whenever I try to dress it up or make it more exciting, I feel dishonest. I mean, I could totally write a song about a sexy stalker where it's like, thrilling and dangerous. But that's just...not the reality."

"That makes sense." Adora's already substantial resolve to stop the stalker increased even further upon considering the stalker had the potential to be sexy and exciting. Her client had more than enough to deal with already.

"Right? Ugh! Everything in my life is so *boring*! Even this creep is boring, and he wrote me a poem about how badly he wanted to kill me." Catra lay back down on the bed. "Tell me something, Adora. Anything. Just something about your life that's going on."

Adora scratched her head. "Uh, let's see. I mean, I spend most of my time with you, so I feel like you know most of it. Hmm. Oh! I was going to talk to you about this, actually. My best friends, Bow and Glimmer, are moving soon. They found a really nice place

near their campus, so they're finally moving out of their parents' houses. It's a big moment."

"Imagine being somewhere new, with no supervision..." Catra sighed wistfully. "Good for them! Why did you want to tell me, though?"

"Well, I promised I'd help them move — I'd have to take a day off, probably this weekend. Is that okay?"

Catra nodded. "It's not like anything will be going on here," she muttered glumly. "You might not even have a job by then once the bosses realize I don't have any music yet."

Adora walked over to the bed, sitting down next to Catra's head. "Hey, don't say that. You'll think of something," she said earnestly. "And if you don't, I'm sure they'll understand." Catra gazed up at her, brows still furrowed, and on impulse Adora ran a hand through her hair. "You'll get past this."

"Thanks, Adora." Catra leaned into her hand, prompting Adora to continue her movements. "Keep doing that. Maybe it will finally stimulate my brain past this writer's block."

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Despite Adora's ministrations, Catra made little progress by the time Wednesday came around. Ms. Weaver appeared in the penthouse apartment early that morning to collect her for the meeting.

"Rise and shine, my dears. Today is a momentous occasion."

"I'm awake!" Catra leapt off Adora's bed, where she had taken to sleeping as of late. She said being next to someone helped her fall asleep, and with her writer's block, she needed all the sleep she could get. Adora had no objections.

If Ms. Weaver saw Catra's somewhat inelegant rise, or the location she rose from, she made no comment on it. "Good. We

should aim to drive out in about an hour. Do you have songs ready?"

Catra shook her head. "I have one called 'Trapped Inside,' another called 'Boredom Deconstructed,' and I'm almost done with one called 'Siri, how do I fire my manager.' I think that one is going to be the single!" She beamed at Ms. Weaver; Adora snorted, and immediately put a hand over her mouth.

Ms. Weaver sighed. "If only your survival instincts were as sharp as your wit. Please, Catra. Think about this logically. Hordak signed you to a three-year contract with a minimum of three album releases. If you break the terms of the contract, not only will you not have the resources of Hordak behind you, you'll be sued and buried in a legal dispute. You won't be able to make music at all. I know you don't feel as passionate about the music we've worked on so far, but you'll have a chance to write more once your position is secured."

"I'm not performing your stupid songs. What don't you understand about that?" Adora raised an eyebrow. Catra rarely pulled punches, but she seemed especially harsh this morning.

"Watch your tone, Catra," said Ms. Weaver, evidently agreeing with Adora. "I'm still your manager. And we still have to make an album, regardless of your feelings on the matter."

Catra folded her arms. "Let's go to the board meeting, then. I'll be happy to explain that I'm *trying* to work on the next album, but it's been a little *difficult* on account of the fact that my manager controls every aspect of my life."

"Have you forgotten the threats we received? I don't like the situation any more than you do, but your safety is non-negotiable." Ms. Weaver paused for a moment, then continued more quietly. "You are certain, then? You would rather present nothing to the people who decide your future than show my— our songs?" Catra nodded. "You're making a mistake." The silence lingered; Catra's expression didn't waver. Ms. Weaver sighed

again. "Well, if you insist on this foolish course of action, let me see if I can at least buy you some time." She pulled out a phone from her pocket, walking back into the elevator. "I'll see if we can push back the meeting, but get ready, just in case."

Catra stared after her as she vanished behind the closing doors. "Is she...trying to help me?"

"Seems that way." Adora and her client looked at each other in confusion. "I mean, that's...good, right?"

Catra's brows furrowed. "You'd think." Adora shot her a questioning glance. "Shadow Weaver always has some sort of angle," Catra elaborated. "She's not just doing this to be nice. I just don't know what the angle is yet."

"I mean, she mentioned that these are her bosses too, right? It makes sense that she would want to make a good impression on them."

"Yeah, that could be it." Catra didn't look convinced. "Well, whatever. She *would* wait until the last possible moment to let me know postponing it was an option, wouldn't she. She's so obsessed with getting this album out."

Adora nodded. She usually tried to stay neutral in the conflict between the pop star and her manager, but Ms. Weaver had really been amping up the pressure on Catra as of late. Adora understood that the album was important, but it seemed to her like Ms. Weaver's efforts were having the opposite of their intended results; the more Ms. Weaver harped on how important it was to release the album as soon as possible, the more difficulty Catra seemed to have writing it.

Maybe she could talk to Ms. Weaver about this, Adora realized. Despite the current tension, Ms. Weaver had said on more than one occasion that she cared about Catra's happiness. If Adora let her know the current approach wasn't working, maybe she would adjust her behavior. Of course, Catra wasn't exactly shy about

letting Ms. Weaver know that, but maybe hearing it from Adora could change Ms. Weaver's mind.

Just as she was about to share her intentions with Catra, the elevator dinged once more and Ms. Weaver glided back into the room. "You have one week," she said unceremoniously.

"Thanks, I guess." Catra folded her arms. "But I hope you know that even if I haven't written anything by next week, I'm still not going to present anyone else's songs."

"Of all the uncertainties in this world, your stubbornness is not one of them." Ms. Weaver turned back to the elevator. "I look forward to seeing what you come up with." She stepped back through the doors.

"Wait!" said Adora. "I'm planning to take a day off soon, is that okay?"

Ms. Weaver swiveled around. "Of course, dear. Why don't you accompany me to my office and we can discuss the logistics. You can take more than a day, you know. We've been working you rather non-stop since you started here."

Adora nodded, and with a final glance back at Catra, stepped into the elevator. Ms. Weaver turned to her as the doors closed in front of them.

"I apologize for not being more proactive in getting you to take time off. You're long overdue for a break."

Adora shook her head. "Thank you, but I don't need a huge vacation or anything like that. I just promised to help some friends move this weekend."

Ms. Weaver chuckled softly. "Helping others even on your day off. You're a very dependable young lady, Adora. I see why Catra relies on you so much."

"Why she, uh, what?" Adora flushed.

"You're a very steady presence in her life. She hasn't really had that." The doors opened, and Ms. Weaver led Adora through the hallways to her office. "I don't know all the details of Catra's past, and the ones I do know aren't mine to share, but she didn't have a lot of people who stuck around for her. I've tried to be that, of course, but our relationship...well, it's complicated."

Adora raised her eyebrows. Catra never really talked about her past with Adora. Even with how close they had gotten, the pop star still had a lot of walls up. Adora resolved to ask her again when she got the chance. For now, though, she had a different objective in mind. "About that," she said. "I was wondering what you might think about maybe trying a different approach with Catra."

Ms. Weaver didn't respond until they were inside her office. She shut the door and gestured Adora to sit down in the cushioned chair in front of her desk. "I'm all ears."

"Well, sometimes I feel like..." Adora trailed off. She probably should have thought through her intervention a little more; she didn't want to phrase anything in a way that sounded like she was criticizing or attacking Ms. Weaver. "I think Catra's feeling a lot of pressure right now, and I think she might be able to write more effectively if she had a little more freedom. Both with the timeline and just in general."

The manager took a moment to consider her statement, sitting down behind her desk. "And what do you suggest?" she asked.

Taking a deep breath, Adora went forward. "Well, Catra probably won't have an album by next Wednesday. Why not let the directors know she's not able to work on it productively while we deal with the stalker situation? Just to give her some more time to work with." Now that she had started, she found the words flowing from her lips, like water finally breaking free from a dam.

"And even though we have to stay vigilant because of the stalker, there must be some events or activities she can do without

compromising her safety. You mentioned you might be able to line up something like that before the Etheria Awards. I think Catra would really appreciate that. And I think it would help her write this album, too."

Again, Ms. Weaver was silent for a moment. "You've been thinking about this a great deal, it seems," she remarked.

Adora ran a hand through her hair. "I guess I have." She wasn't sure where all of that had come from, but it rang true as she said it. She cared about Catra, and seeing her so frustrated and stressed about her music was upsetting. Adora remembered watching Catra perform, how she seemed to feed off the crowd's energy and revel in the spotlight. And she remembered Catra telling her about how good it felt to share her feelings and thoughts with the world through her songs. Those memories provided a stark contrast to Catra's current relationship to songwriting.

"You're right." Adora looked up in surprise. "You're right, of course. I'd have to be blind to not see the pressure that poor girl is under. Believe me, the last thing I want to do is negatively impact her well-being." Ms. Weaver sighed. "Unfortunately, I don't have all that much agency in the matter. Pushing back the meeting with the directors for a week is one thing; postponing it inevitably is another one entirely. I don't think you understand how lucrative Catra's debut album was for Hordak, or how important she is to the label. She's the biggest star on Hordak's roster by far. They have high expectations and standards for her, not to mention a legally binding three album contract. Nonetheless, I'll see what I can do." She steepled her fingers. "As for your request for safe excursions, I will look into that further. I must confess my worry for Catra's safety has made me wary of even the slightest risks. But I can't disagree that it's important for her to find time outside of here, even if I'd like to."

Adora blinked. Well, that went better than she was worried it might have. "Thank you," she said. "Catra will really appreciate this, I know."

Ms. Weaver hummed softly. "I should be the one thanking you, Adora. You've made my path forward abundantly clear. Now, what times exactly will you be taking off?"

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"Please don't scrape the car, please don't scrape the car....yes!" Glimmer cheered as she successfully turned the U-Haul on to a narrow side street.

Bow winced. "Are you sure you don't want me to drive?" He and Adora were squished into the passenger seat; they hadn't thought to account for U-Hauls only having front seats, and though Perfuma was en route with her pickup truck, she had to make a few stops first and told them to start without her.

Adora smirked, though she was pretty sure Bow couldn't see her face at the angle they were sitting at. They both knew the answer to that question, if not from years of friendship with Glimmer, from the first three times Bow had asked. But Adora supposed some feelings had to be voiced.

"Don't be silly!" Glimmer laughed. "Besides, we're almost there."

At Ms. Weaver's urging, Adora had decided to take the whole weekend off, even though Bow and Glimmer only needed her help on Saturday. She was beginning to think that having another day to relax after today was the right decision.

Thankfully, they parked without incident, finding a nice spot on the same block as the new house. "I'm excited to see this place," said Adora, stretching as she hopped out of the car. "The pictures you showed me looked really nice."

"Yeah, it's super cute," Glimmer replied. "Plus campus is like two minutes away, and we're only a ten minute walk from Starla's, that cafe I really like." She closed her door. "Let's go check it out, and then we can start moving things in!" She skipped down the sidewalk, Bow and Adora trailing after her.

"I feel like I just lost a year of my life on that ride." Bow glanced back at the car as if he couldn't quite believe it was still intact, then took a deep breath in and out. "But it's fine. We're all here and we're all safe." He grinned. "It *is* a great place. I'm almost surprised we were able to get it, to be honest. But I think most students aren't looking for places until fall semester starts, and besides..." he looked both ways before leaning in conspiratorily. "The landlord is kinda scary. She's super tall and jacked, has a long white ponytail, and gives off a total 'don't fuck with me' vibe. And she lives *right* there." Bow gestured to a rather foreboding looking crimson and black house across the street.

Adora raised her eyebrows. "That's pretty intense."

"She wasn't mean to us or anything, but...let's just say I'm *never* going to be late on rent. Ever."

Adora laughed as they stopped at the front steps and looked up. In contrast to the one across the street, this house was painted bright lavender, with elegant white columns supporting an awning over the door.

"Come on in, guys! I'll show you around!" Glimmer poked her head out of the doorway. "Ahhh! This is so exciting!"

Bow and Adora grinned at each other and let themselves be swept up by the energy of the pink-haired girl. She pulled them through the doorway.

"Alright, we have the living room, bathroom, dining area, tea nook, and the kitchen. Bow and I's bedrooms are on the second floor along with the full bathroom. But the most important stop on our grand tour is...the backyard!" Glimmer pulled open the back door to reveal a small, but very green, backyard. "Ta da!" She skipped down the few steps that led down from the door. "Look, it even has a waterfall!

Huh. There was, indeed, a small waterfall in the back corner of the yard. Adora approached it cautiously, trying to discern its

function and inner mechanisms. "Is the waterfall for showering?"

"Ha!" Glimmer threw back her head and laughed. "Good one Adora."

Bow snickered beside her. "Waterfall for showering."

Just then, the doorbell rang. "That must be Perfuma!" Glimmer bounced up the steps and over to the front door, Bow and Adora following close behind. Sure enough, a blonde woman in a bright pink dress smiled at them through the window, both hands wrapped around a medium sized fern.

"Hello everyone! It's so good to see you! I'm glad that the universe put us all together once more!" Perfuma put her plant down on the living room table and proceeded to hug everyone. "Oh, and this place is gorgeous! I love all the natural light!"

"It's great to see you, too." Adora smiled warmly as she embraced her friend. Perfuma had been Adora's roommate for her entire time at Brightmoon, and while one or both of them were off on assignment more often than not, she had talked through a lot of Adora's initial doubts and insecurities about being a bodyguard. She had always been a reassuring presence. Adora bent down to look at the fern on the table. "And it's nice to see you again as well, George! It's been a while."

Perfuma ran a finger down one of George's leaves. "He's just not getting enough attention in our room. Whenever I'm away for a job, he gets lonely, and sure, Angella will *water* him, but she looks at me like I'm crazy whenever I ask her to just throw him some gentle words of encouragement once in a while. He needs a new home." She shook her head. "No offense, Glimmer."

"None taken." Glimmer shrugged. "Mom was never one for gentle words of encouragement." She picked up the fern and placed it on a side table by a window in the living room. "Welcome to the home, George! Oh, this is perfect! Did you bring any other plants?"

"Ha!" Perfuma giggled. "Good one Glimmer. 'Did I bring any other plants.' Oh, you're too funny." She pointed out the doorway at the end of the street, where her truck was barely visible underneath all the greenery in the back.

Glimmer clapped her hands gleefully. "Amazing! How did you get so many!"

"I brought some clippings from my apartment and then picked up some from a friend. The rest I rescued from the street on the way here." Perfuma shook her head vehemently. "Can you believe someone would give up on those beauties?"

"Alright, here's the plan." Adora gathered her friends in a huddle. "We'll start by unloading the heaviest things from the U-Haul and bringing them into the living room, which we'll use as a staging ground. Once we've got the big ticket items out of the way, Perfuma can peel off and bring in the plants while you two bring the rest of your stuff in. I'll provide general support wherever I'm needed most. Now, I've been studying the layout, and I broke the house down into quadrants. The most efficient way for us to..." She trailed off as she saw the amused looks on her friends' faces. "What?"

"Oh, nothing." Glimmer smiled fondly at her. "I think you may need a break from bodyguarding, though."

Perfuma patted Adora's back as she walked towards the doorway. "Yeah, that was straight out of the Operations Manual."

"Well I, for one, appreciate having some strategic expertise on our side." Bow pulled her into a one-armed side hug. "Let's do this, guys!"

As she followed her friends outside, Adora smiled to herself. She *had* been spending all her time bodyguarding recently. But bodyguarding Catra felt a lot different than the other assignments she'd had.

Her mind went to the pop star, probably splayed out somewhere in her apartment writing music, or at least trying to. It didn't seem fair that Catra never got to experience the easy camaraderie Adora felt with her friends. Adora couldn't imagine how it must feel to spend all her time in one building, unable to go outside or interact with anyone outside of a select few people. It would be awful.

Though, she supposed, if she could hang out with Catra all the time, it wouldn't be unbearable.

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Using Adora's tactics, they made quick work of the bed frames and mattresses piled in the U-Haul, and moved on to the smaller boxes. Between those and Perfuma's plants, they were quickly beginning to fill the living room, and Adora paused to consider the possibility of expanding the staging ground into the dining room. Before she could properly weigh that against the operational cost of moving the bed frames upstairs to free up space, however, her pocket buzzed.

It was her Hordak phone, and Adora pulled it out immediately, ready for an emergency. But it was just a selfie of Catra stretched out in her beanbag. As she looked at the picture, admiring Catra's le— admiring the patterns of sunlight on Catra's legs, another message came in from the pop star.

i'm bored. send me some pics of the new apartment

Adora smiled. Easy enough. She snapped a few pictures of the kitchen and dining room, then went into the bathroom to document the succulents that Perfuma had artfully arranged on the windowsill.

not bad, looks super cute actually! now send me some pics of you lifting things

Adora raised an eyebrow. Why would she...

it's for my writer's block

Adora didn't really understand how that would help, but far be it for her to stand in the way of the artistic process.

"Glimmer?" she asked.

"Just a second!" came the reply from outside the door. "Actually, can you give me a hand with this thing? It's a little heavier than I — ahh!" Adora jumped over to the doorway to help Glimmer balance the massive box in her arms. They slowly walked it over to the side of the living room.

"Whew! Thanks Adora. My mom was really excited when I told her I got a record player, and she gave me a bunch of her old records she had from when she was younger. I think she went a little overboard though." Glimmer sighed. "To be honest, I think she mostly just wanted them out of the house. But until my vinyl copy of *Golden Hour* comes in the mail, it's all we have for music." The smaller girl opened the top of the box and pulled out a record from the middle. "Cyndi Lauper, huh? I can work with this. Now, what were you saying?"

Adora rubbed the back of her neck. "Do you mind taking a few pictures of me, uh, lifting things?"

Glimmer guffawed. "Uh, no, I guess? What is this for? Are you setting up a Tinder profile or something?"

"No!" Adora flushed. "It's not anything like that. Catra just wanted some because she's really bored and has writer's block."

"Wait." Glimmer grinned. "She asked you for a picture of you lifting things?"

"Yup."

"For her *writer's block*?"

"Mhmm."

"And you just...accepted that?"

Adora shrugged. "I'm not a singer. Everyone has their own process."

"I'm seeing a whole lot of talking and not a whole lot of helping me unload the van, guys," said Bow, stepping through the doorway with two boxes stacked on top of each other.

Glimmer giggled. "Sorry, Bow. We'll get right to it. I just have to take some pictures of Adora carrying things so she can flirt with the world famous pop star she's contracted to bodyguard."

"Glimmer!" Adora crossed her arms. "That's not what's happening and you know it."

"You're right," said Glimmer, her grin only growing wider. "Really, she's the one flirting with you."

Bow put his boxes down with a thump. "Adora, that's amazing news. We'll do whatever we can to support you."

Adora rolled her eyes. "She's not flirting with me, she's just bored and trying to deal with writer's block. Now are you going to help me or not?"

"Whatever you say!" Glimmer sang, not even trying to hide the smirk on her face as she skipped across the room. "Now, pick up that box and pretend it's really heavy."

"But not too heavy," chimed Bow. "Not for you."

"Yeah, like you're a little strained, but it's nothing you can't handle."

"Can you hurry up and take the picture?" Adora huffed. "This box *is* heavy."

"Hey!" Glimmer put her hands on her hips. "Don't rush me! We have a story to tell and we are not doing it halfway."

...

After an enthusiastic photoshoot that netted approximately three photos Adora could send Catra while maintaining some shred of dignity, they finished unpacking everything from the U-Haul and collapsed on the couch. Perfuma handed out bottles of a purple-brownish organic energy drink that smelled vaguely of grass.

"It's not bad," mused Adora, prompting Bow and Glimmer to hand her theirs surreptitiously. Perfuma beamed in response.

"Don't you feel recharged? There's so many antioxidants in here. Since I'm such a free spirit, I have an unusually high amount of free radicals, and this really helps keep them under control."

As Perfuma explained free radicals and their harmful effect on human cells, Adora relaxed into the cushion, letting the conversation wash over her. She had missed this. Of course she loved hanging out with Catra, but Hordak felt like such a tense environment. It was nice to switch out of bodyguard mode and just be a person. She took another sip of the grass juice; it was starting to grow on her.

The hours went on. They danced to music from Glimmer's new record player, running through every artist they recognized in Angella's collection and then moving on to albums with interesting names or cover art. Eventually, they ordered pizza to commemorate the new home, digging in at the dining table Glimmer had haggled for on Facebook Marketplace (though according to Bow, it was more intimidation than negotiation).

"So it seems like you and Catra are getting along really well, huh?"

Adora glared at Glimmer, who maintained an innocent expression. Perfuma clapped her hands. "Ooooo, bodyguarding drama! Tell me everything."

"There's not really much to tell," said Adora. Bow and Glimmer waggled their eyebrows at her. "No, really. I mean, Catra's really

fun to be around, but we've mostly been stuck in her apartment for the past few weeks."

"In her apartment together...all alone?" asked Bow, eyes sparkling.

Adora flushed. "Not like that, Bow! I'm her *bodyguard*. She's mostly been working on her new album. She's under a lot of pressure to put it out."

"I'll bet." Glimmer leaned back in her chair, stretching her arms above her head. "I can't imagine how it must feel to have so many fans all waiting on you. And her first album set the bar so high."

Adora tilted her head to the side. "I don't know. I mean, I'm sure there's some element of that. But Catra's always looked so at ease with her fans. I think her manager is putting way more pressure on her than any sort of expectations." She scratched her head. "Actually, I'm not sure how much I should say about all this. I may have signed an NDA at some point early on."

"That is definitely juicy, though." Perfuma smiled at her. "And you talk about her with such familiarity. I mean, it sounds like the two of you spend a lot of time together."

Adora nodded mutely, not wanting to encourage any further discussion on the topic. But she knew she wouldn't escape that easily.

Glimmer looked at her inquisitively. "Is she...you know..." She made a suggestive face, though Adora wasn't quite sure what it was suggesting.

"Is she what?"

Glimmer and Bow glanced at each other. "Does she wear a lot of flannel?" asked Bow.

"No? I mean, she probably has one or two..." Adora furrowed her eyebrows. "Where are you going with this?"

Her friends exchanged another glance, and Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Is she a woman who loves other women?"

"What?!" Adora flushed again. "That's not a — why would — how would I know something like that?"

"Look," said Glimmer. "I'm just gonna say it. There is no straight explanation for her asking for pictures of you lifting things. Not one." Bow nodded emphatically in agreement. "Besides, I've always thought that her song "Force Captain" has pretty sapphic undertones."

Adora's heart beat faster. Could Catra actually...was that actually a possibility? She'd always been so quick to shut off her own unprofessional thoughts, or at least try to, that she'd never even considered them being reciprocated. They did spend so much time together, and Catra seemed to enjoy her presence...but no, she shouldn't think about this. Not when she was contracted to protect her. Her duty was to be a reliable bodyguard to her client, and thoughts like this would only get in the way. But even so...

"Come on, guys, Adora doesn't have to talk about it if she doesn't want to." Perfuma rose to stand behind Adora's chair and lightly massaged Adora's back. "Besides, if the universe wants it to happen, it will happen. Just like you guys were meant to find this place!"

Bow began to detail the process of the apartment search, and Adora leaned back, grateful for the change in topic. She had trouble following the conversation, though, her mind still racing. As she tried to think about something besides her client, she found that the song playing in the background sounded eerily familiar. She cocked her head and focused completely on the music.

What good are apologies if the damage is deep
Now you're nothing to me but a secret to keep

Yes, it was definitely familiar. The beat was slightly slower, and the style of singing was a little different, but... this was the song Catra had performed for her and Ms. Weaver in the studio a few weeks ago! One of the songs Ms. Weaver was trying to get Catra to include on her album.

Adora stood abruptly. The conversation came to a halt as her friends looked at her.

"Everything okay, Adora?" asked Bow.

Adora didn't answer, moving instead over to the record player. She picked up the empty album sleeve on the top of the stack they had pulled out from the huge box of Angella's old records.

"*Memory of a Melody*, by Light Spinner," it read on the front, in black text over a plain white background.

"Who put this on?"

Glimmer skipped over to stand beside her. "I did! I just thought Light Spinner was a cool name. Why, do you know them?"

Adora turned to Bow and Perfuma. "Have you guys heard of Light Spinner?" They both shook their heads. "Glimmer, where did your mom get this record?"

The pink-haired girl shrugged. "Uh, no idea. She doesn't really buy records anymore; most of this stuff is from at least a decade ago." She raised an eyebrow at Adora. "What's got you so curious? It sounds like you've heard this before."

"I have." Adora flipped over the album, examining the credits on the back. There were only two songs on the record; "Memory of a Melody" was the single, and the B-side was a song called "Enchanted Moon." Small print underneath each song read "written by Selene Weaver."

She stepped back in shock. She didn't know Ms. Weaver's first name, but...how could it be anyone else? Her mind raced through the possibilities. Had Ms. Weaver fostered another singer before Catra? Why would she use the same songs? And why use Catra if she already had a protégé?

"Adora, what's going on?" Bow grabbed her by the shoulders. "You're really freaking me out right now."

"Sorry! Sorry. I'm just..." Adora took a deep breath. "Catra's manager...look, I don't think I'm supposed to share any of this information, so please don't tell anyone. But like I said earlier, Catra's been having writer's block recently, and her manager has been writing songs for her. And this is one of them."

"What?!" Glimmer exclaimed. "That's plagiarism, then."

Adora shook her head. "That's the thing. I think she *wrote* this song. It says this is written by Selene Weaver, and I'm pretty sure that's her name."

"So she also worked with Light Spinner?" Perfuma mused. "It's not unusual for managers to have multiple clients, though it is strange that she's using the same song. Maybe Catra's doing it as a cover?"

"That's possible." Adora put her hand on her chin as she considered the options. "Ms. Weaver didn't say anything about that, though. We need to find out who Light Spinner is and where she is now."

"On it," said Bow, typing on his phone intently. "There's not much, but there are a few old articles about this single coming out. It doesn't seem like she made any other songs."

Glimmer peered around Bow's shoulder at the screen. "Well, what happened to her? She can't have just vanished." They scrolled through the results. "But there's really nothing else there, huh. She never released anything else."

"That doesn't make sense." Adora frowned. "Ms. Weaver has a whole album of songs, at least. I guess she might not have written them at that point. But she's *so* focused on Catra getting songs out. It's hard to believe that she and Light Spinner would just...stop."

"Maybe they had a disagreement?" Glimmer asked. "I mean, that happens. Not everyone is as supportive as Jason Owen." The rest of them looked at her in confusion. "Kacey Musgraves' manager," she clarified. "He actually won a manager of the year award last year."

"Or maybe they decided to part ways amicably?" offered Perfuma. "Perhaps Light Spinner realized the universe had a different path for her than being a singer."

Perhaps. But from what Adora had seen of Ms. Weaver...

"Oh! Here's something!" said Bow excitedly. "It's from a longer interview with a record executive. They're asking about new signings...oh." Bow's jaw dropped. "She got in a car crash."

"What?" In two quick steps, Adora moved next to Bow, craning her neck to read the text on the screen.

You've had some exciting debuts from new artists recently; seems like everyone loves Prince Peekablue and Light Spinner's new records. What should we expect from them next?

Unfortunately, Light Spinner was recently involved in a car accident. She's alive and well, but it will be awhile before she releases music again. Our thoughts and prayers are with her as she recovers. Prince Peekablue, on the other hand, will be releasing his debut album in November. It's tentatively titled "Farsight Blues."

That's awful news about Light Spinner, I hope she gets better soon! Let's talk about Prince Peekablue, though —

he blew us all away with "Sweet Bee's Honey." What can we expect from the full album?

Bow scratched his head. "Okay. So Light Spinner released one of Ms. Weaver's songs, but then got hurt and couldn't release any more music. And now, ten years later, Ms. Weaver is trying to get Catra to make the same songs."

"Right." Adora folded her arms uneasily. "And she's...she can be kind of intense when she's trying to get Catra to do these songs instead of taking the time to write her own. In retrospect, it makes sense that she's personally tied to them. I just wonder how far she would go."

Glimmer turned to her in surprise. "You don't think she did something to Light Spinner, do you?"

"I don't know. I mean, that sounds crazy. And Ms. Weaver's seemed more reasonable lately. But she's definitely been hiding things from us." Catra's words echoed in Adora's mind. *"Shadow Weaver always has some sort of angle. I just don't know what it is yet."* "I need to go back to Hordak," she said suddenly. "I need to make sure Catra is okay."

Bow's eyes widened. "This is pretty serious, huh?"

Adora nodded. "I have to check. Even if it's nothing." She winced at Bow and Glimmer. "Sorry for ditching you guys. Hopefully this is nothing and I can come hang out again soon."

"Don't worry about it." Glimmer shook her head. "I'm kinda worried too, to be honest. I hope Catra is okay."

"Come on, I'll give you a ride," said Perfuma. "I should be heading home soon anyway."

After saying goodbye to her friends and hopping in Perfuma's truck, Adora pulled out her Hordak phone and tapped out a message.

Hey Catra I need to talk to you about something. I'm headed back to Hordak now.

Adora sighed in relief as Catra's typing bubble came up almost instantaneously.

oh? sounds dramatic

I wanna talk about something with you too actually! I finally finished my song — the pics were really helpful ;) I want you to be the first one to hear it

Adora stared at her phone. For once, the nerves running through her stomach had nothing to do with her client's behavior. On another day, she'd give anything for the chance to hear one of the songs Catra had been working on. But now, all she could think about was Ms. Weaver's cold gaze in the rearview mirror as they drove back from the Etheria Awards, and how far the manager might go to reach her goals.

...

After squeezing her hand and making her do a quick round of self-affirmations, Perfuma dropped her off in front of the Hordak Records building.

Adora took a deep breath as she pushed open the double doors. A security guard sat in Scorpia's usual seat, raising a questioning eyebrow at her.

"I'm Catra's bodyguard," said Adora, trying to put as much confidence and authority into her voice as she could. She offered her lanyard to the guard, who studied her for a moment, then shrugged and scanned the ID card. After a few moments, he handed it back and waved her forward.

As she rode up in the elevator, Adora tried to figure out exactly what she was going to say. It's possible there was a reasonable explanation for the Light Spinner situation, but Ms. Weaver had at the very least kept information from them, and at the very

worst...well, Adora didn't want to think about the very worst scenario.

She took another deep breath as the elevator came to a halt. Whatever the truth of the situation was, Catra deserved to know what they had discovered about her manager's past.

"Hey Adora." Catra grinned at her from atop the granite counter before sliding off and approaching her. "You really can't stay away from me, huh?"

Adora flushed. "I wanted to make sure you were okay."

Her client laughed. "You're ridiculous, you know that? I don't think you've even been gone 24 hours." She reached over and lightly tapped a finger against Adora's forehead. "I appreciate the concern, though. You're quite the dedicated bodyguard. But did you really just come back to see if I was okay? Or was there something else on your mind?" Catra sounded uncharacteristically hesitant.

Adora paused, wondering how best to convey the whole story. "There's something I need to tell you that couldn't wait." Catra nodded, taking a step closer to her. "I was out with Bow and Glimmer today...well, I guess you already know that. We were moving them in, and Glimmer got a turntable, and we were playing some of her mom's old records, and...have you ever heard the name Light Spinner?"

Catra's brows furrowed. "Um, no? Where are you going with this?"

"She was a pop singer about a decade or so ago. And she also worked with Ms. Weaver. She released one of the songs that Ms. Weaver wrote that you guys were practicing before. But she didn't release anything else and we found out that Light Spinner actually got into an accident and never made any music again. And you and Ms. Weaver have been arguing and I remember you saying that she always had an angle and it turns out she's been trying to get her music out for years and I was worried that she might do

something to you especially if I wasn't here." Adora took a moment to breathe. "Sorry, I know that was a lot."

"Yeah...wow." Catra stepped back. "That's...not what I was expecting." Her hand rose to her chin, and she paced back and forth in front of her bodyguard. "So she worked with someone before me, huh? And she also made them perform songs that she wrote?" Catra shook her head. "She's really never satisfied. I thought she was just being a hardass with me, but to think this is so long in the making..." She turned to Adora. "What happened to Light Spinner?"

"She got in a car accident. And maybe it was just a car accident. But maybe..."

"Maybe it was an 'accident'?"

"Yeah."

"Shit." Catra's ears twitched. "The elevator's coming up."

"What?" Adora jumped, glancing at the as of yet motionless elevator door. "Do you think it's her?"

Catra nodded grimly. "Who else? Well, no time like the present, I guess. I need answers."

"Catra, wait." Adora put a hand on her shoulder. "Try not to provoke her too much, okay? We don't know what happened to Light Spinner. Maybe it was nothing. But we know she really, really wants you to make these songs. Please don't do anything reckless."

The popstar stuck her tongue out at her bodyguard, and Adora felt a smirk come to her face despite the situation. "Relax, Adora. I'm not afraid of Shadow Weaver. Besides, you're here to protect me, right? She can't do anything if we're together."

A warm feeling spread through Adora's chest. "Right."

The elevator dinged. Even before the doors opened, Ms. Weaver's voice came through.

"Catra? I need to speak with you. I was looking over your contract, and we need to release this album sooner than I thought. The directors..." she trailed off as she stepped into the room to see the two of them. "Adora? What are you doing back here so soon?"

Catra stepped forward, jabbing an accusing finger towards her manager. "She came back because she was worried about me. Because she found out that you've been lying to us."

Ms. Weaver's eyes narrowed. "Is that so?"

"I'm not the first pop singer you've tried to 'mold,' am I." Catra folded her arms. "What did you do to Light Spinner?"

"Light Spinner?" Ms. Weaver took a step back. "Now that's a name I haven't heard in a very long time."

"What happened to her?" asked Adora, laser-focused on the woman in front of her. If she made a single move that indicated she might hurt Catra...

"You need not concern yourself with events so buried in the past. Light Spinner is long gone."

Catra's eyebrows shot up. "She's *gone*? What does that mean? What did you do?"

Ms. Weaver laughed, a slow, sinister chuckle that echoed throughout the room. "You two really don't have any idea what you're talking about, do you. How did you even hear that name?"

Adora and Catra glanced at each other. "I heard one of the songs you made Catra sing," the blonde said. "From a record released a decade ago. Released by Light Spinner. Written by Selene Weaver."

"I see." Ms. Weaver's voice was dangerously wry. "And why exactly do you think I've done something to this Light Spinner?"

"She had an accident and stopped releasing music." Catra glared up at her manager. "Is that what would happen to me if I continued to refuse to sing your songs? I'd have an accident, and you'd find another up and coming singer to make your stupid album?"

The masked woman laughed again. "I'm sorry, dears. I don't mean to mock you. But you've constructed a version of reality very different from the truth."

Catra scowled. "Stop dodging the question then. What did you do to Light Spinner?"

Ms. Weaver's head whirled to Catra, all traces of amusement gone in an instant. "Foolish girl. You should be asking yourself that. I *am* Light Spinner."

"What?" The singer stepped back in shock. "You're...a singer?"

"You think my passion for music is simply that of a manager? You think I dreamed of helping someone else attain fame and glory? No. There was a time when I too yearned to perform onstage. To revel in the adoration of the crowd and share my stories and emotions with the audience." Her eyes bore into Catra. "A time when I was exactly like you."

Catra shook her head. "I can't believe it. But how...wait, you said I should ask myself what happened to Light Spinner. What do you mean? We only started working together a few years ago."

Ms. Weaver stood very still for a moment. "Perhaps, but our paths intersected earlier than you know."

Adora glanced over at Catra, nervous. She wasn't exactly sure how she expected this confrontation to go, but she definitely did not expect whatever was happening now. Before either of them could speak, though, the manager began her story.

"It started nearly fifteen years ago. My entrance to the industry wasn't quite as smooth as yours. Not everyone has your raw talent, or your...unique appeal." Ms. Weaver's tone made it sound like that was not a compliment. "I wasn't signed by a major label before the age of 18. I had to work my way up, performing wherever I could, singing with whoever would have me. It was years before any producer gave me a second glance."

"Norwyn." Her voice softened slightly. "He took a chance on me when no one else would. We recorded my first real single, Memory of a Melody, in his studio. I had my first taste of what it really felt like to be a star. Once it happened, I knew I couldn't stop until I had it all." She raised her hand, curling it into a fist. "We sent it to whoever we could. Labels Norwyn had an in with, labels he didn't; anyone who would take it. Finally, someone got back to us. Sorcery Records, over in Mystacor. We drove over six hours from the studio to perform for them. It went well, and they told me that they would sign me for a preliminary deal to make my debut album." Ms. Weaver gazed out the window, and her voice grew distant. "It was...everything I'd ever hoped for." She paused for a moment, then turned back towards Catra and Adora.

"My team and I celebrated in the car on the way back, but it was a long drive. Eventually, we calmed down, and most of them fell asleep in the back. I stayed awake, sitting in the passenger seat, making small talk with the driver to keep him alert. But even I was getting drowsy. Soon enough, I drifted off as well."

Ms. Weaver paced back and forth in front of them as she spoke. "When I awoke, we had just gotten off the highway, no more than half an hour from the studio. Everyone else was still asleep. I glanced over at the driver — I could tell he was getting tired, too. It was past midnight. But before I could say anything to him, something jumped out on the road."

She stopped abruptly in front of Catra, and turned to look down at her, only a foot separating the two. Catra looked a little nervous, but met her gaze without flinching.

"It was a child — a girl. She scampered across the road, but froze in the glare of the headlights. Her eyes — one yellow, one blue — were large and full of fear." Catra's eyes widened. "Yes," Ms. Weaver murmured. "Just like that. I screamed, and the driver broke out of his daze and yanked the steering wheel. The next thing I saw was a telephone pole directly in front of us. Everything past that is a blur." Adora felt a faint squeeze on her ankle, and looked down to see Catra's tail wrapped around it. "No one else saw the girl; I suppose she ran off. But I never forgot the look of those two eyes staring back at me." Ms. Weaver stared down Catra for a moment more, than resumed her pacing. "Everyone in the car survived. But the windshield shattered, and a shard of glass punctured my throat. The doctors told me I was lucky to be alive, and luckier still that I could talk. But my face was scarred, and my vocal cords were permanently damaged. I would never sing again."

"I — I'm sorry." Catra stared at Ms. Weaver, eyes still wide and mouth agape. "I remember that night. I had just been placed in a new foster home, and I...I don't know why, but I just got so scared. I decided to run away, but I was in an unfamiliar part of town and I didn't know where to go." She shivered slightly, and tucked her arms around herself. "They found out pretty quickly and started coming after me. I was just trying to get away. I remember looking at the car and thinking that was it. But the car swerved, and my new foster parents found me right after that. I didn't run away again for years."

"When I got out of the hospital, I knew everyone expected me to give up," Ms. Weaver continued, as if she hadn't even registered that Catra spoke. "I thought about it. I'd been working my whole life towards a single goal, only to have it torn from my reach just as I managed to get close enough to touch it." Her hand balled into a fist. "But I refused. I leveraged my connections within the industry to find a job scouting talent. It hurt to see girls with none of my abilities get all the opportunities I never had, but I knew I was where I had to be. I kept an eye on the promising ones, but I didn't just need promise. I needed someone inexperienced, someone malleable. Someone who I could guide on her path, who

could make the music I never got to make. For years, I searched fruitlessly. Then, one day...I went to an open mic at a bit of a seedy venue. The Fright Zone." Catra's tail tightened its squeeze on Adora's leg, and the bodyguard knew her client must have recognized the name.

"I sat through an hour of mediocrity before I saw her. And when I did, I could hardly believe it. Those same eyes — that same expression. Lost and scared, caught in the spotlight, staring at the audience." She turned towards Catra. "Then, your eyes closed, and you began to sing."

She raised a hand to cup Catra's cheek, the pop star frozen in front of her. "I knew then that the universe was giving me another chance. That I was meant to lead you into this industry, to mold you into my image. I signed you on the spot. But while you lacked confidence, you were not *meek*. You were strong-willed, with ideas of your own. As we made your first album, I realized mentoring you would not be enough. You had talent, but your temperament needed...adjustment." Ms. Weaver leaned in closer to Catra, and she traced a finger across the singer's cheek. "I needed to push you in the right direction. But you rebelled against my attempts to control your behavior. You escaped your bodyguards at every opportunity. And you refused to behave in the manner of a proper pop star. I needed another tool." She turned her head towards Adora, and the bodyguard felt a sinking feeling in her stomach.

"I thought, perhaps, the directions would be easier taken if they came from a different face. One closer to your own age. And it worked, for a while. But I could feel my influence waning. Your insubordination at Princess Fest proved that. I searched for other ways. I tried to instill fear in you. To restrict your freedoms. To limit your options, so the only path left for you to take was the one I chose for you."

"It was you," gasped Catra. "You're the stalker." Ms. Weaver nodded.

"You wrote that letter? But..." Adora's head shot up in realization. "That's why you didn't want to go to the police!" Ms. Weaver nodded again.

"All those pictures of me..." Catra shivered. "And that note? You're sick."

Ms. Weaver chuckled. "Sick? You're an artist, too. You must understand the need to express yourself, to share your ideas with the world." She grabbed Catra by the shoulders suddenly. "You robbed me of the chance to do so on my own. I'm merely taking what's rightfully mine." Adora stepped forward to come between them, but Ms. Weaver released Catra as quickly as she had grabbed her. "But I knew you wouldn't see it that way. To be quite honest, I was at a loss. Even restricted to this building, trapped in a deadline, you refused to give in. That's when I realized...the solution had been in front of me all along."

She turned to Adora, raising a hand to her face the same way she had to Catra's. Adora willed her feet to move, but they remained frozen to the ground. "Adora. Sweet, innocent, dutiful Adora. I could tell the two of you had...bonded...but it only occurred to me after the Etheria Awards how deep that bond was. How much Catra cared for you." Her head swiveled towards the singer in question. "Tell me, Catra. How much do you value your precious bodyguard? Is she worth your music? Your record deal? Your independence?"

Catra shook her head, eyes watery. "Don't do this," she pleaded. "Please. I...she's my best friend."

"And I would hate to separate the two of you." Ms. Weaver's voice had turned sickly sweet. "But I need my album made. I've waited a lifetime for this chance. It's been distorted, delayed, diluted. I am *not* waiting any longer. So you have a choice, my dear. You may keep your beloved Adora as your bodyguard. You will have more freedom, more luxuries and outings. All I ask is that you complete and record the album that we have rehearsed, and that you be a little more...cooperative with my feedback. Or...you can

say goodbye to your 'best friend,' and we'll find a new bodyguard who's more amenable to my goals."

"No." Catra shook her head again, tears running down her cheeks. "Please, Ms. Weaver. I — I —"

"You can't do this to her." Adora stepped forward, a visceral anger rising within her. How could Ms. Weaver torture Catra like this? All of her words about caring about Catra's happiness and wellbeing had been lies. She just needed a vessel for her ambitions.

Ms. Weaver raised a hand to Adora's lips. "Quiet, my dear. She's got a big decision to make."

Adora wrenched Ms. Weaver's hand from her mouth. "No, she doesn't. I won't let you do this. I won't let you use me as a pawn to control her." Adora's heart beat faster. None of this was fair. Catra didn't deserve to be manipulated like this. She brought joy to so many people with her music. Adora thought back to the screaming fans at Princess Fest, the volumes of fanmail that came every day, the little girl at the mall who saw through Catra's disguise. All the pop star wanted to do was share her music with the world. And Adora was sick of being used as an obstacle to that.

"I won't let you do this," she repeated. "I quit."

Both Catra and Ms. Weaver turned to her in shock. "Adora, don't —" started Catra.

"I have to. She's just going to use me to control you more, don't you see? You said it back at Princess Fest. I'm just another tool for her to manipulate you with."

Catra grabbed her hand. "I was wrong, Adora! You're so much more than that. You mean so much more to me. Don't do this!"

"I have to." Adora squeezed Catra's hand tightly. "I'm sorry, Catra. But I can't just sit back and watch her take over your future like this! You'll never be free if I'm around."

"Don't say that!" Catra looked up at her, eyes frantic and full of tears. "We'll look out for each other. We'll figure something out!"

Adora shook her head, her resolve growing even as she felt her own eyes water in response. "This is *wrong*, Catra. She'll keep lying to you, controlling you, and using me to do it. I won't be part of it. I can't."

"Please, I —" Catra sniffled. "I don't think I can lose you." She wrapped her arms around Adora, and the bodyguard's heart wrenched.

"This isn't what I want either," Adora said, glaring at Ms. Weaver as she returned the hug. "But I don't see another way out. This is what's best for you."

Catra pulled back suddenly. "What's best for me?" She wiped the tears off her face, eyebrows rising in anger. "What's *best* for me?" She glared at Adora. "Thank goodness I'm surrounded by people who know what's best for me. I don't know what I would do if I had to make a single decision about my own life that mattered." She turned away from them, stalking towards her loft. "Go, then, for all I care! You think you're protecting me, but you're the exact same as her!"

"Catra, wait —" "Catra, get back here —" Adora and Ms. Weaver spoke simultaneously. The singer whirled around.

"No, I'm done listening to you. Both of you! I'm not singing your stupid album, and I'm not going to beg you to stay with me." Catra let out a half-crazed laugh. "God, I can't believe I was about to...well, whatever. I don't want to see either of you ever again. Now GET OUT!" She stomped away, ignoring Adora's protests, and didn't look back.

...

The ensuing elevator ride with Ms. Weaver was one of the more awkward experiences of Adora's life. The two stood on opposite ends and stared at the wall. When the door opened for Ms.

Weaver's floor, however, the manager pulled Adora out with her. She led Adora to her office wordlessly.

"Your Hordak ID and phone." Ms. Weaver held a hand out across her desk. Adora pulled the phone out of her pocket and yanked her lanyard off. Ms. Weaver examined them for a long moment before putting them away.

"Understand this, my child," she said suddenly, just as Adora started to turn around to leave. "You may have just cost me the fulfillment of a lifelong dream. I will not forget this. And I will not forgive it." Her eyes gleamed underneath her mask. "You are not welcome at Hordak Records any longer. You will be barred from the premises should you try to come back. And I will be filing an official complaint at Brightmoon Security for insubordination and unprofessional conduct."

Adora glared back at her. Before today, she would never have dreamed of raising her voice at an authority figure. Now, it came so easily. "You see what you're doing, don't you? How much you're hurting her? How can you be okay with this?"

"My relationship with Catra is none of your concern anymore." Ms. Weaver's hands gripped the edge of the desk. "If you truly care for her, then stay away. You'll only bring her more pain."

"You won't get away with this." Adora's eyes prickled with tears. "I'll tell people what you're doing to her."

Ms. Weaver's voice was ice cold. "If you reveal the slightest detail of your time at Hordak, you and Brightmoon Security will be buried with lawsuits for breaking the NDA in your contract. Even if you don't immediately go bankrupt from the legal fees, I doubt that any prospective employers would take kindly to a bodyguard that can't keep a secret." She sat down gingerly behind her desk. "Face it. Your rash behavior has ruined my life's work and broken poor Catra's heart. And for what? So you can feel morally just because you yourself won't be used to manipulate her?" She steepled her fingers. "I hope you think it was worth it."

"You..." The prickles were threatening to become actual tears, but Adora held them back as best she could. She wouldn't give Ms. Weaver the satisfaction. "This is not over. I don't know how, but I'll find a way to make things right."

"You've done enough." Ms. Weaver gestured towards the door. "Farewell, Adora. I do hope you're proud of yourself."

...

Thankfully, the security guard didn't comment on the tears streaming from Adora's face as she walked out of Hordak. She wasn't sure how everything had gone so wrong so quickly. This time last night, she had been drifting off to sleep next to Catra. Just a few hours ago, they had been texting back and forth. Catra was going to debut her new song to her.

When she exited the double doors, she looked upwards, hoping to somehow get a glimpse of Catra's penthouse apartment. But even as she got further away and the angle became less severe, it was too high for her to see.

Chapter End Notes

> Whew! I know it's been a really long time since the last update, so thank you everyone for your patience and your continued interest in this story. I *am* going to finish this fic, even if it takes me another year to get the final chapter out (hopefully it will not take a year).
>
> That said, I have a few other announcements. First, the official Chasing the Spotlight playlist is here: https://open.spotify.com/playlist/2Hp9cQLk1Oh7PLvtVSOTzY?si=A7J2M2SfTMySceJFbBF_FQ. This consists of both songs/artists that are featured in the story, as well as ones that inspired it or match the energy of it. Something to listen to while waiting for the next chapter :) big shoutout to Micah @bow-woahh for hosting the playlist! Check out their She-Ra fics if you haven't already; if you're into AUs (which I'm

assuming you are if you've read this far), I highly recommend Bloom, but all their stuff is great.

Another huge shoutout goes to NovacatMRB, who messaged me after the last chapter came out and correctly predicted basically everything that happened in this one! They helped me figure out some of the twists and turns of this story, as well as other general improvements/edits. Thank you for everything!

Finally, thank you to you, reader. This is by far the longest piece of writing I've ever done, and I won't lie, I've really struggled at times to fit everything together and find the will/time to write. When I started this back in early 2019, it was just a silly idea in my head. Everyone who has read, left kudos, or commented on this fic has provided the fuel for it to become more. <3

Safe

Chapter Notes

Hey uhhh I know it's been a while but...I finished it!

Big thank you to NovacatMRB for their help with this chapter and the whole story in general! And another big thank you to Fuhadeza who was immensely helpful with this chapter -- they have a lot of amazing She-Ra fic, I highly recommend A Two Body Problem, Solved (another modern AU where Catra is a creative!).

The official Chasing the Spotlight playlist is here!

That's all! I hope you enjoy the story! :)

The next few weeks were the loneliest of Adora's life.

When she reported back to Brightmoon, Angella summoned her to her office to recount the events from her perspective, having already received an official feedback form from Ms. Weaver. As Adora went through her experience at Hordak, her boss was understanding, but firm. "Believe me, I know that this job is more than just physically protecting someone. And I put little stock in Ms. Weaver's claims of 'flagrant insubordination and disrespect.' You are a capable bodyguard, Adora. But even by your own account, you got too involved. You can't let your client's problems become your own."

She was right. Adora knew she was right. Brightmoon's whole reputation was built on quiet competence and professionalism. But when she thought about how Ms. Weaver treated Catra, it didn't seem so black and white. "Isn't there anything we can do?"

Angella's lips tightened. "We are not going to intervene further. Our contract with Hordak has been officially terminated. Your duties to Catra are over."

"But–"

"Enough." Angella studied her for a moment, her expression softening. "I know it's not in your nature to turn away when you see someone who needs your help. That's part of what makes you a good bodyguard. But an equally important part of the job is knowing the limits of your responsibilities. We're not law enforcement, and we're certainly not heroes. Understood?"

"I understand." Adora hung her head.

Angella put a hand on her shoulder. "For what it's worth, it sounds like you helped Catra a great deal while you were there. If Ms. Weaver was using you as a bargaining chip, removing yourself from the table is bound to give her more freedom. But it's up to her now. Your part in this is over."

That all made sense to Adora. But as the days went by, she couldn't help but feel like she'd let Catra down. The singer had few people she could trust and rely on. Ms. Weaver was using her as a pawn to fulfill her own ambitions. Hordak Records just wanted a successful, profitable pop star. And even Entrapta and Scorpia, who as far as Adora could tell, genuinely liked Catra, had limited interaction with her outside of their professional relationships.

Adora's friendship with the pop star had been more than that. Despite all her efforts to remain professional, her feelings for Catra were so much deeper than those of a bodyguard for a client. But to Catra, it must seem like just another instance of someone leaving her. Adora's eyes stung when she thought back to the night of the confrontation, to how hurt Catra looked as she stormed off. *"I don't think I can lose you,"* she had said. And then she had.

Even if she would never see Catra again, Adora had to try to let her know how she felt. At least Catra would know that someone saw her and cared about her for who she was.

But how to get a message to her? Catra's number had only been saved in her Hordak phone, which Ms. Weaver had confiscated from her when she quit. That was true for all her other contacts at Hordak who may have helped her as well.

Her next idea was to go in person to the Hordak building. She didn't have an ID card anymore, but Scorpia knew her, knew her relationship with Catra. That had to count for something, right? But though the receptionist greeted her warmly, she wouldn't allow Adora through to the elevator.

"I'm sorry, Adora, I really am. But Ms. Weaver left strict instructions that you are not allowed in the building anymore." Scorpia winced apologetically. "I actually called security as soon as you stepped in. They'll be coming any minute. Sorry!" Scorpia continued to shout apologies as guards stoically escorted Adora out of the building. The next time she showed up, they blocked her from even entering.

…

"Ugh! There has to be some way to get through to her!"

Glimmer patted her back lightly. "I'm sorry, Adora. I know this is hard."

Adora sighed, putting down the binoculars she'd been staring through for the last ten minutes. They were parked across the street from Hordak, with Adora hunched down in the backseat to avoid any possibility of being seen. "It's just so frustrating. I know exactly where she is. I've been in this building so many times. It's just an ID scan and an elevator ride away. But I can't get there."

Bow nodded sympathetically. "I know how you feel. When we were trying to get tickets to see Kacey Musgraves at Princess Fest, we knew exactly what to do and where to go. We had the website link, and we knew we had to act fast. But we were trapped in class and they didn't allow laptops."

"We should have skipped," muttered Glimmer. "But someone wanted to be a goody two shoes."

Bow whirled around. "The test that day was for a *third* of our grade, Glimmer. Forgive me for wanting to actually pass that class."

"I didn't say that *you* had to skip! I was perfectly willing to risk my grade for a chance to see her!"

"We both know that Angella wouldn't have let you go to the concert if you failed! And if she knew I was involved, she'd probably stop letting me come over, too!"

This was not a new argument.

"Guys, shhhh!" Adora held the binoculars back up to her eyes. "Yesterday, they switched the security guards right around now. If this is a consistent schedule, this might be my best chance to sneak in."

Her friends glanced at each other, agreeing to a wordless truce, at least for now. "Are they switching?" ventured Glimmer after fifteen seconds of silence.

"Not yet. But they should be leaving the building right about...now!" Adora pumped her fist. "Two new guards entering the building, two leaving. I'm sure they've all been briefed to stop me from entering. But if I'm in a disguise, they won't know to stop me immediately. I'll enter during the switch, so they're not actively monitoring everyone who comes in. All I have to do is yank someone's ID and run into the elevator. As long as I close the doors before they stop me, I'll be good."

Bow and Glimmer glanced at each other again. "About that…" said Bow hesitantly. "I'm all for you getting a big dramatic reunion with Catra. Like, I can't stress enough how fully in favor of that I am. But it sounds like you might be in serious trouble if you do this. Like, actually-might-get-arrested trouble."

Glimmer nodded. "And Mom is *not* going to like this at all. Especially after she explicitly told you to let this go. Believe me, she gets real strict real fast."

Adora sighed. "You're right." Even to her, this idea sounded half-baked. She didn't want to disappoint her boss or damage Brightmoon's professional reputation. But there had to be some way for her to get to Catra. She wasn't going to give up.

…

One long, lonesome night at Brightmoon had been enough for Adora. With Perfuma away on assignment, her room felt empty; she'd gotten so used to sharing her space with Catra. The next morning, she packed up a suitcase of her clothes and moved into Bow and Glimmer's extra room.

She'd thought about asking for a new assignment. Even a small job would give her something to do, some distraction from her former client. But Angella encouraged her to take time off.

"You've been on the job 24/7 since you started bodyguarding Catra. Some time to relax and clear your head will do you good. You have a long career ahead of you, Adora. There's no need to push yourself so hard."

With no work to occupy herself, Adora found herself staking out Hordak more often than not, trying to find some opening where she could sneak in. Glimmer was right; Angella would be beyond disappointed if Adora made a scene trying to enter. But surely an opportunity would come where the security would be occupied with something else, or a guard would show up late, or *something* would happen that would give Adora a chance.

"Even just a minute or two to talk with Scorpia," Adora mused out loud. "I'm sure she'd understand if I could just talk to her."

"What was that?" asked Glimmer, fiddling with the radio knob. "Sorry, I'm just trying to find some decent music. Do you think it's

more likely they play Kacey Musgraves on the pop station or the country one?"

Bow leaned back in the passenger seat to look at Adora. "What sort of opening are you looking for? It's been pretty quiet the past couple weeks; seems like there's not much foot traffic going in and out. And, uh, pop, I guess. I mean, it could go either way."

"You're right." Adora sighed, putting down her binoculars. "I just don't know what else to do at this point. And what if an opportunity does come and I'm not here to take advantage of it?" She stretched out, yawning widely. "You guys know you don't have to be here, right? I mean, I really appreciate that you are. But I'm sure you have better things to do."

Bow shook his head. "Nonsense! The Best Friend Squad rides together. We're just as invested as you at this point."

"Bow is right," said Glimmer. "About this, not about the radio stations. Turns out they're both more likely to be playing commercials right now. Ugh!" She slumped, putting her head on the wheel. "Bow, if you borrow the aux cord for one of your projects again, please remember to put it back. This is painful."

"I didn't hear any complaints yesterday when we were playing *Emotion Side B* at twice your record player's original max volume! But point taken." Bow had been experimenting with connecting the record player with a variety of other speakers; while Adora didn't trust herself anywhere near the mess of wires he'd constructed, the sound quality had noticeably improved.

Adora glanced back at Hordak, her gaze traveling up the building. The penthouse apartment couldn't be seen from this angle, but she knew Catra was up there somewhere. Was the pop star looking out at the city, wondering where her old bodyguard was? "I just wish I knew how she was doing. She's in the middle of a huge fight with her manager. I don't know what's going to happen."

“Uh, Adora?”

“And I just left her. Who knows how Ms. Weaver is trying to manipulate her now? And she’s facing that alone.”

“Adora!” Glimmer tugged at her sleeve. “Listen to this!” She gestured at the radio, where a peppy voice was introducing the next song.

“...it’s been a long time coming! We know you’re all just as excited to hear it as we are, so without further ado: “Safe,” the new single from Catra!”

Adora blinked.

Glimmer turned the volume up, and the three of them leaned in closer to the speakers as the song began. It started with simple piano chords, slower than Catra’s usual style. After a few measures, the singer’s voice came in, steady and somber.

Never really one to show what’s on my mind
Always too afraid to hope that you were mine

Adora felt her heartbeat quicken. This wasn’t “Memory of a Melody.” This was one she hadn’t heard before. Was this the song Catra had talked about? The one she wanted to show Adora before everything went haywire?

Never had someone who cared if I was fine
Always been alone so didn’t really mind

The piano stopped, and Catra sang the next line a capella, drawing out the final word in descending notes.

But I feel safe with you-ou-ou

A quick pause, and the piano returned.

Never met a girl so selfless and so kind

Always felt the spark but now I see the shine

"Adora," mouthed Glimmer. Adora shushed her.

Never had someone like you who always tries
Always been afraid but now I think it's time

'Cause I feel safe with you-ou-ou

This time, the piano came back in accompanied by a string ensemble, and the tempo sped up. Catra's voice soared above the instrumentals, filled with energy and emotion.

And I feel safe with you
Bad thoughts replaced with you
Fill every space with you
I feel so safe with you

This love was made for two
This heart was made for you
I feel so safe with you
I feel so safe with you

As the next verse started, Glimmer could keep it in no longer. "Oh my god. Oh my god. Adora, this song is about you!"

Adora flushed. She had never dared hope that Catra returned her feelings, that Catra had the same thoughts that Adora tried so desperately to bury. It felt absurd to think that she might; to think that this song, playing on the radio to the whole city, was about her.

But who else could it be about? Catra always said she wrote about what she knew, and the singer didn't really know many people. It certainly wasn't about Ms. Weaver.

Adora thought back to what Catra had told Wallace Lawless at the Etheria Awards, when the pop star's date had told them that Adora was unwelcome at his afterparty. *"She's kind, and funny,*

and she always makes sure that I'm safe and okay." Adora had replayed that quote in her mind for weeks.

"Holy shit." Adora felt her heart thump in her chest. "I think it is about me." She took long, deep breaths in and out, trying to calm herself down. "Holy shit."

Bow grinned at her. "We told you! Oh, this is awesome."

"She really likes you," Glimmer said delightedly. "I knew it! I knew "Force Captain" was sapphic!" She pumped her fist in celebration. "Oh, this is such a win for the home team!" She and Bow dragged Adora into a somewhat haphazard group hug as the song faded out.

"Wow!" said the upbeat radio host. "Definitely a bit of a departure from her previous style, but that was amazing! So much emotion in that song. I think we're definitely going to be seeing this one at the top of the charts for a while."

"Agreed," said the other host, similarly excited. "It's been a while since we've heard new music from her, and fans are ravenous for more. To celebrate this song's release, she's doing a concert at Arxia Stadium, which for our listeners outside of the city, let me tell you, is *not* a small venue. But tickets sold out in minutes!"

Bow and Glimmer looked at Adora in dismay. "Sold out already?" said Glimmer. "Ugh, this is Kacey Musgraves all over again!"

Bow patted Adora on the back. "Maybe we can try to find a resale ticket?"

Adora nodded, glad to have an objective to focus on. If she kept thinking about this song, she felt like she would combust. She took one last look at Hordak before turning to her friends, brows furrowed in determination. "We're going to that concert. One way or another."

…

“Are you sure this is gonna work?” asked Glimmer. The three of them were in line outside Arxia Stadium, slowly making their way up to the entrance hall.

Bow shook his head. “I mean, it all depends on the security guards, really. If they’re sticklers for detail, we might be in trouble. Honestly, I’m thinking maybe we should try something else.”

“It’s too late now,” said Adora. “And it’s not like we have any better options.”

They hadn’t been able to find any resale tickets, but Glimmer had gone to Arxia Stadium to see Taylor Swift a few years ago, and Bow used his computer skills to edit her tickets from that show to look like tickets for this one. The barcodes were the same, and they weren’t sure what would happen if they were scanned; Bow’s best guess was that they wouldn’t. They were hoping that the security guard would manually examine them and determine that they looked legitimate enough, or that the three of them looked pitiable enough, to let them pass.

“Remember,” said Adora. “If all else fails, we just make a break for it. Split up and try to make it through.”

“If my mom knew we were about to do this, she would be so upset.” Glimmer grinned. “But that’s never stopped me before!” As the person checking tickets gestured for the group in front of them to come up, she put her hand in between Bow and Adora. “Best Friend Squad on three.”

“Here goes nothing,” said Bow. He and Adora mirrored Glimmer’s gesture, and they counted down quickly. “Best Friend Squad!”

…

Sure enough, the tickets did not scan correctly.

The ticket checker, a middle-aged man who unfortunately looked rather stern, held Bow’s phone up to his face. “Where did you buy

these tickets?”

“Online,” said Bow sheepishly. “I’m pretty sure it was the official website.”

The man nodded. “Well, they’re not scanning. Might be a problem with the reader, though it’s been working fine today. Step to the side for a minute and one of my colleagues will help sort you out.” He directed them out of the line before waving the next group forwards.

“What now?” asked Glimmer. They were tantalizingly close; they could see people milling about inside the stadium’s concourse, asking for directions to seats and waiting in line for merch, but they still had to get through this checkpoint. “Do we just make a run for it?”

Adora surveyed their surroundings. There were four staff members checking tickets, and enough security guards that she didn’t like their chances of sneaking in. But she couldn’t see any other way. “It might be our only choice. We probably have a minute or two before someone comes to us. Let’s wait for a big group or something and then go for it.”

Then, Adora heard a loud, brash voice she had hoped never to hear again.

“What do you mean I need a ticket? Don’t you know who I am? It’s bad enough I had to wait in line with all these plebeians. Let me through!”

Wallace Lawless, accompanied by a cadre of stern-faced men in suits and sunglasses, stood on the opposite side of the room from them. Adora couldn’t make out what the staff were saying to him, but it was clear he didn’t like it.

“This is outrageous! Bring me your supervisor at once! Actually, make that your supervisor’s supervisor. This is clearly lightyears above your paygrade.” Wallace raised his arms magnanimously. “Look, if you want a selfie or an autograph or something, we can

do that. But you can't just not let me into the concert. I'm *Wallace Lawless*."

"Is that really him?" Glimmer asked, peering over. She wasn't the only one to take note. A crowd quickly formed around him.

Bow frowned. "He seems kind of rude."

"Oh, you have no idea," said Adora, rolling her eyes. "But this is probably our best chance. Heads down, just walk normally." Adora paused, making one final scan of their surroundings. There was definitely a commotion around Wallace, but the other staff hadn't left their posts yet. "Actually, let's get our phones out. Maybe if we pretend to be fans taking pictures, we can work our way in."

Glimmer nodded. "Good plan! Besides, I want a picture anyway. He may be a dick, but this is still the closest I've been to an actual celebrity."

Under the guise of starstruck fans, they inched their way closer to the entranceway. Wallace continued to protest, but didn't seem to be making any headway with the ticket checker he was talking to. The mass of fans grew around him, and the flow of people entering the stadium slowed. Eventually, some of the staff started to separate the crowd back into lines, and Adora knew they had to move quickly.

"Follow my lead," she said, with a quick glance at Bow and Glimmer. She let the push of the dispersing throng carry them towards the entrance. As the nearest staff member stepped forward to direct people, she ducked behind him and walked through. She kept her head down and didn't look back, trusting that Bow and Glimmer were right behind her.

"Hey!" came a voice. She kept moving. Another ten steps and they would clear the entrance hall. But there were two guards at the end of the hall, so they couldn't run yet.

"Hey, stop!" The staff member who had originally scanned their tickets jogged over. "I thought I told you guys to wait over there."

“Yes!” Adora said, a little too enthusiastically. “But, uh, someone was able to scan our tickets, so we went through! Must have been the reader.”

He folded his arms. “Really? Because I didn’t get a chance to send anyone over to you yet. You wouldn’t be trying to sneak in, would you?”

“No!” said Glimmer. She sounded very offended. “Of course not. We just went in the other line and they were able to scan us.”

“Uh huh.” He narrowed his eyes. “And who was it that scanned you in?”

The three of them glanced at each other. “Uh…her?” ventured Bow, pointing to a short woman with long hair.

“That’s funny. Because Gloria is handing out wristbands today, not scanning tickets.” He gestured to the guards. “Escort these folks out, please. They do not have valid entry.”

Adora made eye contact with Bow and Glimmer again, and nodded once. It was time for plan B. “Run.”

They burst off in different directions. Glimmer ran to the right, Bow ran to the left, and Adora dove between the two security guards and rolled, using her momentum to propel herself past them and into the concourse.

“Stop them!” yelled the ticket checker. The chase was on.

Adora quickly lost sight of Bow and Glimmer as she sprinted through the concourse. It wasn’t super crowded, which meant she could move easily, but also made it easy for the guards to track her. She spared a moment to glance behind her. The two guards from the end of the entrance hall were about ten paces behind her, one speaking rapidly into their walkie talkie.

She saw two security guards about 100 feet in front of her turn around in response, and after a brief scan of the area, they

settled their eyes on her. Crap. She didn't want to leave the wider walkway that surrounded the stadium, but it seemed like she didn't have a choice. Adora ran for the nearest pathway out to the seats, squeezing by a young couple walking down it. But as she reached the end of the path, she saw another guard running up the stairs to meet her.

"Crap," breathed Adora. This was not what they planned. She darted to the side and began to leap up the stairs two at a time. If she could just get some distance…a quick glance behind her told her she was, but not enough. She surveyed the area around her, looking for a way back inside. There! Just a few feet from the top of the stairs lay another passage back to the concourse.

She powered up the remaining steps and took a hard left at the top, only to trip over something nondescript. She hit the ground and tumbled over, the wind knocked out of her.

She looked up blearily to see a hulking but vaguely familiar figure looming over her.

She squinted. "Rogelio?"

He raised an eyebrow at her. Then that must mean the obstacle she had tripped over was…

"Owww," groaned Kyle from beside her on the ground.

"Sorry, Kyle," said Adora, out of breath. She tried to push herself upright, but only managed to lean against the back of a seat. "I didn't see you there."

"No one ever does." He shook his head sadly as Rogelio gave him a hand up. "What are you doing here?" Security guards began to close in around them. "Oh no. Don't tell me…you're not the person who tried to break in, are you?" As Adora struggled to her feet, still winded, she noticed a walkie talkie on Kyle's waist.

"No?" offered Adora, giving her best innocent smile, hoping it covered the anxiety bubbling beneath it. She had to find a way

out of this.

One of the guards clapped Rogelio on the back. “Good work.” Rogelio pointed to Kyle in response, who flushed.

“We’ll, uh, take it from here,” he said, showing his Hordak lanyard to the security team. “A few of you should stick with us, though. This girl is highly trained and belongs to one of the most prestigious bodyguarding agencies in the country.”

Adora scowled. “You’ve done your research, huh?” She gave one last desperate look around for an angle, but she was surrounded, and it would take her a few more minutes to recover enough to run again. She was caught. She felt a surge of hopelessness. Was this really how it would end?

Kyle chuckled. “We’ve been filling in here and there for Catra’s new bodyguard. You’re a frequent topic of discussion.”

“She talks about me?” Adora asked. Kyle gave her a knowing look, and she could’ve sworn she saw Rogelio smirk. “Wait – she has a new bodyguard?”

“Yeah! Guy named Hector. He’s very professional! Doesn’t get bothered by her antics at all. Sounds like his last client was a real nightmare.”

Adora felt a pang in her chest as she thought of someone else protecting Catra, laughing with her, spending all day with her in the penthouse. “How is Catra? Is she okay?”

Kyle and Rogelio exchanged glances. Rogelio shrugged. “It’s been, ah, up and down,” said Kyle. “It’s kind of hard to tell with her. I know she’s happy about performing again, at least.” Adora nodded, thinking back to Catra’s excitement about being onstage at Princess Fest. “But things have definitely been pretty tense between her and Ms. Weaver.”

A chill went down Adora’s spine at the thought of Catra’s manager. “Wait, you’re not taking me to Ms. Weaver, are you? Please, I

have to see Catra. Ms. Weaver can't know I'm here."

Kyle and Rogelio exchanged another glance. "We don't make those kinds of decisions. You'll have to take it up with the boss. Which, speaking of…" they stopped in front of an unmarked door. "Lonnie's set up in here today."

Adora hung her head. "Are you sure you don't want to just let me go to the concert? I won't tell anyone, I promise."

Kyle smiled ruefully. "I think I would lose my job if I brought you here just to let you go. But between you and me–" he leaned in conspiratorially. "I'm rooting for you, and I hope you patch things up with Catra." Rogelio nodded in agreement and gave her a thumbs up.

"Thanks," Adora muttered. It was hard to feel grateful; she knew they were just doing their jobs, but she had been *so close* to making it into the stadium and vanishing into the crowd. So close to making it to Catra.

She opened up the door and stepped inside. The office was small, and had clearly been out of use for some time; stacks of folding chairs and boxes of different sizes lined the walls. The chief of Hordak's security sat behind a dusty desk, her feet propped up on top of it.

"Well, well, well." Lonnie raised her eyebrows at Adora. "I have to say, I didn't expect to see you again. Let alone here."

"I'm surprised to see you here, too. Why is Hordak running security at this event? I would think a venue as big as Arxia would be more than equipped to handle it."

Lonnie gave her an amused glance. "Take a guess."

Oh. Duh. "Ms. Weaver doesn't trust outside security?"

"And the grand prize goes to the bodyguard crashing her former client's concert." Lonnie gave her a mock round of applause.

“What are you doing here, anyway? Didn’t the two of you have a falling-out?”

Adora flushed. “It wasn’t really – well, I guess it was – everyone knows about that, huh?”

“I mean, she didn’t talk to anyone for a solid week after you quit. It was hard not to notice.” Lonnie studied Adora for a second. “Now, is there a reason you decided to break in instead of buying tickets? I know they were expensive, but damn.”

“They were sold out!” Adora protested. “And I need to see her. Listen, Lonnie. Ms. Weaver is manipulating Catra. The reason I quit is because she was using me to control her. And I don’t know what she’ll do now that I’m not there. She’ll find some other angle.” Adora slammed her hands on the desk. “She was the stalker, Lonnie! She wrote that letter and took those pictures, then lied about it, all just to control Catra! She’s not a good person, and Catra isn’t safe with her.”

Lonnie leaned back in her chair. “Those are some serious allegations. Do you have any proof?”

Adora shook her head. “No, but she told Catra and I that to our faces. It’s all to control Catra and get her to do what she wants. She used to be a singer, too, and she’s using Catra to live the life she couldn’t.”

The security chief folded her arms. “Give me a second.” She thought for a moment, then sighed. “I wish I didn’t believe you, because things are about to get a lot more complicated for me. But that woman has given me the creeps since day one. And she has more control issues than anyone I’ve ever met. She gave us a very firm directive to keep you out of Hordak and away from Catra, which I thought was odd – I mean, it’s pretty obvious you wouldn’t do anything to hurt her. Makes sense that she has something to hide.”

She stood up and rummaged through a box on her desk. "Having said that, she's still my boss, and I'm not going to do anything to jeopardize my job." She tossed Adora an orange wristband. "So you didn't get this from me. But that will get you onto the stadium floor."

Adora smiled in relief. "Thank you, Lonnie. Seriously, I really appreciate this." She shifted her weight from side to side. "You didn't happen to, uh, catch any other trespassers, did you?"

Lonnie smirked. "Your friends are in the next room over." She fished out two more wristbands. "Your plan was really just to run past security? Aren't you some highly trained tactical operative?"

"I'm a highly trained *bodyguard*," said Adora, indignant. "We don't usually have to do any infiltration." After a moment, they both laughed, but then Lonnie sobered up.

"None of this comes back to me, okay? I'm serious. If anything, say that Kyle tripped over his own shoelaces or something and you made a break for it."

Adora nodded. "You got it." She turned to leave.

"And Adora?" Lonnie grinned at her. "Go get your girl."

…

Newly equipped with their wristbands, Adora led Bow and Glimmer down the stairs towards the stadium floor.

"Thank goodness you were able to convince them to let us go," said Glimmer. "Just running in really wasn't a good plan. I mean, they caught up to me in like ten seconds. Turns out short legs and never doing cardio isn't exactly the recipe for a quick getaway." She kicked one of the seats as they passed it. "I wish I could teleport or something."

Bow nodded glumly. "I didn't make it very far either. I tried to blend in with a group of people buying merch, but they spotted

me somehow." Adora glanced at his heart-adorned crop top, but elected not to say anything.

They had arrived at the concert with time to spare, but their escapades had taken a while. The floor area was packed to the brim, and the lights had already gone down, excited screams coming from all around them as the fans awaited Catra's entrance.

Glimmer checked her phone. "Wow. A concert starting on time? Now I've seen it all!"

"Catra doesn't like to," said Adora, thinking back to Princess Fest. That seemed so long ago now. "She says it's better to build anticipation. But apparently Ms. Weaver is a stickler for that kind of thing."

"She really wants to control everything, huh," said Bow. "Stuff like that seems so innocuous, but when you add it all up, it seems… evil."

"I don't think she's evil." Adora paused, thinking through her next words. "After hearing her story, I understand why she feels so strongly about her music. What happened to her really was tragic. But Catra deserves to tell her own story. She deserves someone who sees her as more than just a means to an end."

"Someone like you?" Glimmer teased. She started to say something else, but Adora didn't catch it, because a spotlight went up on the center of the stage, and there she was.

Catra.

"Whoa," breathed Adora, staring up at the singer's image on the large screens that flanked the stage. She looked different. Her hair was dramatically shorter – almost a pixie cut – and she wore an understated crimson shirt over black leggings.

She looked *amazing*.

“Hello, everyone,” said Catra, barely audible amidst the roars of the crowd. “It’s been a while. How are you feeling?”

Adora couldn’t read her. She knew Catra loved performing, but was she okay? How was the situation with Ms. Weaver?

As the singer launched into “Force Captain,” Adora realized with dismay the sheer mass of humanity that stood between her and the stage. She didn’t have a plan beyond getting to the front, but even that would be difficult. They presented their wristbands and stepped onto the stadium floor.

She turned to Bow and Glimmer. “Ready?” They nodded. Adora linked hands with Bow, who linked hands with Glimmer, and they stepped into the mob of fans. They made a good team; Adora put her shoulder down and forced her way forward, while Bow kept up a steady stream of apologies and Glimmer stared down anyone who protested.

Even so, it was slow going. Adora wished she could appreciate the performance more; her field of vision had far too many sweaty backs and far too little Catra. The closer they got, the more dense the crowd was, and it became harder and harder to push through. Adora felt a tinge of guilt. All the people they were squeezing in front of had actually paid for their tickets, and some had probably waited in line for hours to get this close to the barricade. But her mission was paramount.

Catra’s concert continued as they wormed their way forwards. She followed “Force Captain” with two of her other hits, “Fright Zone” and “Crimson Wasteland.” To Adora’s surprise, she didn’t talk much between songs, only offering a few lines of banter or introduction before starting the next one. Usually, or at least at Princess Fest, she was far more talkative.

After what seemed like an eternity, they finally worked their way up to the front, a mass of irritated concert-goers in their wake. Adora apologetically but firmly wedged her shoulder into a narrow gap between two fans pressed up against the barricade, and

slowly moved the rest of her body into the space as the crowd jumbled back and forth around her. Bow and Glimmer were content to stand behind her.

Finally, she had a clear view of Catra; they were probably less than twenty-five feet apart. She took a moment just to admire the singer. Catra made her choreography look effortless, dancing across the stage gracefully, never missing a step. Adora didn't think she'd ever get tired of watching her.

She quickly realized, though, that she had a problem.

She had a great view of Catra. But it would be almost impossible for Catra to spot her in the audience, even in the front row. Adora remembered being on the stage at Princess Fest; the stage lights were so bright, and the audience so dark by comparison, that making out individual faces was out of the question. And how would Catra know to look, anyway? Adora tried shouting a few times, but between the music and the general noise from the crowd, she could barely hear herself. And she was far from the only person trying to get Catra's attention; almost everyone in the front row had their phones or their hands outstretched, screaming their love for the pop star.

She'd have to pick her moment, and give it all she had.

Finally, a song ended and Catra didn't immediately begin another one.

"Whew!" she said into the microphone. "I don't know about you all, but I need a second to catch my breath. How's everyone doing?"

The crowd roared. Catra laughed.

"Thank you all for coming out tonight. I truly love performing these songs for you."

Adora, despite her intention to save her voice, found herself cheering along with everyone else.

“This next song is about someone very special to me. Someone who always went out of her way to look out for me, who was kind to me even when I wasn’t always kind to her. Someone who made me really happy, because she made me feel safe.”

Bow and Glimmer pounded Adora’s back as the crowd cheered again. Adora felt a pool of nervousness in her stomach. Now might be her best shot. She felt a moment of doubt; what if the song wasn’t really about her? Was she about to make a fool of herself in front of everyone?

“I never got to tell this person how much she means to me,” continued Catra. “But I hope that one day, she hears this song and understands.”

Doubts be damned. Catra deserved to know how she felt. She took a deep breath, and with all the volume she could muster, yelled “I’m here, Catra!” But the din of the crowd was thunderous; she barely made a dent.

Catra’s ears twitched. “Adora?” she asked, an open question to the thousands before her. Adora waved her hands as conspicuously as possible as the singer scanned the audience.

Their eyes met, and Catra’s face lit up. “Adora! Oh, I knew you’d come.”

She bounded over towards her former bodyguard, sliding off the stage in one graceful movement. For a moment, they just stared at each other; then, Catra ran forward and threw her arms around Adora.

It was a fairly uncomfortable hug. Catra was barely taller than the barricade, and the metal pressed painfully into Adora’s chest as she returned the embrace, her arms at an awkwardly high angle. It was the best hug of her life.

Finally, Catra released her, the smile still on her face. She gestured to the two closest security guards. “Let her through. She’s coming up on stage with me.” Before Adora could process what was

happening, they opened a narrow gap in the barricade and pulled her through.

Catra hugged her again, this one a lot more comfortable.

“Hey,” said Adora.

“Hey.” Catra’s breath was hot on her ear, and Adora suppressed a shiver.

“I like the new look,” said Adora as Catra stepped back. The singer blushed.

“I kind of chopped it all off a few days after you left. I guess I just needed to be in control of something, you know?” Adora winced, but Catra just laughed. “You should have seen Shadow Weaver when she found out. She always wanted me to keep it long. I mean, it did look pretty awful. My stylists pulled off a miracle getting it to look somewhat passable.”

“It looks amazing.” They hoisted themselves onto the stage, tentative cheers coming from the crowd at Catra’s reappearance alongside an audience member. “How are things with Shadow Weaver? Are you okay?”

“About that.” Catra glanced around her. “I was hoping you’d be here, because–”

“Adora, what are you doing here?”

Ms. Weaver entered the stage from behind the curtain, flanked by two mean-looking men in suits. She looked as foreboding as ever. Her voice was controlled, but her chest rose up and down quickly; Adora guessed she had run to the stage as soon as Adora’s presence was revealed.

“I told you to stay away. You made your decision. So again, what are you doing here?”

Adora stepped in front of Catra protectively. “I’m right where I’m supposed to be. Where I should have been all along. Between you and her.”

Murmurs rippled throughout the crowd, and Adora realized the stage was lined with microphones. This confrontation would be public. She turned to shoot Catra a questioning glance, but the singer gave her a small nod.

“How sweet,” sneered Ms. Weaver. “Lest you have forgotten, you are not her bodyguard anymore. You have no place here.”

Adora folded her arms. “And yet here I am.”

The manager switched her focus to Catra. “Why are you welcoming her, Catra? Adora decided herself that she was done with you. She left, remember? You do not need her.”

The singer narrowed her eyes, then stepped up to her microphone. “I apologize for the delay, everyone. We’ll be getting back to the show in just a few minutes. But first, there’s a serious matter we have to discuss.”

“What are you doing?” hissed Ms. Weaver. “These people paid a lot of money to see you perform. This is *not* what they want to see. Continue your concert.”

Catra ignored her. “This woman is my manager, Selene Weaver. She’s been controlling me for years: telling me what songs to play and when to play them, what to wear, where to go. She’s even started trying to write my music for me. And I have no choice but to do what she says because of a contract I signed when I was a naive seventeen year old.” Catra’s voice was measured and clear; this sounded like a practiced speech. “For the longest time, I thought I had no choice but to obey her. To play by her rules. After all, it’s in the contract, right?”

The crowd was the quietest they had been all night, spellbound by the story. Many had phones or cameras out to record.

Ms. Weaver stepped forward and made a gesture towards the audience that Adora didn't recognize. "If you wish to discuss your contract, we can do so privately." She motioned to the two men behind her, and they began to approach Catra.

Adora raised her hands and assumed a fighting stance. "Not so fast." She sized them up; they were bigger and stronger than her, so her best chance was to strike hard and fast. Maybe a low kick to the knees? But the two of them stopped about five feet away from her, looking at each other then to Ms. Weaver.

The manager made the gesture again; it looked similar to the military hand signal for stop. When nothing happened, she spoke. "Entrapta, cut the mics and lights. This show is over."

Fans began to yell in protest, and Adora saw Ms. Weaver's fists clench at her side.

"Entrapta!" she repeated.

The lights stayed on.

Catra smirked. "Looks like just about everybody wants to hear what I have to say. And unless you want everyone to see your goons try to drag me off stage – good luck getting past Adora, by the way – that's exactly what's going to happen."

Adora saw the men glance at each other again. While she doubted they thought she could take them, they clearly didn't want to start a physical altercation.

"As I was saying," continued Catra, Ms. Weaver frozen in silence, "this woman has pulled the strings behind my entire life for years. And I can't *do* anything about it because of this damn contract. But I was seventeen when I signed it. And the last time I checked, you can't sign a legally binding agreement with a minor."

Adora kept her eyes on Ms. Weaver and her enforcers, but her mind was racing. Had Catra actually found a way out? Everything she was saying made sense.

"So, I knew there was something fishy about this contract. But every time I asked to see it, Ms. Weaver deflected. She would tell me that there was no point; it was all legal jargon, but of course she could explain if I had any questions. Which just confirmed to me that something was up. Finally, thanks to Hordak Records' extremely helpful receptionist, I got my hands on a copy."

The crowd hung on to her every word, and Adora found herself doing the same.

"The contract had everything Ms. Weaver said it had. Stipulations about release dates, rules about talking to the media, financial control…it was airtight. But again, I was seventeen." Catra, ever the performer, paused for dramatic effect. "Then I realized there were two parts to this contract. The contract itself, and a different agreement designating Ms. Weaver as my legal guardian."

Exclamations of surprise came from the audience. Adora glanced at Ms. Weaver; while the masked woman was inscrutable as always, Adora could see how tensely she was holding herself.

"Now, I did some digging on the process of appointing a legal guardian, and it's fairly involved. You need to petition a court, there are interviews, and sometimes even a home visit. But I don't recall any of that happening. I mean, I'm pretty sure the minor in question has to at least be informed of what's going on. But I'm guessing that my dear manager skipped that step, since doing so would reveal that she couldn't actually sign a binding contract with me."

Catra turned to address Ms. Weaver directly for the first time, her eyes bright with fury. "So let's review. You signed me to a contract under false pretenses. The contract's validity is based on you being my legal guardian. And that guardianship is illegitimate." Catra cocked her head to the side. "That doesn't sound like something that will hold up under examination."

"Catra, do not pretend to understand the intricacies of contract law." Ms. Weaver's voice remained even. "I promise you that

whatever scandal you think you have unearthed is nothing. If you would like, we can go over it with a lawyer later."

"No!" Catra's eyebrows furrowed in anger. "We're settling this here and now." She turned back to the crowd. "I don't want to be held by this contract any longer. It's unfair to me, probably illegal, and definitely exploitative. And this woman has shown that there are no limits to the lengths she will go to control me." She glared at Ms. Weaver. "Now, part of me wants to sue you for all the money you're worth – most of which you probably made off of me anyway." She gestured to Adora. "After all, I have a witness right here who can speak to all the ways you've abused your power. But a bigger part of me just wants to be done with this. Done with you."

She produced a slip of paper from her pocket and slowly unfolded it. "This form releases me from all legal agreements with you. Without you as my guardian, the contract with Hordak is void. I will be free to make my music the way I want to." She glanced at Adora. "To live my life that way I want to." She held out the paper and pen to Ms. Weaver. "The only thing I need is your signature."

Ms. Weaver laughed, but it sounded forced to Adora. "Do not be absurd. If you want to dispute your contract, there are protocols for that. Lawyers have to be involved. This is just meaningless theater."

"I'll admit to it being theater," said Catra. "Since we do have quite an audience right now. Thousands of people watching you deny me freedom, recording and uploading it for the world to see. What do you think the headlines will say tomorrow? I don't think they'll be on your side."

"Catra, this is ridiculous." Angry jeers and shouts came from the crowd, eventually coalescing into a single phrase.

"Sign the form! Sign the form!"

Adora saw Bow and Glimmer passionately leading their section in the chant and smiled.

Ms. Weaver stood frozen in place. She wasn't used to not having control of a situation, Adora realized. She likely never anticipated a public confrontation.

"Well?" asked Catra, smirking up at her manager. The chants only grew louder.

Still, Ms. Weaver made no move to take the form. "This is the path you have chosen, then?" Her voice was quiet; Adora could barely hear her, even from a few feet away.

"This is the path you drove me to," retorted Catra.

Ms. Weaver narrowed her eyes. "I drove you to be the best version of yourself you could be." She waved a hand at the audience. "These people do not care about you. They do not even know who you really are. You are nothing but a fleeting amusement to them. *I* saw value in you when no one else did. What will you do when you no longer interest them? When they move on to the next up-and-coming star?"

Catra frowned. "You mean like what happened to you?"

"Don't you see, Catra? I am trying to save you from that fate! These people will *never* care about you. Not the real you. Not the way I do. I know I can be harsh. But all I do, I do to make you better. And without me, you wouldn't be anywhere near where you are today." She reached out to cup Catra's cheek. "You know, deep down, that what I'm saying is true."

For a moment, Catra closed her eyes and leaned into her hand, and Adora's heart plummeted. After everything Ms. Weaver had put her through…she stepped forward to intervene, but before she could, Catra spoke.

"The sad thing is that I want to believe you. I want to believe that everything you did was for my benefit." She opened her eyes,

staring defiantly up at her manager. “But Adora showed me what it really means to care about someone. She was kind to me in ways you never even tried to be.”

Ms. Weaver shook her head. “I prepared you for greatness!”

“But you never truly *cared* about me.” Catra stepped back, removing Ms. Weaver’s hand from her. “You just want a vessel to live vicariously through. You’re bitter, and cruel, and I’m done playing your games.” She held out the paper.

Ms. Weaver scowled. “Insolent girl. You were nothing before I found you, and you will be nothing without me.” Her gaze swept over Adora. “This is all your fault, isn’t it? I hope you feel guilty when it all comes crumbling down.” With that, she snatched the paper from Catra’s hand and signed it in short, quick strokes, dropping it rather than handing it back.

Catra caught it and glared up at her now-former manager. “The only thing Adora is guilty of is showing me that people can actually value me regardless of what I provide for them.” She examined the form, and, evidently finding it to her satisfaction, pocketed it. “Now get off the stage and get out of my life.”

Ms. Weaver glared back. “Do not come running back to me when this all comes crashing down.” She shook her head contemptuously. “To think I saw myself in you. Goodbye, Catra. One day you will understand just how severely you have erred.” With that, she stalked offstage, the two men in suits following close behind.

The crowd roared its approval, and Adora let out a breath she didn’t realize she’d been holding. It was finally over. Catra leaned into her and Adora wrapped her arms around her automatically. “That was incredible,” she murmured, cognizant that the stage mics would pick up her voice if she spoke too loudly. “I can’t believe you knew all that stuff about guardianship and contract law.”

Catra grinned up at her. "I sounded pretty convincing, didn't I? To be honest, I have no idea if that stuff would hold up in court. But I figured the public pressure would probably be enough."

"Wait. You were making that stuff up?"

The singer laughed. "I mean, I did my fair share of Googling. But I just needed enough to make her feel like she had to do it, and to get the crowd on my side. Ms. Weaver hates when people see beyond the image she chooses to present. I think that's why she wears her mask, you know? So I knew this would be outside of her comfort zone. And it *is* pretty bad publicity to have a singer so clearly unhappy. I can understand why she wouldn't let me use social media now; I would've had #freecatra trending months ago." She grabbed Adora's hands. "I'm really glad you showed up, though. I mean, I was kind of counting on it. I think she would have just dragged me offstage otherwise."

"As soon as I heard about the concert, I knew I had to come." They smiled at each other. "It was quite the journey though. I'll have to tell you about it sometime."

Catra batted her eyelashes at her. "Well, what are you doing after this? I have a free schedule for the first time in years."

"Well…" Adora scratched her head sheepishly. "My friends – Bow and Glimmer – are here, too, and there's this diner we like that's not too far from here. They make the *best* pancakes."

"Pancakes, huh?" The singer giggled. "You really do have a one track mind, don't you?"

Adora felt unusually bold. "I might have room for one or two more."

"Oh, really?" Catra's grin was electric. "Stay right there," she commanded. She bounded over to her microphone to address the audience. "Wow. Thank you all for your support, and for sharing this moment with me." They cheered in response. "I can't tell you how good I feel right now. I feel free for the first time in…maybe

for the first time, ever. I've been wanting to do that for such a long time." Again, raucous cheers. "Now, I know you're all ready for more music. It's coming, I promise. But there's something else I've been wanting to do for ages, and I just can't wait any longer." She turned to Adora, a shy smile on her face, and Adora suddenly realized that her life was about to change forever.

Who was she kidding? It already had.

Catra moved to her in slow motion. She raised her hands to Adora's face as if to guide her closer, but Adora was already leaning down to meet her. When they kissed, the cheers were the loudest they had been all night.

Neither of them noticed.

They finally broke apart, gasping for breath.

"Wow," said Adora. She felt a bit lightheaded. "I'm, uh, glad I'm not your bodyguard anymore. Because that is *definitely* not allowed."

Catra giggled. "You're ridiculous."

The singer took her hands again, gazing up at her with affection. The reflection of the stage lights were bright in her eyes, and Adora thought that she could spend her whole life chasing that image.

"Adora," Catra began, slowly but without hesitation. Whatever she was about to ask, Adora already knew the answer was yes.

"Can I sing you a song?"

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